

Phil 330 Thomas Aquinas

Numbered Transcript

PHIL 330 • Bishop Robert Barron

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Lecture 1: Life, Times, and Culture

At a glance — Barron introduces Thomas Aquinas — his life, times, and 13th-century culture — presenting him as intellectual hero and master of scholasticism.

- 1.1 I'm delighted to be with all of you today to talk about Saint Thomas Aquinas, who is a personal hero of mine, my intellectual hero, but also someone I think who needs to be reinserted into the public conversation. Let me say something quick about both those things.
- 1.2 I discovered Aquinas when I was 14 years old. I was a freshman at Fenwick High School, which is outside Chicago, a high school run by the Dominican order, which was Thomas Aquinas's order, many centuries before. We came in from the playground, I remember, all sweating. It was an all-boys school at the time. One of the young Dominican friars was teaching religion, and he laid for us one of Thomas Aquinas's famous arguments for God's existence. Now, I don't know why this is true. I still find it mysterious. But for some reason, that lecture just grabbed me.
- 1.3 Now, I was a Catholic kid going to Mass on Sunday with my parents. I didn't not believe in God, but I'd never really thought about God in a serious way. I never thought you could. I came of age when religious education was pretty poor, actually, in the Catholic Church. But here was something rich and deep and luminous, and it lit a fire in me. It set me on a path that, honest to God, I'm still on. It's brought me right here to this moment as a bishop of the Church, as a teacher of the faith.
- 1.4 I remember I came home and I was so fascinated by this that I took my 10-speed bike and rode out to the local public library, and I found this series of books called The Great Books, and there were two of them on Thomas Aquinas. So I grabbed the one that was about the existence of God. I remember I put it under my T-shirt, I tucked it in and rode my bike home.
- 1.5 I'm 14 years old, and I'm reading this text of Thomas Aquinas. If you read him at all, you know how densely complex and technical the writing is. So I barely knew what I was reading. But at the same time, it was weird. It's almost like I had found this treasure that I knew about. And this book became like a beacon for me. I'd go back to the library, I'd renew it, I'd bring it back to the house. Again, trying to read it but barely understanding it. But it set me on this intellectual and eventually spiritual path that I'm still on. So I'm happy to give these lectures as a tribute to Aquinas and the role that he's played in my own life.
- 1.6 But here's the second thing, though. I think Thomas Aquinas is the greatest religious thinker that the West has produced. If you're going to think about religious matters in a serious way, you've got to come to terms with Thomas Aquinas. And what's bugged me in a big way, go back now 25 years, the rise of the New Atheists. They weren't very new in their arguments. Their arguments were all very old. They were new in their nastiness

toward religion. But time and again, I would say, "Can someone here make reference to Thomas Aquinas? Can someone present the faith in an intellectually serious way?" Because our critics were dismissing us, this old superstition. I think we need to reinsert Aquinas into the conversation.

- 1.7 I'll tell you a quick story. I was doing a radio interview at that time when the New Atheists were all the rage, and it was a Canadian interviewer, and I'm on the phone with him. We're debating back and forth about Hitchens and about God and about the New Atheists. At the end of the interview, he said to me, "Now, Father, would you at least admit that Christopher Hitchens got you, religious people, thinking about these things for the first time?"
- 1.8 I paused to let my annoyance sink in. I said, "Look, I'm the very inadequate representative of the oldest intellectual tradition still extant in the West: the Catholic Church." I said, "Trust me when I tell you we did not need a snarky British journalist to get us thinking about these things for the first time. We've been thinking very seriously about these matters for a long time." And one of the greatest figures in that Catholic intellectual tradition is the subject of these lectures: Saint Thomas Aquinas. So that's why I'm, for personal reasons and more professional reasons, delighted to be able to talk to you about it.
- 1.9 Here's the way I'm going to structure it. Lecture 1 is going to be about Life, Times and Culture, because I think it's the case, even though Thomas has been a major figure for a long time, I think a lot of people today, I'm guessing many who'll be watching these courses, don't know that much about him, don't know that much about the culture that produced him. So, I'm going to spend this first lecture really going into that matter.
- 1.10 And then, we're going to go through the thought of Aquinas. So, beginning with approaches to God. Why does it make sense even to talk about the existence of God? Then I'll look at the attributes of God. What can we know? What can we say coherently about God? I'll then look at the distinctively Christian doctrine of the Trinity, because the way Aquinas appropriates that is very rich and interesting. So God.
- 1.11 Then, we'll move to creation. So God gives rise to a world outside of Himself. Then we'll look at the question of providence and evil. I'll say it now, that's the issue in theology that most preoccupies most people, if they get interested in theology because of that. How do you justify God's providence in the light of evil? We'll look at that issue.
- 1.12 Then, we will look at humanity. What's Thomas's doctrine of the human being? It's very rich that we're made in the image and likeness of God. It's very important for him that we've come from God, we're marked by God, therefore we're ordered back to God.
- 1.13 And then finally, I'll look at ethics. Thomas's ethics is predicated upon what he calls beatitudo: happiness. What is our happiness? What makes us happy? Again, can I suggest to everybody watching? That's the question that unites every single person. I don't care who you are. You're the most ardent believer. You're the most ardent

atheist. Everybody's interested in happiness: beatitudo. What is it? Aquinas is deeply interested in that question. So that's the framework for the eight lectures I'll be giving.

- 1.14** Let's start now with Thomas Aquinas himself: Life, Times, Culture. Let me start with this. Can I disabuse everyone of a notion that was born largely of 19th-century historiography? It goes something like this. In the ancient world, there was this great burst of light in Babylon and Egypt, Greece, Rome, this great flowering of civilization and culture and intelligence. And then, with the fall of Rome, Europe entered the Dark Ages of superstition. The Dark Ages lasted on this reading from the fall of Rome all the way to, let's say, the dawn of the Renaissance in the late 15th and 16th century with the Protestant Reformation and then with the rise of the sciences. So burst of light in the ancient world, long darkness, and then the burst of light that gave rise to what we call the modern world.
- 1.15** May I suggest to you that's so much nonsense, that way of looking at things? First of all, I'll quote G. K. Chesterton, the great Catholic writer. Chesterton said that there was a Dark Age for sure after the fall of Rome. But the only light during the Dark Ages came from the church. It's true, it seems to me. Largely, those Benedictine monasteries that were spread across Europe, that's where agriculture, the science of the time, learning, were preserved. And from a lot of the monasteries came the towns and villages, eventually cities, of Europe.
- 1.16** What kept even this modicum of civilization going during the Dark Ages was precisely the Church. In truth, think of any text from the ancient world that you love, whether it's Sophocles, Euripides, Plato, Cicero. Well, you have some medieval monk to thank for that; probably his hands cracked with the cold whilst copying out these texts during the Dark Ages. So first of all, the Church was the only light during the Dark Ages.
- 1.17** But here's my main point: the Dark Ages did not end with the Renaissance of the late 15th, 16th century. There was a renaissance every bit as important that came many centuries before. It happened now, in the end of the 12th, and then it blossomed in the 13th century. What am I talking about? I'm talking about the civilization that gave rise to, think of all those Gothic cathedrals that dot the landscape in Europe. They began building in the late 12th. Think of Notre Dame in Paris, 1163, that commences. The Cathedral Chartres begins in the 1180s. But then throughout the 13th century, all over Europe, these great cathedrals arise.
- 1.18** Think of the poetry of Dante. T. S. Eliot himself said, "Western literature is divided between two figures, Shakespeare and Dante, and there is no third." So one of the greatest, not just Christian poets, one of the greatest poets, period, emerges precisely during this 13th century renaissance.
- 1.19** And now think, too, of the university system. It is true what John Paul II said. He said universities emerged ex corde Ecclesiae, "from the heart of the Church," no question about it. Where did the first universities emerge? They emerged out of the cathedral

schools that were associated with the cathedral churches in Europe. The ones that became big enough developed into universities. So think now of Bologna, think of Paris, especially. Think of Oxford, think of Cambridge, think of Prague, all over Europe. The universities emerged from the heart of the Church.

- 1.20 Think, too, of someone like Francis of Assisi, this great religious genius, born in the late 12th, dies early 13th century. Well, listen now. Any culture that produces Francis of Assisi, the university system, Dante, and the Gothic cathedrals, you can call that anything you want, but the one thing you can't call it is dark. That was a civilization of extraordinary luminosity.
- 1.21 Our subject now for these lectures, Saint Thomas Aquinas, is the greatest of the scholastic thinkers that emerged from this early university system in medieval Europe. He's the one who sums up in his person the best of that culture. That's why he remains a pivotal player for the development of Western culture.
- 1.22 Think of this, too, everybody. The sciences eventually emerged a few centuries later—as we know them, the modern physical sciences—precisely out of these Christian universities. It's not as though the sciences emerged in some great twilight struggle against religion. They come up out of these universities that were formed *ex corde Ecclesiae*, in the High Middle Ages. Aquinas is the greatest of these figures in the 13th century. So first, I think we need that broader perspective.
- 1.23 Now, a little bit about him and about his life and times. Thomas Aquinas is born, they're not exactly sure, either in 1224 or 1225. To give you a little frame of reference, Saint Francis of Assisi dies in 1226. So he dies the year after Thomas is born. That's the period we're talking about. He's born of a family of minor nobility. So he's from a little town called Aquino, hence his name in Latin, Thomas Aquinatis, Thomas from Aquino. That gets anglicized as Thomas Aquinas.
- 1.24 But Thomas Aquinatis is born in a little town of Aquino, in the castle of Roccasecca, which was a family castle. I've been there a couple of times, and it's a gorgeous spot. It's between Rome and Naples. So Aquino is about midway between Rome and Naples. Roccasecca is up on top of a great mountain, and it gives you this commanding view of the Italian countryside. Beautiful spot. You can take your car to a certain point, then you've got to walk the rest of the way up to the castle. That's where Thomas is born.
- 1.25 I say his family is minor nobility. At that time, the great political struggle was between the Holy Roman Emperor and the papacy. You find that these families caught in this ongoing struggle. A couple of generations after Aquinas, Dante is involved in the very same struggle. He ends up on the wrong side of it and gets exiled from Florence. But Thomas' family, too, is caught up in this battle between the Holy Roman Emperor and the papacy.
- 1.26 As a young kid—Thomas is not the eldest son; the eldest son would inherit the land and the fortune—but then sons down the line were often given to the Church. Interesting

thing, actually, because think of the eldest son. It was just a luck of the birth order that he receives the inheritance. But the sons who were sent to the Church could often rise through their own merits. The Church was much more a meritocracy than the secular society. Think of someone a few centuries later, like Cardinal Wolsey, who served Henry VIII and became the second-highest figure in the land. He was the son of a butcher. That could happen in the Church. It was more of a meritocracy than a secular society.

- 1.27** So Thomas, not the eldest son, is sent to the Benedictine monastery of Monte Cassino. You still go there. That's also not far from Aquino, between Rome and Naples. It's been destroyed and rebuilt many times. Most recently, it was bombed during the Second World War, totally destroyed, and then rebuilt afterwards. If you can visit that today, also up on top of a great mountain. It was a monastery founded by Saint Benedict himself. So go back to the sixth century. Saint Benedict, the founder of the Benedictine order, established this monastery, and it's still the mother house of the Benedictine world.
- 1.28** Well, young Aquinas, seven or eight years old, probably, is sent there. The plan undoubtedly was that he would be educated there. He'd become a Benedictine monk, and then his family hoped, in time, the abbot of the monastery. That would have been a very high position. Monte Cassino was a very important abbey. To be the abbot, the head of it, was to be in a very high place in medieval society. That's undoubtedly what Thomas's parents wanted.
- 1.29** But they sent him there as a young guy, and he spends nine years at Monte Cassino, which I think is very interesting and often overlooked in treatments of Aquinas. What would he have taken in now as a young kid? In a Benedictine world like that, it meant silence, it meant prayer, it meant meditation, it meant chanting of the Psalms, it meant an immersion in the Scriptures.
- 1.30** So Thomas, as a young kid, is inaugurated into this monastic rhythm of life. And I think it profoundly shaped him. He doesn't become a Benedictine, as I'll say now in a few minutes, but he's very Benedictine in his formation as a young man. And there is this deeply meditative, deeply contemplative dimension to Aquinas.
- 1.31** Now, when he's about 16 or so, he's forced to leave Monte Cassino. The reasons are political, and I won't go into all those details. But there was a political upheaval, and Thomas has to leave Monte Cassino. Where does he go? Well, it's very interesting where he goes. He goes to the city of Naples and becomes a student at the University of Naples, which is one of these new universities in Europe. Now, I don't know if you've been over to Italy. Naples, to this day, has the reputation of being an edgy place, wonderful and a little dangerous. Well, the same is true in the Middle Ages. Naples was an edgy, out-there place.

- 1.32** So here's this young kid who spent nine years in a Benedictine monastery. He's living a very contemplative life, and suddenly finds himself in an urban setting and at this new University of Naples. While he's there, young Thomas from Aquino becomes a double revolutionary. What do I mean?
- 1.33** First, he becomes an Aristotelian. Let me say a word about that. For about a thousand years before Thomas Aquinas, Christian theology was deeply influenced by the philosophy of Plato. Go back to people like Origen of Alexandria, go especially to Augustine, Saint Augustine. Most of the early church fathers were deeply influenced by Plato. I remember the famous Raphael painting, the School of Athens. And Plato is like this, he's pointing up to the forms. He's pointing up to divine inspiration. Aristotle is right next to him, and he has this moderating hand-out like this because he's pointing down to this world.
- 1.34** As Thomas Aquinas comes to the University of Naples, it was exactly the moment when many of the texts of Aristotle, which had not been available in the West, were becoming available. So they knew about Aristotle's text on logic, but they did not have access to his text on the soul, on physics, and especially on metaphysics. They were coming into Europe for the first time right as young Aquinas is becoming a student at Naples.
- 1.35** The Church wasn't crazy about this Aristotelian invasion, because as they read these new texts—new to them anyway—it seemed to be at odds with Christian doctrine. What Aristotle was saying about the soul, what he was saying about God, about creation, seemed at odds with Christian theology. The church had had a thousand years to get used to Plato. They were used to theologians using Plato. Aristotle seemed a little dangerous. So a number of the popes around that time had actually banned Aristotle from the Christian schools. You couldn't read them.
- 1.36** There were, however, certain underground figures who, living dangerously, were clandestinely teaching Aristotle. One of them, and now as an Irishman, I can claim a connection to Thomas Aquinas—one of them was a fellow named Peter of Ireland. We don't know much about him, but he was a professor at the University of Naples, and he was one of these underground Aristotelians.
- 1.37** So here's the young Aquinas shows up, and he begins hearing about Aristotle, and he finds it fascinating. He'll dedicate much of his intellectual life to finding a reconciliation between Aristotle and Christianity. This is where it begins, though, when he's a young kid in Naples.
- 1.38** I say a double revolutionary. So first, Aristotelian. Secondly, a Dominican. So Thomas at Monte Cassino, Benedictine. They've been around for a long time, well-established; everyone knew about them. Becoming an abbot of Monte Cassino, I get it, it makes perfect sense in medieval society. But mind you, Francis dies in 1226. His order is brand new.

- 1.39** His counterpart is a man named Domingo de Guzmán. We know him as Saint Dominic. And Saint Dominic had recently founded an order of preachers. This is a little weird. They knew about—we call them parish priests or priests that were the local priests in the town. They knew about Benedictine monks. What they didn't know about were religious order people who were out in the world, who were bringing the riches of the tradition out into the streets. Well, the Dominicans are called the Order of Preachers. And young Aquinas in Naples would have seen some of the first Dominicans, literally on street corners, preaching.
- 1.40** Again, this is weird stuff. It didn't happen that way in the Middle Ages. More to it, both the Franciscans and the Dominicans were called mendicants, simply a fancy way of saying beggars: mendicare, to beg. Because both Francis and Dominic said, "We have to trust completely in God's providence. And so you're going to beg every day for your food. We're not going to provide it. You've got to go on the streets with a begging bowl and ask people for food."
- 1.41** Imagine you're in medieval Europe, in a city like Naples, and who are these people? They're begging for food, and they're on the street corners preaching? They seem a bit—to use our language—like a cult. That's probably how the early Dominicans would have struck people. Well, somehow, young Thomas Aquinas, he fell in with the Dominicans. He must have heard them, must have seen them, and he decides he's going to join the Dominican order.
- 1.42** His parents, I mean, they didn't care much about Aristotle, but that would have gotten him in trouble at high academic levels. But becoming a Dominican? They say that, especially his mother, was extremely unhappy. "No, no, you're meant to be abbot of Monte Cassino. I get that. A Dominican? You're going to be begging on the streets and preaching? Are you crazy?"
- 1.43** So Aquinas, who had already been given the Dominican habit, it's pretty much the same habit you see today—Dominicans wear an all-white habit. So this young kid had put this habit on, and he was moving with brother Dominicans up north to get out of Naples.
- 1.44** Well, his mother sent his brothers, and his brothers were bully boy types. They were mercenaries, soldiers. She said, "Stop him." So, the brothers waylaid him. They stopped Aquinas, and one of them tried to pull the Dominican habit off of him. But they say that young Aquinas just clung to his Dominican habit, wouldn't let it go. But the family decided, "This kid is crazy. Let's try to straighten him out." So they bring him to a family castle, and they lock him up for a year. The hope was to dissuade him. They said, "Well, he's crazy, and he's been taken in by these crazy new Dominicans. He'll come to his senses." So they locked him up in the castle. They fed him and so on, but they were hoping just to dissuade him from this crazy decision.
- 1.45** Well, during that year, it's very interesting, actually. Thomas was never one to waste time, and he would have studied the Bible in a very serious way, even to the point of

coming close to memorizing it. That might strike us as weird, but I've known lots of Muslims who have memorized the entire Quran and can read it. It strikes us as impossible. It's not impossible. The reason we say that is that Aquinas often cites the Bible in his writings, but often gets it just a little bit wrong, which tells you he wasn't consulting a text. He wasn't consulting—he was drawing on memory. So during that time, he might have so immersed himself in the Bible as basically to memorize it.

- 1.46** The famous story told about his year in the castle is that one of his brothers, he was getting exasperated, decides to bring a prostitute into the room to seduce Aquinas, to get away from his vocation. So they bring the girl into the room. According to the story, Aquinas grabbed a brand from the fire and chased her out of the room, and she left the room screaming. To me, it has the ring of truth. It seems like such a strange story that I think it might be true. But after a year, Aquinas's parents are like, All right, what the heck? We're not going to dissuade him," and they let him go.
- 1.47** So he then makes his way from Italy up north. Where's he going? He's going to Paris, and I want to say a word about Paris. It's very important for understanding Aquinas. Paris was the intellectual center of the Church, and it was actually for several centuries, really up until the time of the Reformation. Paris was where the greatest minds gathered.
- 1.48** Now, you know why? It's because about a century before Aquinas, There's a figure called Peter Abelard. You know the story of Abelard and Heloise? Abelard falls in love with Heloise, and her family was all upset, and there's a great drama around them. But Abelard was a very famous teacher at the Cathedral School in Paris. You go to Paris today, and you'll see the Île de la Cité, where the Notre-Dame Cathedral is, the island in the middle of the Seine, that's where the Cathedral School was in the 12th century.
- 1.49** Abelard came there. He was so popular, he was so bright, he was so articulate that he attracted students from all over Europe to come to the little Cathedral School. So it grew and grew and grew until the students spilled off the island onto the left bank of the Seine, which to this very day goes by the name, Le quartier latin, the Latin quarter, called that because Latin was the language spoken by all these students who came to the cathedral school. Anyway, this becomes one of the first great universities, the University of Paris. And when young Aquinas gets there, it's really in its original heyday.
- 1.50** While he's there, he meets another famous Dominican, a man named Albert, who has the nickname Magnus. We call him Albertus Magnus, Albert the Great, or Big Albert, if you want. One story the Dominicans tell us, it might have been a joke because he was so little. "Hey, there comes Big Albert, Albertus Magnus."
- 1.51** But he really was a great figure. Albertus Magnus was one of the first great scientists in the West. Any telling of the history of science has to include Albert the Great, because he wasn't doing experimental science in our sense, but that observational science. He was very involved in that and saw the link between that and theology. He was also, like

Peter of Ireland, an underground Aristotelian. He was one of the leading Aristotelians in Europe.

- 1.52** So young Aquinas and he falls under the influence of Albertus Magnus in Paris. He goes with Albert as an assistant to the town of Cologne. If you've been to Cologne in Germany, Köln, the Germans call it, but no, Cologne, just from Colonia. It was just a Roman colony, right? But it was a center of learning at the time. Albert went there and took with him young Thomas Aquinas.
- 1.53** Well, Thomas studied under him with a lot of other students, and he was famously taciturn. That young Aquinas was very quiet, very meditative, self-contained. He was also, by all accounts, a big person. Now, whether that means fat, his enemy said fat, but the accounts all seem to come together that he was a physically imposing fellow. So his fellow students—and it's true to this day, of course, students will give nicknames—they referred to him as the dumb ox of Sicily. So Sicily, at the time, would have been the area of Italy where he was from, ox, because he's this big guy, and dumb, meaning not stupid, but mute. He's the dumb ox of Sicily.
- 1.54** Albert the Great heard this, and he famously said, "I assure you the bellowing of that ox will one day fill the world." Pretty good and pretty prophetic. One of the stories is that one of the students felt sorry for this, seemed like a dull classmate, and went over to help him with his logic. And then Aquinas just very calmly corrected that student's logic, and they were, like, "Okay, he's not so dumb after all."
- 1.55** So he studies there with Albert, and then he makes his way back to Paris, and he becomes a magister. Now, it's very interesting. The word "magister" means teacher in Latin. Our words "master," "maestro," come from that. When you have a master's degree, it's a magister's degree. Thomas becomes, we'd say, a professor, a full professor of theology in Paris.
- 1.56** What did that entail? It entailed a series of things. To be a magister first meant you were a preacher. So predicatio, "preaching," is the first obligation of a professor. Interesting, isn't it? You wouldn't think of that. Even like in a school of theology today, would you say, "The doctor or the professor's first job is preaching." It was in the Middle Ages, predicatio. If you're doing predicatio, what do you have to do? You have to do a Bible commentary. If you're going to be a preacher, you've got to know the Bible.
- 1.57** So Aquinas does a lot of biblical commentary in his career. He writes great commentaries on Isaiah, on the Book of Job, on the letters of Paul, a magnificent commentary on the Gospel of John. Sadly, a lot of that isn't read. Most people don't read his biblical commentaries, but that was a major preoccupation of Aquinas to comment on the—they called it the sacra pagina, "the Holy Page of the Bible." Okay, so you're a preacher, therefore you're a Bible interpreter.

- 1.58** Now, if you're a Bible interpreter, and anyone that's ever read the Bible knows this, you come across anomalies and questions and problems and contradictions. " Heck, Isaiah says this, but Jeremiah seems to say something different." "The Book of Genesis makes this argument, but it seems different from what Paul is saying. I got this in the Gospel of Matthew and this in the Gospel of Mark." How do you make sense of all this?
- 1.59** Bible commentary leads to what the medievals called "disputed questions," *quaestiones disputatae*. You debate and argue theological questions. Thomas Aquinas is one of the great masters of the *quaestiones disputatae*. Let me tell you how that worked.
- 1.60** What we're doing right now, actually, is from the 19th-century German academy. The Herr, doctor-professor, comes in at a podium and lectures and people sit and take notes. We're used to that, but that's a relatively recent form of education. Certainly, it wasn't true in the classical world. Think of Plato's dialogues. Where did those come from, but Plato's way of teaching, which was question, answer, new question, new answer, challenge. Aristotle's school is called the Peripatetic, which means walking around. They walked around talking to each other about their intellectual lives.
- 1.61** Here's the form it took in the Middle Ages. Thomas didn't come in and lecture, as I'm lecturing here; he engaged in the disputed question. The structure was this: the master would propose a topic for debate, and it would be publicly announced. So we're going to debate the existence of God. We're going to debate the power of God. We're going to debate the incarnation. We're going to debate some issue.
- 1.62** People would come, students and observers. The master would be there, but working with him was, they call it, a *baccalaureus*—we'd say like a doctoral student. And he would monitor the debate, and people from the audience would say, "I think there is no God because," *et cetera, et cetera*. And then someone else would say, "No, no, I think there is." And the *baccalaureus* might respond. Then someone else would bring up an objection and another objection, and the *baccalaureus* would manage this whole affair. The master is there, but not speaking yet. They would then break up.
- 1.63** They come back for a second session, maybe the next day. At this point, the *magister*, the master, having taken in all the questions and objections, having heard the debate, having heard what his student has said, now gives his resolution. He'd say, "Here's the answer to the question." And then he says, "What were the best objections that I heard? 1, 2, 3, 4, 5. Here's my response to each of those objections." So that two-pronged approach was a *quaestio disputata*.
- 1.64** They afterwards were written up by secretaries; people there were taking down the debate. And then those notes maybe were given to the *magister*, who would then write them up. We have those from Aquinas. We have *quaestiones disputatae* that are now in written form. But the real education took place in the lively give and take of question and answer. Thomas was a master of that.

- 1.65** Now, if people read Thomas Aquinas today, most likely they're not reading his sermons, they're not reading biblical commentaries, and they're not reading disputed questions. What they're reading, if they read him at all, are what they call in the Middle Ages *summae* or "summaries." So some of the great masters, like Thomas, would then summarize all the theology. They'd try to bring it all together. But the summary would reflect the dynamics of the disputed question.
- 1.66** So what I want to do is show you, with Thomas's masterpiece in mind, which is called the "*Summa Theologiae*," the "Summary of Theology," of how that's structured, because we have to understand the dynamic behind that work if we're going to get into the meat of it. So the "*Summa Theologiae*," like a Gothic cathedral, and like Dante's "*Divine Comedy*," is divided into three sections.
- 1.67** Think of a Gothic cathedral with three portals and three major elevations, and three's all over the place. Think of Dante's "*Divine Comedy*," which has three major sections—the *Inferno*, the *Purgatorio*, and the *Paradiso*—subdivided each one by 33 cantos or stanzas, each canto divided by little sections of three lines: three, three, three, three, three.
- 1.68** Thomas Aquinas's "*Summa Theologiae*" has three parts. The first part dealing with God and creation, the second part with the human journey back to God, the third part dealing with Christ and the sacraments. Why three? The Trinity, you see, the Trinity, God's deepest nature, is what's going to save us. So they want to trinitize us in architecture, in poetry, and in theology. So when you're citing Aquinas, the first thing to keep in mind is, are we in the first part, are we in the second part, are we in the third part? *Prima pars*, *secunda pars*, *tertia pars*?
- 1.69** Now, each major section is divided then into questions. So remember, disputed questions. "Question," *quaestio*, is very important for Aquinas. What's the question? And the question is then subdivided into articles. And the articles are where the fireworks happen. The articles is where the argument is really engaged. Watch how an article in Aquinas is structured. If you open up the page of the "*Summa*," it can seem so dry and technical, and where are we, and what's going on? Think lively disputed question in the Parisian context.
- 1.70** A Thomistic article is structured this way. It begins with the *utrum*. *Utrum* is Latin for "whether"—not the weather, sunny or cloudy—whether, W-H-E-T-H-E-R. Whether there's a God, *utrum deus sit*, whether there's a God. Whether God has power, whether God is a body, whether the goal of human life is beatitude, *utrum*, *utrum*. He raises the question.
- 1.71** The *utrum* is followed by a series of objections, which will be the opposite of the position Thomas will take. So, "It seems there is no God because—" Second objection, "It seems there is no God because—" Third objection, fourth objection, maybe five or six objections, mind you, laid out in a very compelling way.

- 1.72** You know what? I think I learned it from Jordan Peterson, the word to steel man an argument. You know the opposite of the straw man? When you straw man, you set up a very weak version of your opponent's argument. To steel man means to state it as powerfully as you can. Thomas Aquinas is the master of steel-manning arguments. The objections to the position he'll take are really strongly articulated. So *utrum*—whether—then the objections.
- 1.73** Then a little section called the *sed contra*, which means, "but on the other hand." See, there's a debate going on in his mind, but it's reflective of the debate he heard in the lively disputed question. *Sed contra*, but on the contrary, then it's usually a citation from the Bible or from the church fathers. "So it seems there is no God. On the contrary, the Bible says, I am who I am."
- 1.74** The *sed contra*, which is a little more poetic, more scriptural, typically, is followed by a section called the *respondeo*, Latin for "I respond." Now, what's that? That's the master now, on the second day of the disputed question, saying, "I've heard the objections. I've taken it all in. Now, here's my resolution." So that's the *respondeo*.
- 1.75** One way to read Aquinas, if you're strapped for time or if reading the whole thing seems too much, is to go right to the *respondeo* on each article, go right to what does he say. But he's a very fair-minded fellow. He finishes the *respondeo*, lays out his argument, but then he returns to each objection: a response to objection one, a response to objection two, to objection three, and so on.
- 1.76** Here's a wonderful thing to me about Thomas: he's deeply respectful of his intellectual opponents. He hardly ever says, "Well, objection one is silly, and here's why," or "What a stupid objection to make." He usually says, "In light of what I've said, here's something really right about that objection, but here's how I would correct it." Very irenic, very fair-minded.
- 1.77** Here's the way people cite a text from Thomas Aquinas. If you wanted, where is that? You might say "*prima pars*," so there's like a one with a little-A after it for *prima pars*. Then, you'd say Question 3, Q3, Article 4. And then you might say Ad 5, A-D means toward; that's his answer to the fifth objection. First part, second question, third article, response to the seventh objection. That's how you find your way through the text of Aquinas.
- 1.78** But see, what I urge everybody listening is, I know when you pick up the text, it can seem very technical, very scholastic, very dry, but always hear behind it the lively debate that was going on. I think everybody, Aquinas stands in that great Western tradition that goes right back to Socrates, who's the founder of Western philosophy. Socrates never once came to a podium and said, "Let me give you a lecture on the following subject." His approach was, "What do you think about this? Some people say this about justice, but what's your opinion?" And then he gets the answer, and then, "But that doesn't seem right because of this, that, and the other. What do you think?"

- 1.79** That dialogic approach that's deeply respectful of one's opponents, I love that. And you see it in Thomas Aquinas, I think in spades. And I think that's something much needed in our situation today, that sense of respect for one's intellectual opponents. So that's Thomas, and the way he words his style of theologizing.
- 1.80** He's in Paris for a time in the 1250s, and then 1259, he is sent to Italy. He's Dominican, so he's under the order of the head of the Dominicans. And he goes to join the Papal Court. So at the time, the Pope would spend some time in Rome, but then he'd move around, they say largely to stay away from the plague or to stay away from diseases and so on. The Pope would move from town to town.
- 1.81** Aquinas, for a number of years, did that. He moved around with the Pope, working on a number of his great texts, I mentioned the "Summa Theologiae." He also writes a book called the "Summa contra Gentiles," the "Summary against the Gentiles," against the non-believers, if you want. Some say it was written to help Christians who are working in Muslim lands. Could be. There's a debate about that. But it's a somewhat more minor version of the "Summa Theologiae."
- 1.82** He spends time in Italy, and then he goes back to Paris for a second sojourn in the late 1260s into the 1270s. And then he, finally, in 1272, comes back to Naples, to his home province. He's not old. He's about 49. Now, for the time, relatively old. For us, it isn't. But teaches there for a time.
- 1.83** But then something happened to him. On December 6th, in 1273, Thomas had a very disciplined life. He began every day by saying Mass and then assisting at a second Mass, celebrated by his associate, a man named Reginald. And then he would work all day. He'd work dictating, writing, preparing. He just did his intellectual thing.
- 1.84** Well, that morning, something happened to him because he came out to his associate, who was ready to start working, and he said, "No, I'm not going to write anymore." Now, mind you, this is someone who wrote 50 folio volumes. If you look at the collective works of Aquinas on the library shelf, a staggering amount of productivity. That's what he did. But he said to Reginald, "I'm not going to write." And he said, "What's the matter?" And he pressed him. Aquinas didn't want to say, but he kept pressing him. And finally, he said, "I cannot because everything I've written seems like straw compared to what's been revealed to me." It's one of the most intriguing lines, I think, from any of the saints.
- 1.85** Here's the mastermind of the great tradition. This is the great academic theologian. Words were everything for Aquinas. "No, I'm not going to write anymore because it's all straw." Straw? Are you kidding? It's some of the finest theological writing in the tradition. "Yeah, but compared to what's been revealed to me." What was revealed to him? We don't know. We don't know.
- 1.86** Then he said to Reginald, "I only hope that as the Lord has put an end to my writing, He will soon put an end to my life," which he did. This happened in December of 1273. In

March of 1274, Aquinas was on his way to the Council of Lyon. Interesting Council, by the way, called to try to resolve the East-West division, the Eastern-Western Christian division. They hoped that Aquinas, this great mastermind, would help them with that. On his way there, some say he struck his head on an overhanging branch, some say he collapsed, but he was taken to a Cistercian Monastery. It stands there to this day, although it's changed hands, but it's still there today, and stayed just for a few days there and then died on March 7th in 1274. So his prayer came true. The Lord put an end to his writing, and then very quickly put an end to his life.

- 1.87** But what that was, we don't know, the mystery of it. Was it a physical impairment of some kind, like a stroke? Maybe there's some evidence of physical impairment. On his way to Lyon, he stopped briefly to see his sister, who's called Theodora. And she has a text where she referred to him as *stupefactus*, "stupefied" or out of his mind or something. So what happened, we're not sure. Was it also a mystical experience? I think so. The Lord showed him something that even this greatest of Christian intellectuals was just gesturing toward the fullness of God's reality, something like that.
- 1.88** Let me say a couple of things about what I'm calling him, Thomas the Saint. So Thomas the scholar will spend a lot of time now developing his thought, but a little bit about his life personally as a saint. I mentioned the two masses, and then he began his work. I always think of Thomas as a chess master. The really great chess masters can turn from game to game, and they're playing a number of opponents simultaneously. They say Thomas would dictate to three or four secretaries at once. "This one is a commentary on Aristotle. This one's a commentary on the Gospel of John. This one's part of the Summa. This one's a disputed question." And he would turn from one to the other and pick up whatever the argument was. Extraordinary mind.
- 1.89** They say that in the middle of the day, the European custom, he would take a little siesta, but would often dictate arguments in his sleep. So as he was napping, he'd be formulating arguments. He was famously absent-minded, as a lot of great academics are. And they say there was a Dominican assigned to Aquinas at the table to make sure he wasn't putting inedible things in his mouth. So he was so distracted, so unaware of his surroundings.
- 1.90** The most famous story is about Aquinas and King Louis IX, who was Saint Louis. They were friends. Louis had great respect for Aquinas, and he invited a number of Dominicans to the king's table once, and the lively conversation is going on, and Aquinas was typically abstracted, thinking about something. In the middle of the conversation, they say he brought his beefy fist down on the table, and all the glasses shook. And Aquinas said, "That will settle the Manichees," the Manichees, ancient heretics. Thomas had come up with a really clever argument against them. Everybody was upset like, "What are you doing? You're interrupting the king's table." But Louis, the saintly king, said, "No, find a scribe to take down his argument." So two saints, Saint Louis and Saint Thomas Aquinas, in that famous story.

- 1.91** They say when Thomas—and you'd never guess this from his writings, which are so dryly academic—but when he would celebrate Mass, they say he would just weep copiously. His secretary said when he was being considered for canonization, that Aquinas gained much more from prayer than from study. When he was wrestling with a question, he would pray. And they say he would go into the chapel and rest his head against the tabernacle as though begging the Lord for inspiration. Again, when you read his text, you'd never sense that person, but there he was behind them.
- 1.92** Let me tell you—I'll bring this to a close with this—I mentioned Aquinas coming into my life when I was 14. When you become a bishop, you have to choose a motto. The motto I chose is from Thomas Aquinas. It's this Latin phrase, *non nisi te, domine*. Here's where it comes from.
- 1.93** Not long before he died, Thomas was working on the text on the Eucharist, the greatest of Catholic sacraments. He was trying to explain it. But he felt that even with all his efforts, it wasn't good enough. So he brought the text to the chapel, and he placed it there before the Crucifix, as if to say, "Judge this Lord," or "Is this worthy of You?" The story has it that a voice comes from the cross, "You've written well of me, Thomas. What would you have as a reward?"
- 1.94** It's a very interesting thing. Think of King Solomon in the Bible, the young Solomon. The Lord says, "What do you want? What should I give you?" And Solomon asked for wisdom. Good answer, by the way. Don't say, I want all the money in the world. So Aquinas is asked the same question, "What do you want? I'll give you a reward." And his answer was *non nisi te, domine*, which means "I'll have nothing except you, Lord." By the way, also the right answer. If you ever get that question, that's the right answer.
- 1.95** But it sums up Aquinas in many ways, too. His life was utterly devoted to God, and he had identified God as the source of his happiness, his *beatitudo*, and it's summed up there. With that, let's bring it to a close for this lecture, and we'll pick up next time now with Thomas addressing the question of God.

Lecture 2: Approach to God

At a glance — Aquinas's approach to God, including the famous 'five ways' (viae) toward demonstrating God's existence.

- 2.1 All right, we're back. The first lecture was about Thomas: Life, Times, and Culture. This one will be about his Approach to God. There's a couple of things, though, I forgot to in the last lecture I wanted to bring up.
- 2.2 One is that we can get a sense of what Thomas looked like. There are two skulls that are competing for authenticity. So Thomas dies in this place called Fossanova, this monastery that still exists. He was buried there for a time, but then his bones were transferred up to Toulouse in the south of France. There's an interesting story behind that because the Dominicans in Paris wanted him, and then Fossanova wanted to keep him. And the Pope compromised, and they put him in between in Toulouse. So his bones are there, and you can visit those in a golden casket under an altar.
- 2.3 But the people in Fossanova claim that when the bones were sent, they kept the skull of Aquinas. But then up in Toulouse, they said, "No, we have the right skull up there." I've seen the one actually in Fossanova. I was there for a liturgy, and they had the skull of Aquinas on display.
- 2.4 But the other one that probably is more authentic, recently, they gave it to these forensic police people, and they were able to put together a reconstruction of his face. Look it up online. He looks a bit like Liam Neeson. Most of the pictures of Aquinas had been very Italian-looking, but on his mother's side, in fact, he was more Germanic. Some of the accounts say that he was tall and blonde, and so that might fit the more Germanic or Northern European. But I think he looks like Liam Neeson, but with a friendly face.
- 2.5 The other thing I forgot to tell you: I mentioned the view that he was a big, heavy person, and there are a number of texts that testify to that. But what they meant by that precisely in the Middle Ages is not clear. And I got a bit of evidence that I'm going to stick with. If you go to the town of Viterbo, not too far from Rome, that was one of the places where the Papal Court went, so Thomas was there. He preached one time from the pulpit in the Cathedral at Viterbo. I always heard that story. So when I got there, someone said to me, "Do you want to see the pulpit where Thomas preached?" I said, "Yeah, who doesn't?"
- 2.6 So we go there. To my infinite surprise, the pulpit is not inside the church. It's out on the wall. It's like a bricked pulpit on the wall of the cathedral. So he would have preached to the crowds outside. Well, go there or look it up. I don't know how someone who is really heavy could possibly have fit into that little pulpit. And it's stone, so it hasn't changed in all these hundreds of years. So that's my argument that he

wasn't super heavy, but maybe just a big, brawny fellow. But take a look at his picture. You can see maybe what he looked like.

- 2.7** So that's Thomas, the person. That's Thomas, the man, the saint, the great scholar, one of the most important religious thinkers in the Western tradition. But let's now get into his thought. What's most important to him, no question about it, his entire career: God. There's a story that Dominicans tell that when Thomas was very young, like a kid in catechism class, seven years old, let's say, the teacher was talking about God. And Thomas evidently said to him, "But master, what is God?" Good question, by the way. And he never stopped asking it.
- 2.8** For him, theology is talk about God and then everything else in relation to God. So you could be a physicist, a chemist, you could be a historian, you could talk about being in its various aspects. The theologian talks about God and then how everything relates to God. God was the central preoccupying question of Thomas Aquinas, and it runs through every page of his writings up until that moment when he said, "Something has been revealed to me by God that makes everything I've written seem like nothing." But in the meantime, he wrote a lot about God.
- 2.9** Here's the first observation now. Thomas entertains the possibility that God's existence is self-evident. It might strike us as weird that position. What do you mean self-evident? It seems almost the opposite of self-evident. But there's a very long tradition that Thomas inherited that indeed argued that God's existence was obvious.
- 2.10** To be fair here, Carl Jung, the great psychologist, once said that there's a consensus gentium that God exists, there's a "consensus of the peoples" that God exists. Why? Because across space and time, look at every culture, practically everybody has believed in God up until our time.
- 2.11** Read Charles Taylor on this, the great Canadian philosopher. Taylor writes a book called "A Secular Age," and he says, in 1500, let's say, it would be almost unthinkable in any European context for people not to believe in God. There might have been the occasional village atheist, but the entire culture. That was true up until our time. We might be the first culture that is developing without a keen sense of the transcendent. So the consensus gentium. I mean, why does almost everyone believe in God? Well, maybe it's self-evident that God exists.
- 2.12** The most famous articulation of this view is found in Saint Anselm. Saint Anselm of Canterbury comes about 150 years before Aquinas. He dies in 1109. Anselm was a genius. He was a Benedictine, so doing his work in that monastic context. But toward the end of his life, he becomes the Archbishop of Canterbury. That's why we call him Anselm of Canterbury. But Anselm famously formulates what's come to be called the ontological argument for God's existence.

- 2.13** Here's how it goes in Anselm's version. Let's define God as "that, than which nothing greater can be thought." That's Anselm's formula. *Id quo maius cogitari nequit* in his Latin. "That, than which nothing greater can be thought."
- 2.14** Step two: It's greater to exist both outside the mind and inside the mind than simply inside the mind. Therefore, God exists. Now, it's one of those arguments that you think either that's the most brilliant thing I've ever heard or that's the silliest thing I've ever heard. What's interesting is intellectuals in our tradition, really, really smart people up and down the centuries, have either loved that proof or hated that proof.
- 2.15** Descartes, for example, the founder of modern philosophy, accepted it. Saint Bonaventure, a colleague of Thomas Aquinas, in the Middle Ages, accepted it. Look at it again. "God is that, than which nothing greater can be thought." Therefore, if you say there is no God, you're involving, Anselm thought, in a formal contradiction because you're saying that, which has to exist, doesn't exist. The very idea of God, implying the existence of God. Because if you say, let's say you're Christopher Hitchens, you say that no, there is no God, then you don't know what you're talking about. You're not talking about "that, than which nothing greater can be thought." That's the peculiar quality of Anselm's argument.
- 2.16** Let me give you a couple more modern versions of it, one associated with Alvin Plantinga. Plantinga is a Christian philosopher, a very influential player, and his is based upon modal logic. Modal logic has to do with possible worlds. Here's how his version goes: if I say God is the maximally perfect being—so it's his version of Anselm, "that, than which nothing greater can be thought"—God is the maximally perfect being. Well, wouldn't it follow that the maximally perfect being would exist in all possible worlds? Wouldn't that follow?
- 2.17** If you say, the maximally perfect being, but He doesn't exist in all possible worlds, well, then He's not the maximally perfect being, right? If the maximally perfect being exists in all possible worlds, He must exist in this world because the real world is at least a possible world. Therefore, God exists. It's a more contemporary modal logic expression of Anselm's argument that somehow the very idea of God implies the existence of God.
- 2.18** Here's the third version. Very interesting to me. It was Immanuel Kant in the 18th century who famously said that the problem with this ontological argument is that it's treating being as though it's a predicate. You see what it means? If I say, "Hey, that house is red, it's made of bricks, it's got seven rooms, it's got a slate roof." Another idea: "That house is big, it's red, it's got seven rooms, a slate roof, and it exists." Kant says, "What's the difference?" At the level of, when you're thinking about an idea, existence is not a real predicate. Existence doesn't add anything to the idea of the house. It's just your way of saying, "Oh, and by the way, that house actually is there." In other words, it's a category error, Kant thought.

- 2.19** Well, there's a colleague of Einstein named Kurt Gödel, G-O-D-E-L with an umlaut over the O, Kurt Gödel, who was, I would say, with Bertrand Russell and Alfred North Whitehead, the greatest theoretical mathematician of the 20th century. So think about the lunch that he would have had with Einstein, the two greatest minds of the 20th century. Well, Gödel formulated a version of the ontological argument he thought was valid, even though he was a little reluctant to share it with his colleagues. "They'll think I'm crazy."
- 2.20** Here's Gödel's version of it. He says that the idea of God would be "that which has every possible positive quality." It's his version of Anselm: "that, than which nothing greater can be thought"—"that which has every possible positive quality." So you'd say intelligent and all-knowing and all-loving and powerful and so on. Well, wouldn't necessary existence be a positive quality?
- 2.21** Let's say I don't exist necessarily—I'll come back to this in a few minutes with Aquinas. You don't exist necessarily. It's an imperfection. I wish I did. I'd always exist. So wouldn't necessary existence be a positive quality? Okay, well, then God, that which has every possible positive quality, must have it. Therefore, God necessarily exists. Again, the idea of God, implying the existence of God. If you say, with Christopher Hitchens, that there is no God, you're in a formal contradiction because necessary existence has to belong to the very idea of God. If you say, therefore, there's no God, you're involved in a formal contradiction.
- 2.22** Okay, I'm teasing you with those a little bit. And again, really smart people like Immanuel Kant didn't like that argument. Really smart people like René Descartes and Kurt Gödel and Saint Anselm thought it was brilliant. What did Thomas Aquinas think about it? Not much, actually. Aquinas would be closer to Kant. Thomas said that the ontological argument involves an illegitimate transition from the intentional to the real. That's his way of saying what Kant said, that you can't just, I don't care how impressive the idea is of God, you can't just slide from the idea to the reality, says Thomas Aquinas. So he quarrels with Saint Anselm on that point.
- 2.23** Now, I'm going to add a little caution, though. He does think that in some inchoate way, God's existence is self-evident. Why? Because everybody wants to be happy. Everybody. Beatitudo, remember? "Happiness." We all want it. What is our ultimate happiness? God, Aquinas says. The Supreme Good. Well, you can't desire what you don't know. If I don't know something, I can't want it. Therefore, if I want happiness, and happiness really is found only in God, then in some inchoate way, I have an intuitive understanding of God. I understand that God exists. So he is granting to self-evidence that much.
- 2.24** Now, his caution is that in the fallen, sinful world, most of us are mistaken most of the time about happiness. We think it consists of pleasure or money or power or honor or knowledge or something. So de facto, we don't have a clear understanding of God's existence. Inchoately, indirectly, we intuit that God really exists. But in this fallen, finite

world, we need clearer evidence drawn from the world to convince us that God exists. So it's a very interesting, subtle thing to me how that question plays out.

- 2.25** Anselm and Kurt Gödel and Alvin Plantinga and company are proposing what's called technically a priori arguments for God. A priori, Latin for "prior to," meaning prior to experience. I don't need to experience the world at all. All I need is to entertain the idea of God, and I know that God exists. So the ontological argument is an a priori argument for God.
- 2.26** Thomas Aquinas—now, remember Raphael, he's not so much Platonic, pointing up to intuition; he's Aristotelian. He's pointing out toward the world. So Thomas is much more at home with what are called a posteriori arguments, Latin for "from afterwards," from after experience, that I'm going to garner something from my experience of the world that will convince me that I need God as the ultimate explanation of it. That's the typical Thomist approach, to look out at the world and to find features of it that require explanation, and finally require the explanation of God.
- 2.27** So, we have those two traditions: the a priori, Anselmian, and the a posteriori, more Thomist. I like the fact that they're both present in the great tradition because—we could do a whole course on the ontological argument. I'll just say this about it. I think what all those versions are witnessing to, ultimately, is an experience that we have of the unconditioned.
- 2.28** What do I mean? I'm using Kantian language there. I look out at the world, and it's the world of conditioned things. That means things that exist in categories, things that relate to each other, ordinary things in the world. "I got that experience." I can articulate it further through the sciences. But sometimes in and through, above, under, whatever metaphor you want to use—through all of that, I sense, not one more conditioned thing, but the unconditioned. Not a being, but being itself. Not one more true proposition, but the truth itself. Not one more beautiful thing, but beauty itself.
- 2.29** There's a breakthrough of the unconditioned. Watch what has to be true of that. If it's really unconditioned, I can't say it exists only in my mind. I've conditioned it. I've said it's only there and not there. I can't say it's only out there like a thing in the world. The properly unconditioned is both subjective and objective, neither subjective nor objective, both subjective and objective, beyond the split between the subjective and the objective.
- 2.30** I think, go back to the Proslogion of Anselm, where he lays out this argument. He said, "My brothers in the monastery were asking me to come up with one really great argument, and I was trying, I was thinking, thinking, thinking, and it wasn't coming to me." And then he said, "I surrendered, and then, it was given to me," he says. What was given to him? The name *id quo maius cogitari nequit*: "that, than which nothing greater can be thought." And then, he found the implication of that.

- 2.31** What I'm driving at here is that it was an experience. It was the breakthrough of the unconditioned, I think, that Anselm was witnessing to in saying it can't just be in here. It can't just be out there. It's both. It's greater to exist both inside the mind and outside the mind than simply inside the mind. I think that's the experience, a very spiritual experience, behind the ontological argument in its various forms. But again, we could do a whole course on that, but I wanted to set it up by way of contrast now with Thomas Aquinas, the way he tends to argue.
- 2.32** Now, let me say something general first about these famous arguments or proofs for God. Thomas doesn't call them arguments or proofs. The Latin word, and he uses it a lot in different contexts for that, would be ratio, R-A-T-I-O, so "rational," rationalistic comes from that. A ratio would be like a demonstration or a proof. He doesn't call them rationes. He calls them viae. This is lovely. It means ways. Via means "path" or "way" in Latin. I've got quinque viae, he says. "I've got five paths."
- 2.33** Much better, because can God be caught in the net of our minds? Can God be the conclusion to a neat little syllogism? Okay, premise A, premise B, conclusion. Got it. There's something repugnant to the very idea of God in that approach. "I've got him." Saint Augustine famously said: si comprehendis, non est Deus. "If you understand, that's not God." You're seeking God: "I got it. I got it." That's not it. Drop it.
- 2.34** You know that line in the Buddhist tradition, "If you find the Buddha on the road, kill him." It's making that same point that if you think you've got it, that that isn't it. Thomas himself will say, "Whatever can be known or understood is less than God Himself." That's really good. It's like a warning before we enter into trying to think about God. "Whatever can be known or understood is less than God Himself."
- 2.35** That's why I think he doesn't say ratio. He says via or path. Here's a path that leads in the direction of God. The other term he uses, which is lovely in Latin, is a manuductio: ducere means "to lead;" manu means "by the hand." So a manuductio is a leading by the hand. Like you take a little kid, "Come on, let me show you something. Let me show you." You lead the kid to bring him someplace. That's what these arguments are. They're a manuductio. They're taking us by the hand. We're fallen people.
- 2.36** Thomas is deeply in touch with the Christian idea of original sin, that our minds are fallen, our perceptions are fallen. We don't see the world as it really is. We need a manuductio that will lead us toward God. That's what these things are, it seems to me, these viae, these paths.
- 2.37** Let's look at a couple of them, maybe—let's see how much time I have. The first one, the argument from motion, he calls the prima et manifestior via, "the first and more manifest way." It's the one that he thought was maybe the most obvious. Let me lay it out first schematically. Then, we're going to develop it a little bit, and I want to give you an example to try to put the flesh on the bones.

- 2.38** Here are the bones of the argument: things change. Nothing changes itself. There's no infinite regress of changed changers. Therefore, there must be some first unchanged changer. That's the argument in its most schematic, just the bones of it. Let me say it again: things change. Now, the word that Thomas uses for this proof is *motus* in Latin; our word "motion" comes from that. But he doesn't just mean local motion. When we hear motion, we think this. I'm moving around.
- 2.39** But *motus* in Latin means "change," not just change of place, but any change: change in speed, change in temperature, change in knowledge. I didn't know, and now I know. Change exists. Here's why it's the *prima manifestior*. It's the first and more manifest because the starting point is so obvious. Who would possibly deny that things change?
- 2.40** Second step: nothing changes itself. We've got to pause here and remember, he's an Aristotelian. He uses Aristotle's categories. Aristotle analyzes change in terms of potency and act. Potency for Aristotle means possibility. Something is not, but it could be. So I'm here; I'm potentially there. I don't know Russian; I potentially know Russian. I'm this temperature; I'm potentially another temperature. I don't have it, but I could have it. That's *potentia*.
- 2.41** What's motion or change? For Aristotle, he calls it the reduction of something from potency to act. Reduction is an odd term for us, maybe, but the transition from potency to act, from possibility to realization. So I don't know Russian. I go through a long training process. I know Russian. That's change, the potency to act. I'm this temperature, but a potentially warmer temperature, now I become warmer. Change, the potency to act.
- 2.42** Now you see why nothing can change itself. What's undergoing the change must be in potentiality. What's causing the change must be an act because you can't give what you don't have. So that which heats the thing must be at that temperature. The one that teaches Russian has to know Russian. The one that gives energy has to have energy. So what's being moved is potential. What's moving is actual. What can't you be? You can't be simultaneously potential and actual in the same respect. That's why nothing can move itself.
- 2.43** Now you say, "Wait a minute. How about animals? Don't they move themselves? Aren't you moving yourself right now?" Well, no. I can casually speak that way. But what I mean now is my brain is firing nerves that are firing the muscles that are moving the bones, and so on. I'm just saying some aspect of me is moving some other aspect. Casually, I can say that the animal is moving itself, but not really. If we analyze it carefully, there's always a moved and a mover, and they have to be different. That's the Aristotelian analysis of motion that Thomas follows in saying nothing changes itself.
- 2.44** Now, let's suppose the thing that does the changing is itself being changed. Well, then it has to be changed by another. Let's say that's being changed. Well, it's got to be changed by something else again. But what can't there be? There can't be an infinite

regress of changed changers. Why not? Then I'd never explain the change in front of me. I'd simply postpone the explanation indefinitely. Thomas's language is, you take away the first mover, you take away all subsequent motion, and therefore, you take away the motion that you can see right in front of you. Therefore, there has to be some first unmoved mover. Then he says, *et hoc omnes dicunt Deum*, "and this all people call God."

- 2.45** Let me make a few more clever cases. Then I want to give you an example. So the infinite regress part of it, you say, "Why not? I mean, I guess why couldn't that causal chain just go back, back, back, back, back in time?" First observation: he's not talking about something going back in time. It's very important. He's not talking here about, "I was caused by my father, who was caused by his father and caused by his father." He's not talking about that.
- 2.46** He's talking about a change happening now where there's an immediate here and now dependency upon a cause, which is here and now dependent upon a cause, which is here and now dependent upon a cause. The series is going back in time, Thomas said, "I don't know, that might be infinite. I can't prove that." But the series that is, he calls it subordinated *per se*, that's happening here and now, in that series, if you take away the first element, you take away all subsequent elements, and therefore, you take away the motion that you can see in front of you.
- 2.47** So he's not talking about that God, way back then, started things off. He doesn't think you can prove that philosophically. He's saying it's more moving in a way, pun intended. It's more spiritually compelling. God is operative now in causality. God is operative now in the motion and change that we see around us.
- 2.48** This first element, if motion is the transition from potency to act, if you're a moved mover, then you must have potentiality. What must be true of the first unmoved mover? No potentiality. He's rather—and I'll come back to this in the next lecture—*actus purus*. *Actus purus* is Latin for "pure act," pure energy. What he's saying is that right now, God is the great energizing source of the movement and change that we see in the world.
- 2.49** I now want to give you just an example to try to put more meat on the bones. So I've clarified, we don't want to go back in time. One thing I found, whenever people present this argument, and I see things like billiard balls, I'm like, no, you're getting it wrong. If you're doing billiard balls, you're thinking, "This motion caused by that motion and that before it." That's not what he's talking about. Nor father to grandfather to great-grandfather. That's not it. It's here and now.
- 2.50** Let me give an example. I won't use local motion because I want to broaden the sense of what he means by *motus*. So every morning, I'm a morning person. I wake up early, and I do a holy hour. I go to the chapel in my house, and I spend an hour in prayer. Well, I like coffee, and I like really strong hot coffee. So I get this really steaming cup of

coffee, and I bring it with me into the chapel when I pray. So think of that cup of coffee at this very high temperature—I read this, I did check this, somewhere around 200 degrees, the coffee cup is really hot, and I'm drinking it.

- 2.51** But now in the course of my prayer—so I'm there for an hour, but this maybe takes, what, 15 minutes—that coffee quickly changes temperature. It's super hot just for a little bit, but then it gradually changes and gets much lower temperature. So it's moving, it's changing, it's transitioning from potency to act. It's potentially this lower temperature and it's becoming actualized to that temperature. So if Thomas is right and Aristotle is right, nothing changes itself. That seems obvious. The coffee cup itself, the coffee itself isn't changing. What's changing it? Well, I mean, the temperature in the room. It's now moving to room temperature.
- 2.52** You say, "All right, I get it. There's something being moved and something moving. But is the temperature in the room itself being affected?" Well, of course it is by the temperature outside to some degree, but also by the heating system in my house. All right, so this is moved by that, which is here now being moved by this third thing. Well, what about that? The temperature outside, now, bring in a meteorologist that will explain why the temperature outside is the way it is: all kinds of high pressure, low pressure, winds, and so on, and so forth, even the movement of the Earth is going to get involved if I'm talking about the temperature outside.
- 2.53** How about the temperature caused by the heating system in my house? Well, that's dependent upon the electrical grid of the city of Rochester, which is dependent upon the wider electrical grid of the state of Minnesota, which is dependent upon all kinds of other factors. I won't go any further because engineers will tell me I'm wrong. But that's not the point. The point is that cup of coffee that I have in my hands that is changing, it's becoming actualized to a lower temperature, is here and now, watch now, being moved—think of it like a Russian doll—by a whole series of causes, each one extrinsic to the other, because nothing moves itself.
- 2.54** If I were a scientist, I could give you many, many, many more of these instances, but that's not the point. The point is, finally, Aquinas says, I've got to come to some unmoved mover, some unchanged changer that's responsible for the actualization that I can see right in front of me or I can feel it in my hands. "There's no God. It's just an infinite regress." No. Then you're violating the principle of sufficient explanation. You've not explained to me why this coffee is cooling in my hands, which I can sense.
- 2.55** Here's where, to me, it becomes very mystical and very spiritual. And that's why I thought of this, because the example is drawn from my prayer life, as this coffee mug is cooling, I'm aware of God. I'm aware of the prime mover, of the unchanged changer, of the one that is fully and purely actual and is ultimately actualizing this change that I can feel with my hands and taste. That's the Thomistic argument. Not back in time.

- 2.56** Or think of this—it's a dumb example, but think of a lamp suspended from a chain, and then finally it's hooked into the ceiling. The lamp right now depends upon the chain that holds it up, which depends right now on the one above it, which depends right now on the one above it. What can't you have? You can't have, "Oh, the chain goes back infinitely." No, then the lamp would be on the floor, but the lamp is not on the floor. It's suspended. Therefore, you have to have—it's an analogy, right? You have to find something which is not just one more link in the chain. You've got to come to some, as Thomas puts it, first unmoved mover, and this all people call God.
- 2.57** In the next lecture, I'm going to talk a lot about the attributes of God. We'll say much more about this. Is this argument so convincing that everyone in the whole world will just read it once and say, "I got it, God exists?" Well, obviously not. But is it a via? Is it a path? Is it a stimulus to thinking in the direction of God, that whatever God is, is something like this? He's something like the unactualized actualizer, the unenergized energizer of the world. That's this thing.
- 2.58** Let me give you one more, maybe if I have time. The second argument is called ex causalitate, "from causality." It's very similar to number one, so I'm not going to develop it.
- 2.59** The third one is intriguing to me. It's called ex contingentia mundi, "from the contingency of the world." Now, again, he's not doing Anselm. He's not doing intuition. He's looking out at the world. He's Aristotelian. And what does he see? Here's the first step in this third via: things come into being and pass out of being. As we look out at the world, we notice that things come into being and pass out of being.
- 2.60** Again, this should be pretty obvious. The natural world, plants that didn't exist, come into being. They flourish for a time. They pass out of being. All of us didn't always exist. We came into being at a certain time. We flourish for a time. We will pass out of being. Every human being, I think, over the last millennia, has all passed out of being.
- 2.61** Think of this scenario right now. So all of us in this white room with this equipment, the cameras around us and so on, this came into being. It didn't exist this morning, this state of affairs. I wasn't here, you weren't here. I don't know if the cameras were here, but this state of affairs didn't exist. Will it pass out of being? Yeah, in a few hours. I'll leave, you'll leave, the technicians will leave, and this scenario, this state of affairs, will no longer obtain. Things come and go.
- 2.62** Can I suggest, everybody? I don't know a poet or writer who doesn't, at some point, talk about this issue. This is like the issue that animates most philosophy and poetry and drama: the instability of things. There was a great priest scientist from the last century called Teilhard de Chardin, a French priest, and he grew up to be a paleontologist and a scientist.
- 2.63** He tells a story, when he was a little boy, like three years old, and the custom was to let the boys' hair grow really long when they were kids. So when his mother first cut his

hair and he had these blonde locks, and she's cutting his hair, and he's sitting by the fire, one of the locks of hair rolled into the fire and burned like that. It's gone. And it shocked him. A little three-year-old, he thought, "Wait a minute, that's me. That was part of me a few seconds ago, and now, like that, it's gone." So he dedicated his life in a way to finding what doesn't pass away. And I think, again, much of philosophy is born of this desire.

- 2.64** So Aquinas begins the argument with this observation: things come and they go. What does that tell him? It tells him something very important, and I think it's the root of all science, actually. It tells him that such things do not contain within themselves the reason for their own existence because if they did, then they would exist necessarily. Go back here to Alvin Plantinga and Kurt Gödel in a way. They would always exist if they contain within themselves the reason for their being. But if they come and they go, that means that they don't have that ontological stability. They are, but they don't have to be.
- 2.65** Again, I suggest, I think all the physical sciences rest upon this intuition. There's a state of affairs that is but doesn't have to be. Therefore, what? Therefore, I got to look for a cause, whether it's an explosion that happened. All right, that happened for sure. Did it have to happen? Well, no. Therefore, something must explain it. We're all here. Do we have to be here? Obviously not. So how do you explain it? I could have gotten sick. The car could have broken down. The equipment might not work. This is an existent state of affairs, but unstable in its existence. Does that make sense? We are, but we don't have to be, and that's why we look for causes.
- 2.66** So the next step in the proof: things come and they go; therefore, they don't contain within themselves the reason for their own existence. Therefore, I got to find a cause, a contingent state of affairs, which I've been describing, requires a cause. So let's again think about our situation right now. Here we are. This exists. It doesn't have to exist. So what are the causes?
- 2.67** All kinds of things we could say: the stability of this floor, which is requisite for this state of affairs, which is because the stability of the ground that we're on, which is in turn dependent upon the stability of the planet that we're on, which depends upon the situation that planet vis a vis the sun and the solar system. I can go all cosmological on us.
- 2.68** How come these cameras are here? Well, because the people who made them and the people that brought them and because the temperature in this room is such that they can exist. It could be a thousand degrees in this room. It could be a thousand below in this room. Those cameras wouldn't function.
- 2.69** How come I'm able to talk up here? I've got oxygen that I'm breathing. That's why you're all alive. Where's that come from? It's being held down by the gravity of the

Earth, and the gravity of the Earth comes from the size of the Earth, and in turn, it's positioned in the solar system and the Sun and all of that.

2.70 What I'm doing here in a playful spirit is beginning with contingency; I'm compelled to look for causes. Now, let's say the cause that I find—and I've named a number of things here—the cause that I found is itself contingent. Well, then I got to keep looking, don't I? It doesn't explain itself. And let's say that thing needs to be explained. Well, I got to keep looking. And I was doing that with the floor, Earth, planet, Sun, solar system.

2.71 Or even do it now psychologically: how come we're all here? Because I want to do this course for Jordan Peterson, because I suppose you want to learn something about Saint Thomas Aquinas. Why do I want to do a course with Jordan Peterson? I think he's a good guy, and I think propagating truth the way he does is a good thing. Why do you want that? Because I think truth is worth serving. Why would you think truth is worth serving?—I could pursue it cosmologically, I could pursue it physically, I could pursue it psychologically. But what I'm doing is I'm trying to explain, finally, why this unstable contingent state of affairs obtains. Does that make sense?

2.72 Now, what can't I do? Here's the familiar argument against infinite regress. I can't go back infinitely, appealing to contingent state of affairs to explain this contingent state of affairs. I must come, finally, to some reality that is not contingent, that is not dependent, that does not require a cause. I must come now—to use Thomas's technical language—to some being that exists necessarily, whose very nature is to be.

2.73 What's characteristic of all of us? We are, but it's not my nature to be. If it were, I'd always exist. I'd be God, right? It's not my nature to be. But I must come finally to some reality whose very nature is to be and who exists in a non-contingent way. This necessary being, Aquinas says, *et hoc omnes dicunt Deum*, "and this all people call God." So the first unmoved mover—there's argument one— but now the non-contingent source of contingent existence. That's God. That's God.

2.74 Now, what I'm going to do in the next lecture is take the next steps that Aquinas does. So what people often do is they might just stop with these proofs or these ways, these arguments, and say, "Wait a minute." Hang on. Thomas is going to now develop over the course of many, many pages: what must I conclude about such reality, about an unmoved mover, about a non-contingent source of contingency? That's the burden of the next lecture.

2.75 Let me just do one more with you. It's an argument that in a way is the most intuitively obvious, but also maybe the weakest in terms of demonstrating truly that God exists. But I want to just explore it with you a little bit. It's the fifth way. So we looked at number one, at three, and now at number five. Number five is an argument from teleology.

2.76 Remember, in Aristotle, you've got four causes: the material, formal, final, and efficient. What he means there, the efficient cause is what brings something into being,

what makes it, what pushes it. The final cause is what pulls it, its purpose. The material cause is the stuff it's made out of. The formal cause is its structure and pattern. Cleverly, he uses those four causes to analyze reality.

- 2.77** The first two arguments we've looked at are talking about efficient causality: what pushes something into being? What makes motion possible? What makes contingency possible? The fifth argument is a teleological argument. Telos means "goal" in Greek, so it's about final causality. Here's how Thomas states it very simply. Remember, he's Aristotelian. He's looking out at the world, at the ordinary experience. He says, "There are things in the world that are not endowed with intelligence, and yet which act purposefully for an end. This is possible only if they are directed by an intelligence that orders them to that end."
- 2.78** As in his famous example, "the arrow is directed to its target by the archer. This overarching intelligence, which directs non-intelligent things predictably to an end,"—*hoc omnes dicunt Deum*—"that's all people call God. And I say, it's an intuitive argument. Probably a lot of people who were trying to show that God exists might come up with something like that argument, of there's some sense of order and design and things having a purpose. Where does that come from, if not from some presiding intelligence?
- 2.79** Let me make a suggestion about it because the objections are obvious. One is that maybe there are a lot of those things, or maybe it's some alien power on another planet. Why would you say it's God necessarily? Let me press it this way. For Aristotle and Thomas, final causality, purpose, is predicated upon formal causality, which means intelligible structure.
- 2.80** So think of a tree as a non-intelligent thing that acts predictably for an end. So predictably, a tree will send out roots, it'll send off branches and shoots and leaves. It acts predictably for an end. Where does that come from? The argument here would be that it comes from the intelligible structure of the tree. The tree is endowed with an intelligibility which then governs the way it unfolds toward an end.
- 2.81** I'm now going to give it a little more modern spin here. Where does intelligibility come from? So the sciences—and I don't care what science we're talking about, physics, chemistry, psychology, whatever it is—the presupposition of any scientist has to be that the world is intelligible. It's understandable. It has a form. It has a pattern of meaning.
- 2.82** It's such a basic intuition. It's almost like a mystical thing that we don't attend to. But if you're a chemist, why would you assume that the world you're going to look at is ordered in a way that your mind will correspond to it? You're a physicist. Why do you assume that you're going to find great patterns of intelligibility when you look out at the world? But every scientist has to assume that. Otherwise, her work wouldn't get off the ground.

- 2.83** Where does it come from? You can just say, "Look, it's there. I don't know. It's just there." Can that satisfy you? I'm rarely satisfied with that answer. Where does universal intelligibility come from, if not from some primordial intelligence that has thought it into being. Here's the way Joseph Ratzinger, Pope Benedict XVI, put it in his book, "Introduction to Christianity." He says that objective intelligibility can only be explained through recourse to some subjective intelligence.
- 2.84** And that's why he says—I find this very fascinating—it's reflected in our language. When we come to know something, we say we recognize it. "I recognize that pattern. I recognize that truth." That word recognize, I'm thinking again. I'm thinking according to a pattern that has already been thought into that thing. I'm recognizing it. In other words, I'm implicitly recognizing the presence of a governing intelligence.
- 2.85** I'll give you one more connection here. There's a great article by a man named Eugene Wigner. I mentioned Kurt Gödel, who was a colleague of Einstein. Wigner, too, was a younger, contemporary friend of Einstein. He was a high theoretical physicist, and a Jew, but a secular Jew, not a religious man at all. But he spent his whole life doing the highest theoretical physics. If you have a background in physics, you know you can't do it without the most sophisticated mathematics. Physics is not just a matter of opening your eyes and measuring certain things. What's always involved in physics is very, very complex high mathematics.
- 2.86** Wigner, at the end of his career, after a lifetime of this, writes an article called "The Unreasonable Effectiveness of Mathematics in the Natural Sciences." Let me say that title again: "The Unreasonable Effectiveness of Mathematics in the Natural Sciences." What struck him was: why is it that we need the highest theoretical math to describe reality?
- 2.87** This is ratified, it's verified in the fact that I can build buildings and bridges and send rockets to the moon based upon my mathematical perception of the complexity of a physical reality. Where does that come from? Why should that work? He wondered: why should that be the case? It's cool in the article, again, he doesn't talk about God, but he often uses the words "miracle" and "miraculous." It's miraculous that this should work this way, that this should function this way.
- 2.88** I think it's a beautiful statement in more contemporary terms of this idea of objective intelligibility being grounded in some primordial intelligence that is thought in the being. Now, to bring back to Thomas Aquinas, see, I think the teleology that he recognizes that non-intelligent things act predictably for an end is grounded in this idea of intelligibility that has been already thought into being.
- 2.89** God, unmoved mover, the unchanged changer, the unenergized energizer. God, the non-contingent source of contingency. And now God, the supreme intelligence that makes credible a world that is marked in every nook and cranny by intelligibility.

2.90 If I have atheists in the room, can we quarrel with aspects of all those demonstrations? Sure. Welcome to the history of philosophy and theology. Do we have to look at what follows Aquinas to get a clearer sense of why these things he's discovered are, in fact, God? Yes. Then finally, are they at least *viae*, as he calls them? They're openings of a door. They're the showings of a path in the direction of God, knowing all the time that if you understand that isn't God. Whatever can be known or understood is less than God Himself. We'll do that exploration now in the next lecture: The Attributes of God.

Lecture 3: The Attributes of God

At a glance — The divine attributes — how Aquinas reasons about what God is.

- 3.1 So we've seen a bit about Thomas Aquinas himself, his times, his culture, what gave rise to him. And then we looked at these viae, these approaches to God, these paths to God, the famous arguments.
- 3.2 As I said before, I think where people get stuck sometimes is that they read the arguments and they think that's the whole story. No, Thomas is just getting started. The paths are like the opening of a door, and now the bulk of his work about God is filling in the picture. He's going to say, "What can we know about God based upon these arguments?" The trouble is if people just read that little tiny opening section of the "Summa" and they don't look at the wealth in there. So we'll be following that.
- 3.3 Go back to that question I mentioned, the little boy Aquinas raised, "But master, what is God?" Well, he kept asking that question. But at the very beginning of the "Summa," he makes an intriguing observation. He says that when it comes to God, we really know not what God is, but what God is not. Now, that's not entirely true, even in Thomas, but there's a lot of truth to it.
- 3.4 Who is God? What is God? Well, I don't really know, but I know He's not this. Whatever He is, I don't really know, but I know He's not that. That's called the via negativa, and Thomas uses that a lot, "the negative way." Here's the rule: whatever is imperfect in creatures, whatever is a sign of imperfection or finitude, does not exist in God.
- 3.5 So I'll take a creaturely imperfection and then deny it of God. In this way, it's a bit like a sculptor's art. Remember, Michelangelo famously said that when he looked at a block of marble, he could see the David in there, and his job was just to remove everything that was not David. It was a sculpting art. There's a lot of it in theology where you say that whatever God is, because remember, si comprehendis, non est Deus. "If you understand, that isn't God." So whatever God is, He can't be this, or He can't be that. A lot of our language, even if it seems positive, is actually an example of the via negativa.
- 3.6 I'll just give you one example. We say God is eternal. It doesn't mean God is everlasting. It doesn't mean He exists in everlasting time. It means He's not temporal. That's what that means. The eternal means He's not temporal. Now, what is that exactly? I don't know. Everything in my experience is temporal. I don't know what that is, but whatever God is, He's not caught in time. So that's the via negativa.
- 3.7 But it's balanced, to be fair, by the via positiva, the positive way. What's that? I find some creature perfection, something good and beautiful and true in creatures and say, "That's in God, because it came from God." If God's the first cause, then whatever is good and true and beautiful in creatures has to be true of Him.

- 3.8** But wait, the *via positiva* is always disciplined by what he calls the *via eminentiae*, the "way of eminence." What that means is that there's a positive perfection in creatures that applies to God, but in such an eminent way that it's really something I don't fully understand. So to say that there's beauty in creatures, well, God is supremely beautiful. But what does that mean? It's such an eminent type of beauty that I can't really get my mind around it.
- 3.9** Or you're good; God is supremely good, God is eminently good. What does that mean? I don't really know. So at the end of the day, the *via negativa* does have a primacy in theology. It's more that I know what God is not rather than I know what God is. So, keep that in mind now as we make our way through these opening questions of the "Summa" and start laying out the attributes of God.
- 3.10** The first one I want to mention is the one I think is the most important. When people ask me about Thomas Aquinas: "What's his most important teaching?" I'll say this. His teaching about the simplicity of God. The "simplicity" of God, *simplicitas* in his Latin. God is supremely simple in his manner of being. What does he mean by this?
- 3.11** Everything else in our experience is metaphysically complex. There's a being over there. It's a type of being. It exists, but it exists in a particular way. I can categorize it, I can define it, and I can name it in a complex manner. I can distinguish between a manner and a form in that thing; I can say it's in this category, not that category. That's true of all things in my experience. But God? God is. God is. In contrast to what? Well, you can't really contrast. In what category? Well, He doesn't really belong in a category. What genus is He in? He's not in a genus.
- 3.12** In that way, it's a bit like this white wall that you're all looking at. The simplicity of it means it's confounding to the mind because the mind's always looking for some place to hang on to. It wants traction. It wants to grasp. It wants to categorize and arrange. God is like my Minnesota background, like a white-out snowstorm. You've lost all point of reference. What's up? What's down? I don't know. How do I get traction in my mind? What category do I put Him in? The simplicity of God signals that strange manner of God's being.
- 3.13** So Thomas addresses this in question three of the first part of the "Summa," the simplicity of God. But now it's under a number of headings. We look at the articles now under that question. Here's the first one. *Utrum*—"whether"—God is a body. Is God an embodied reality? It might seem peculiar to us, but lots and lots of religions have held that God or the gods are embodied creatures. Classical Greek and Roman mythology would have held the gods to be supreme instances of our human bodies. Look at a contemporary Mormon theology. The Mormons hold that God has a body and lives on a planet in the cosmos. So it's not a completely far-fetched view that God has a body. Even in parts of the Bible, God manifests Himself in a bodily way in the Old Testament.

- 3.14** So Aquinas asks: Is this right? Does God have a body? Now, what's his answer? Well, we can guess from the arguments. We heard in the first proof that God is the unchanged changer. That means He's actus purus, "pure act." He has no potentiality. Matter is supremely potential in Aristotle's categories. Matter is that which is supremely malleable. It can be formed in different ways. Think of the matter in this room. It's in a particular form for all kinds of reasons. The matter that makes us up is formed according to our genetics. The matter that makes up this equipment is formed for a certain purpose. It can be formed differently. Someday our bodies will fade away. Someday that matter will change forms. It's the nature of bodies and matter and energy to be malleable. But God is actus purus; therefore, God cannot be a body.
- 3.15** Think for a second here. Some people who read the arguments of Aquinas and say, "I get it. There's some prime mover. There's some non-contingent ground of contingency. But isn't that just matter or energy?" Do you ever hear that argument from someone who's an agnostic or an atheist? "I get it. I agree with Aquinas's argument. But why couldn't I just say matter is the ground of a reality, that if I push the causes all the way back, what will I come to? I'll come to matter or energy." Why can't that be the case?
- 3.16** Because matter never exists as such. Matter. No, matter or energy is always in a particular form, shape or consistency or temperature or speed. Whether we're talking about planets or quarks, matter is not existing as such. It exists according to a particular form, which raises the question naturally. Remember our scientific intuition? If a thing is but doesn't have to be, I look for causes. So whenever I find matter, whether at the microscopic or macroscopic level, I naturally ask the question: why? Why is it in this form and not that? Why is it this temperature, not that? This configuration, not that?
- 3.17** What can't you do? You can't endlessly, therefore, appeal to matter to explain contingent existence. What you come to, Aquinas is saying, is some reality which is not a body, not matter, not mere energy. The thing about this, when we say that God is therefore a spirit—I'm dating myself here, but there was a show called Casper, the Friendly Ghost, when I was a kid. Remember? Did you guys ever watch that? Some of my older colleagues here remember that show. Well, so here's regular things in the world, and then there's Casper. He's floating around. He's a spiritual thing floating around. Don't think of God's spirituality that way. It's not as though God is some vaporous thing among the things of the world.
- 3.18** It means, again, the via negativa. Whatever God is, He's not something like this, like some particular configuration of matter. That can't be what God is. God is something other than that. Now, for want of a better term, I could say, therefore God's a spirit, meaning a non-embodied reality. But the trouble can be that then He seems like He's less than an embodied thing. Wouldn't it be nice if He was embodied? No, no. He transcends whatever modality of existence we find in the world. So He's not a body.
- 3.19** Think of this, too, everybody. There's a spiritual dimension always to this. What's the characteristic of bodies? I can get out of their way. So here we are, we're together, but

in a few minutes or hours, we're going to go our separate ways. I can avoid you. You can avoid me. Bodies can move in different places. I can't do that with God.

- 3.20** I can't say, remember Psalm 139, "Where can I run from your love? I climb to the heavens, you're there. I go to the seas furthest end. Even there, your right-hand holds me up." I'm using that tonality because I think in a way that Psalm is like the prayer of a frustrated person that would love to get away from God. "Where can I run from—" I can't. Stop trying. You can't escape God because God's not a body, not a thing in the world that I could avoid if I wanted to. But God is the very—I'll come back to this—the very ground of our being. That's implied here.
- 3.21** Now, in Article 4, under this Question 3 on the divine simplicity, there comes the discussion that I think is the most important in Thomas Aquinas. Therefore, I think one of the most important in all the Christian theology. Here's the *utrum*, the question: whether in God, essence and existence are the same. Okay, that's the *utrum*: whether in God, essence and existence are the same. I think that's a really abstract question, but here's what it means.
- 3.22** For the medievals, they distinguished—and actually it was the Arab philosophers, the Muslim philosophers who bequeathed to the West this distinction. What's essence? The medievals called it *quidditas*. *Quid* means "what" in Latin. So *quidditas*, they invented that word, "whatness." What a thing is. It's an essential nature or ontological structure. That's the essence. What's existence? They call that *quo est*, "that by which something is." It's the act of existing, the *actus essendi*. So I exist, I have existence.
- 3.23** But my existence is circumscribed, if you want. It's poured into the receptacle of my essence, my *quidditas*. I'm a being, but I'm a human being. That means I have existence, I have the act of existing, but it's not the act of existing as such. It's the act of existing, conditioned by the *quidditas*, the "whatness" of my humanity, if that makes sense. This thing is a podium. It exists. It has the *actus essendi*, the act of being, but it's not the act of being as such. It's being according to this particular form, or *quidditas*, or essence.
- 3.24** The point here, and it's true of any being in this world—the cameras, the people around here, everything— in all of these examples, essence and existence are distinguishable. Does that make sense? They're distinguishable. They render such things ontologically complex. They're a complex of both essence and existence. What's true of God? And it makes God utterly unique. That's why it's such an important clarification. "In God," Aquinas says, "essence and existence coincide." To be me is to be a human being. To be this is to be being as a podium. To be that thing over there is to be a camera. To be God is to be to be.
- 3.25** David Burrell was a theologian at Notre Dame University, a great Thomist philosopher, and he made that statement one time: "To be me is to be human. To be that is to be a chair. To be that is to be a camera. To be God"—it's got to be something, right?—"to be

God is to be to be." Think of essence as a potential principle. It's a limiting principle. Think of it as a receptacle into which the act of existence is poured, if I can use a crude analogy. What's God? God is the actus essendi itself. God is the act of being as such, not being this or that, not being this thing rather than that thing. To be God is to be to be.

- 3.26** Do you see now why this is under the heading of the divine simplicity? We call God simple in his being. My mind's trying to get traction. "But wait a minute. Tell me, who is this God?" Young Aquinas, "But master, what is God?" "Well, He's this or—" No, no, no, no. Wrong question. To be God is to be to be.
- 3.27** Now, now, go back to the Bible. Remember young Aquinas at Monte Cassino and then in his captivity year, learning the Bible? What citation does he use all the time? He uses Exodus 3:14. So Moses in the desert, and he sees the burning bush—I'll come back to that, too. It's a really interesting image, the burning bush. "I got to look at this thing. What is this?" And Moses, who was a Prince of Egypt, was used to being in charge. "I'm going to go find out what this is." "Moses, Moses, take off your sandals. You're on holy ground." God doesn't get controlled by us. We can't manipulate God and come and figure out what he is. No, no. "Take off your shoes."
- 3.28** And then finally, when Moses says to him, "Okay, I get it. But when the people ask me who you are, who sent me, what should I tell them?" And then God's famous answer—which has inspired, has spilled oceans of ink as people try to explain this—God says to him, "I am who I am." In other words, He's saying to Moses, "You're asking the wrong question, pal. You don't ask me, 'Who are you?' You don't ask me, 'What being are you?'" Moses would have assumed, as most people in this time, there were all kinds of gods—the god of this country, the god of that country, the god of this place, the god of that place, the god of the mountain, the god of the river—all right, you're a God, clearly, because you're speaking to me out of a burning bush, so you got to be some sacred thing. So which one are you? What's your name? "I am who I am."
- 3.29** So Aquinas reads that as, "My very essence is my existence. To be me is to be to be," is what God is saying. And you could say it's shorthand for "stop asking me a stupid question" because that's the wrong question to approach God with. That's the supreme expression of the simplicity of God. It also names what's most fascinating about God, the limitless quality of His being, the infinite intensity of His being. I have being, but at a very low level. It's a very low level of actualization. God is being in the fullest possible expression. What it means to be is God's nature. Essence and existence coincide.
- 3.30** This is related very much, too, to argument three, isn't it? Contingency, being that needs an explanation, has to be reduced, finally, to that which doesn't need an explanation, that whose very nature is to be. Otherwise, if God required an explanation, I could keep going. That's not what I'm looking for. What I finally have to settle on is something that doesn't need an explanation. What's the only such reality? I am who I am. That's why it's such an important clarification.

- 3.31** I love this. I want to make sure I get this. I've alluded to it, but I want to say it explicitly. Thomas asked the next article, "Is God in a genus?" Now, keep in mind, he's an Aristotelian. Aristotle was a scientist. He loved categorizing things. So what species and genus and what category do you belong in? I mean, all of creative reality, all finite things I could put in a genus of some kind. So we're human beings, the genus of animal or whatever. I could put planets and quarks, whatever it is, I could put them in some category.
- 3.32** So Thomas asks, "Is God in a genus?" Well, no. If God could be circumscribed by a genus, He wouldn't be the sheer act of being itself. He'd be a type of being. But then he asks, he pushes it, "What about the genus of being?" So you say that the camera is a being, I'm a being, you're a being, the planet Jupiter is a being. Isn't God at least a being? Isn't that at least legitimate that He'd be in the category of being? Aquinas says, "No, He's not in the category of being."
- 3.33** I think that's a mind-blowing observation. Here's a supreme categorizer. Here's a supreme intellectual. But he knows the reality he's trying to talk about doesn't belong in even the highest possible genus. God is not a being. That's why, in his Latin, occasionally, Thomas will slip and call God *ens summum*, which is Latin for "highest being." *Ens* means "an entity," *ens* means "being." But that's not what he typically calls God. Usually, he calls God *ipsum esse subsistens*. That means "the subsistent act of to be itself." Hang on to that for a second. It's a very interesting little description.
- 3.34** What is God? First of all, God's not a noun in Aquinas. God's a verb. *Esse*, "to be." *Ipsum esse*. That means "to be itself," to be in itself. And then, *subsistens*, meaning "self-explanatory." The self-explanatory act of to be—that's God. Got it? If you do, that's not God. I can use the language to gesture toward this reality, but it's all via *negativa*, really, this language. If you say, "Oh, yeah, I understand now," *non est Deus*. But I'm gesturing toward the strangeness of God, the abiding mystery of God. To be God is to be to be, not *ens summum*, but *ipsum esse subsistens*. But the fact that God is a verb—anything that's a noun could be categorized, could be caught, could be understood. God isn't that.
- 3.35** Stay with the burning bush for a second, because I will come back to it, but I want to tease you with it a bit. The Bush is on fire, but not consumed. What's a mark of finite beings? It's that we are inevitably competitive with each other. I don't mean that so much psychologically; I mean it ontologically. So this podium is standing over and against me. If I were to invade its being, I'd have to compromise it. I'd have to melt it down or something. We can relate to each other, but I can't become you without compromising me or you or both. There's a natural repugnance among finite things.
- 3.36** But when God comes close, what happens? Things aren't destroyed, but they become more radiant and more beautifully themselves. Does that make sense? The bush is on fire, beautiful, but it's not consumed because *ipsum esse* is not a being on the same level, not a being jostling for position on the same playing field. Two football teams, we

can't both—we're going to jostle for position. "God, isn't God the supreme being? So, He's going to be pushing me around." No, that's the lie that gave rise to atheism, actually. In all the great atheists, from Marx to Feuerbach and up to Christopher Hitchens, this idea that God somehow is threatening my freedom, God is threatening my integrity.

- 3.37** Remember, Hitchens at one point said that to believe in God is to believe we live in a permanent North Korea, like we're under the constant surveillance of this big being God. Can you see how that's not the case with Thomas Aquinas? God isn't like that. God isn't a being fighting for primacy with us. No, no. God can come infinitely close, and I become more radiant, more beautiful.
- 3.38** Haunting this entire discussion—and I'm being a little more philosophical in these presentations—but haunting all of it is what Christians call the incarnation. We say that God can become one of us without ceasing to be God and without overwhelming the humanity that He assumes. Is Jesus radiantly human? Yeah. Radiantly so. Why? Because God is so close to his humanity. We say the two natures come together without mixing, mingling, or confusion. That's burning bush imagery, and it's this metaphysics of the non-competitive God. Does that make sense? Finite things are always competitive to one another. Inevitably. God doesn't compete with his creation, but makes it more vibrant, more alive. And that's implied in this idea. It seems so abstract. God is not in any genus, even the genus of being. Beautiful. Beautiful.
- 3.39** Okay, let's move on beyond the simplicity. In Question 4, Thomas explores the divine perfection, the divine perfection. His basic argument is simple. God is unmovable, uncaused, therefore fully actual, actus purus. But what's fully actual has realized the full perfection of being. There's no limit to God's manner of being. He's fully actual and therefore "perfect"—perfectum in Latin has a sense of made through and through. It means "done," complete, perfect. Of course, God's perfect because He's actus purus.
- 3.40** What follows from that is the goodness of God. Now, here he's using goodness in the Aristotelian sense—I'll make a distinction later between Plato and Aristotle. For Aristotle, what's good is what's attractive. We use the term in that casual way, too. That's really good. It means I want it. It's attractive. Well, what do I want? Aquinas says that I always want perfection. Whether it's in sports, it's in food, it's in music, in whatever, I'm seeking what's best. Therefore, ultimately, what I want, the ultimate desire of my heart, is what's fully and in every sense perfect. Well, what is that but God?
- 3.41** Therefore, God is good. God is that which lures my will at all times. God is the most enticing, fascinating, alluring reality. This is important, I think. A lot of us have inherited a deist understanding of God, whereby a lot of the American founders were deists. Sure, there's a God as a first cause, I guess, way back there in time. And he made the universe and left it alone, and he went to write his memoir. It's like he's not really involved in the world. Well, that's not a biblical view at all, and it's not Thomas's view

philosophically. God is intimately involved in the world as that which is luring it and drawing it all the time.

- 3.42** Here's God as final cause. He's efficient cause, yes, because He moves and gives rise to the world. He's also the final cause of the world, drawing it back to Himself. Now, I'll come back to this, but let me give a little teaser. Thomas says, "In every act of the will, God is implicitly co-willed"—I'll just tease you with it because I'll come back to it—any act of the will, like your desire to be here today for this lecture. But what are you ultimately interested in? If you really play that out: "I will this because I want this, and I will that because I want—" What do you finally want? You finally want God. You finally want what is perfectum, what is "perfect," what is ultimately real. In every particular act of the will, God's existence is implicitly co-willed. That's the point here in God's goodness.
- 3.43** There's a great theme in Thomas, they call it the *exitus reditus*. *Exitus* means "the coming of all things out from God"—I'll get to that when I talk about creation—"things come out from God," but then the *reditus* is the "return to God." Not just like, what a waste of time; it went out, then it came back. It means it comes back now enhanced and perfected and realized. We talk about heaven and the beatific vision— that's what I want. With all my heart, I want the fullness of existence. That's God's perfection and God's goodness.
- 3.44** Question 8—I'm jumping around a little bit here, in the beginning of the *Summa*, looking at God's attributes. In Question 8, we get to a really interesting problem of God's relation to the world. How does God relate to the world? Not to put too fine a point on it, it's this old problem of immanence and transcendence. Is God present in the world? We say that yeah, He's immanent to it. But is God utterly transcendent beyond the world? Yeah, we seem to be indicating that all the time when we say He's simple and pure and perfect and *actus purus* and all that. So how do we put those things together?
- 3.45** Here's the *sed contra* to Article 8. Remember, I mentioned the *sed contra* is like a little, usually biblical passage. I love this, and I've done a lot of work with this. Thomas cites this mysterious text from the Prophet Isaiah, "Lord, you have accomplished all we have done." That's Isaiah. I love that. "Lord, you've accomplished all that we have done." Notice, please, the non-competitive dynamic going on there. Isaiah is saying that we did it, so we've done it, whatever this accomplishment is. "But Lord, you accomplished all that we have done."
- 3.46** Like when you played a baseball game, and you won, and the team did it, right? But then does the team get together and thank God, thank God for this victory? Yeah, sure. The chef has made this beautiful dinner, and we say, "Thank you, Lord, for this beautiful dinner." "You've accomplished all that we have done."

- 3.47** Is this language credible if we're just talking about creatures? No, it seems to me. Why? Because creatures are competitive ontologically. There's a mutual over and againstness. I can't—it would be wrong for me to say, "I've accomplished everything you've done. Good for you, but I accomplished it." No, no. It would be presumptuous of me.
- 3.48** But now think about this. God is not on this same grid with us. God is not one thing among many, but rather the undergirding and all-pervasive energizing source of the being of the world. Therefore, can I very coherently say, "We accomplished something, and Lord, you did it?" Yes, yes. Because of the non-competitive transcendence of God.
- 3.49** Think about this for a second—this is from mathematics or geometry: a point, a point that becomes a line, a line that now becomes a square, a square that now becomes a cube. What's going on there is that I'm introducing new dimensions all the time. How many points are there in a line? Infinite. How many lines can I fit inside a square? Infinite number. How many squares can I fit inside a cube? Infinite. Why? Because I'm talking about a higher dimension of existence, which is inclusive of the lower dimension without violating it. The line doesn't make the point go away, but the line can relate to an infinite number of points. The square doesn't make the line go away, but it can relate to an infinite number of lines. The cube doesn't make the square go away, but it can include an infinite number of squares.
- 3.50** God, vis-à-vis us, if He were being, a body, a thing in whom essence and existence don't coincide, I'd be battling with Him. Welcome to the New Atheists and the Old Atheists. It's this misconception of God as a competitor with us. But if God is the way Thomas is describing Him, I can be fully alive under the influence and aegis of God, and God can include an infinite number of creatures who can now be realized and can find their way and find themselves precisely through His activity.
- 3.51** "Lord, it's you who have accomplished all that we have done." That's it. That's it. The biblical line is giving rise to this subtle metaphysics that Thomas is affirming. We act, God acts in us, and we're not competing with each other. We accomplish something, and yet we still thank God for it. Yes, both are true.
- 3.52** Here's the way Thomas now puts it. Does God transcend the world? Yes, because God isn't a thing in the world. Of course, God's not like a thing in the world, so He is transcendent to it. But is God involved in the world? Thomas says, yes, the way an agent is present to that which it moves. So he's using an analogy here of the hand moving the stick or something. You've got to be present to it to actualize it. Well, God is the actualizer of everything in the world, and therefore, He's intimately involved in everything in the world, even as He transcends everything in the world. It's not like, "Oh, what a strange paradox." It's one because of the other.
- 3.53** Again, because of the modal difference between God's manner of being and ours, He can be intimately present. It's His transcendence that makes His immanence possible.

Does that make sense? Think again of line and point and square and cube. I think that's a helpful analogy to how one can contain without negating the other. That's God. Here's a line from Aquinas I've always loved: "God is in all things by essence, presence, and power"—and then he says intime, "intimately"—"God's in all things by essence, presence, and power, and intimately so."

- 3.54** In my parents' generation, before my time, there was this Baltimore Catechism, which was the way that people were trained in the Catholic faith. And there's a question in the catechism. Catechism, by the way, that one was very Thomistic. It was Thomas Aquinas for the masses. But one of the questions was: where's God? Answer: everywhere. Does that mean He's like a gas that permeates all things? No, it means God in His transcendence can be present to all things intimately by essence, presence, and power.
- 3.55** Here's a really nice summary line, if I can find it. Yeah, here it is. Thomas says, "God is above all things by the excellence of His nature. Nevertheless, He's in all things as the cause of the being of all things." Right, that's it. That's the paradox. So again, "God is above all things by the excellence of His nature"— because His nature is to be —"nevertheless, He's in all things as the cause of the being of all things."
- 3.56** Saint Augustine, whom Aquinas revered, said at one point that God is simultaneously intimior intimo meo et superior summo meo. That means "closer to me than I am to myself and higher than anything I could possibly imagine," simultaneously intimior intimo meo et superior summo meo. What the heck? How could that be true? If because of this metaphysics, it makes perfect sense.
- 3.57** Where is God in this room? He's nowhere in this room. This room is nothing but beings, nothing but things that can be categorized, nothing but things in which essence and existence do not coincide. God's nowhere in this room. I can't corral God—there's you, and the camera, and there's God. No, no, no. No, no. He's nowhere in this room. Where's God in this room? Everywhere, everywhere in this room, because He's the sheer act of to be itself in and through which all things are. To live in that space, now the spiritual life opens up.
- 3.58** The way I put it now in my own writings, and it's based on the Bible and on Aquinas, "God is that reality which can be neither grasped nor avoided." I can't grasp God because He's not a being. He's not in a category. I could get my mind around everything else in this room. I can't get my mind around God. I can't grasp God. But at the same time, I can't hide from God because my being comes from God. My breath comes from God.
- 3.59** Watch the Bible now. Once you get that principle, watch the Bible. Time and time again, people are trying to do one or the other: either control Him or run from Him. Look at Jonah. God says, "Hey, Jonah, I want you to go east by land." Jonah goes west by sea. "I want to get away from this." You can't. Give it up. You can't. Adam and Eve,

"I'm going to grasp at the knowledge of good and evil. I'm going to make this my own."
You can't grasp at God. Stop trying.

- 3.60** To live in a space where you don't grasp and you don't hide, what do you do in that space? You love God, it seems to me. You surrender to God. You say with Saint Irenaeus that the glory of God is a human being fully alive. Right, right.
- 3.61** You know that Gore Vidal, the great American novelist, had a wonderful description of jealousy. I've never forgotten it. He said that jealousy is this: "When a friend of mine succeeds, something in me dies." Do you ever feel that, fellow sinners? When a friend of mine—the friend is an important term there—"when the friend of mine succeeds, something in me dies." That's born of our competitiveness. But God, the glory of God, is a human being fully alive. He wants us alive. He wants the burning bush that we're more beautiful and radiant the closer He gets. So when you stop grasping and stop hiding, fall in love with God, surrender to God. That's the whole point.
- 3.62** The next issue we come to is the immutability of God. Is God unchangeable, unchanging? Well, it should be obvious from Thomas's first argument that he thinks the answer to that is no. God is the unmoved mover. He's *actus purus*, so He doesn't change. The *sed contra* is a citation from the Prophet Malachi: "I am the Lord, and I change not," we hear in Malachi. What's interesting there is the prophet Malachi is not engaging in metaphysical speculation. He's a prophet. What's he interested in? In the covenant, in God's covenant fidelity.
- 3.63** That's what's important here: we can think, "Oh, wait a minute. I want God to be able to change. Change seems good. He'll react to me, and He'll change as I change. Isn't that a good thing?" No, in Malachi: I don't want a God that changes. I want a God that's reliable, a God that's faithful to me and whose ways are not going to change. So I would put the metaphysics here in service of the theology of God's fidelity.
- 3.64** Anyway, he offers a couple arguments for God's immutability. I find the third one the most intriguing. He says, "Everything that moves acquires something by its movement, attaining what it previously didn't have." Think of my cup of coffee that gets cool. It attains the state that it didn't have before. "But since God is infinite, comprehending in Himself all the plenitude and perfection of being, He cannot acquire anything new." That's why God doesn't change.
- 3.65** Don't read it as He's unresponsive and He's cold and He's like the Rock of Gibraltar, this thing that's fixed in place and never changes. That's not the point. That's the point: God doesn't acquire something new that doesn't require some actualization to be Himself. God is the fullness of being. That's good news for us, spiritually speaking.
- 3.66** And it certainly doesn't mean that God doesn't enter into our lives in the most intimate way possible, that God doesn't know us and care for us. He doesn't respond the way we do, so we would change in a creaturely manner. That can't be true of God. But everything that's good in that intimacy with us, of course God has. There's no

dimension of being into which God could move. He's the act of being itself, so He can't be further perfected. But compassion, identification with us? No, I would say to the supreme degree, all that exists in God.

- 3.67** The Rock of Gibraltar is being at a very low level of actualization. Does that make sense? It's impressive to look at, I suppose, the Rock of Gibraltar, but it's a very low-level being. God's the opposite of that. Actus purus is not the Rock of Gibraltar. So read immutability as very good news, God's fidelity and reliability in relation to us.
- 3.68** In Question 10, he looks at God's eternity. I already hinted at this. It's a good example of the *via negativa*. The key distinction here is between everlastingness and eternity. They are not the same thing. What's everlasting is what remains unchangeably caught in time. We've all lived a certain number of years, and we look at the span of our life, and how much more we have. Everlasting? Vampires are everlasting. Do you want that, if you were stuck in this life and this world forever? That's why people that want, "I want to, through technology, I want to live in this body forever." God, I don't, not at all. Are you kidding? That's the everlasting. It means you're caught unchangingly in time.
- 3.69** Thomas's point here is that God is outside of time. What's the argument? The argument is Aristotelian. Aristotle says that time is the measure of motion. It's interesting. We could do a whole course on the philosophy of time, but time is the measure of change. Think of the Earth turning and the Sun and planets, and the time is a measure of change. Well, God doesn't change. He's actus purus. Therefore, God outside of time. He's eternal. There's no before, during, and after with God. Rather, Thomas says in beautiful Latin that God exists in the *nunc stans*. That means the "standing now," the continual now.
- 3.70** It's a weird thing, but to say that all of history is here and now in the presence of God, or better, God is present to every moment of history now in the *nunc stans*. Again, think of lines and cubes and stuff that He's at a dimension beyond time, so He can be inclusive of all time. Is God present to every moment of time? Yes, because He's not in time. I'm in time, so I can't be present to Napoleon and present to Galileo. I'm caught in my moment of time and they and theirs. God transcends time and therefore can be present to every moment of time.
- 3.71** The German philosopher Paul Tillich—I did my doctoral work on comparing Aquinas and Tillich. So I read him carefully. He described God's eternity as in his lovely German, his *Überzeitlichkeit*. *Zeit* means "time" in German. *Zeitlichkeit* means "timeliness." God has *Überzeitlichkeit*. He's "over time," not everlastingly in time—that's a vampire; that's terrible. God is beyond time.
- 3.72** I always think of this when in the best moments in life, we're not aware of time. Isn't it true? The best moments in life, when you're so caught up in something or someone or a conversation or a game or whatever, you're not aware of the pass of time. That gives you a taste of eternity, I think, what it means to be outside of time. And aren't the

worst moments in life when you're most aware of time? Watching the clock tick, painfully. Who wants that?

- 3.73** Now, this is very interesting to me. One of the objectors says this. So the second objection to this question of God's eternity. He says, "Doesn't the divine judge in Matthew 25 tell the wicked to go into the eternal fire of hell, thus implying there's a negative eternity alongside of God's?" It's clever little objection. So in Matthew 25, the goats are on one side, the sheep, and those who took care of the poor are good, and then those who didn't—that great divide. So doesn't the divine judge tell the wicked to go into the eternal fire of hell?
- 3.74** Listen to Thomas: "The fire of hell is called eternal only because it never ends. Hence in hell, true eternity does not exist, but rather endless time." That's the distinction. What's hell? Hell is everlasting time. That's one of the marks of it. Heaven is outside of time. Outside of time.
- 3.75** Those who follow my work know that I love the Gothic churches, and in the Gothic churches, the rose windows I love, especially. And the North Rose window at Notre Dame in Paris is my absolute favorite. The North Rose is meant to be a meditation on heaven. It's a design based on the number eight. In the middle of it, you have Christ, but then right around there are eight little circles. Then there's like twice eight, sixteen, another row of thirty-two, and then another row of thirty-two. If you add all these up, you get the number eighty-eight. So the whole window is meditating on eight. Why?
- 3.76** Seven for the medievals meant the complete cycle of time, like the seven days of the week. What's eight, therefore? It's not start a new week. It's what's outside of time. So the window—and I had that experience looking at it—it takes you so up out of yourself that you're outside of this world. You're outside of time, and you're meant to taste heaven in that window. So that's the eternity of God into which we're summoned, the *nunc stans*, the "standing now" of God.
- 3.77** Next, he looks at the knowledge of God. So let's say you follow so far and say, "Okay, I get it. God is the first cause, unmoved mover, non-contingent, ground of contingency, *ipsum esse*, essence, and existence coincide. I guess I get all that, but does He know me? Does He have knowledge? Does God know me or care about me?" Here's the way Thomas gets at it.
- 3.78** First of all, for medievals, knowledge here would have a biblical sense more than an Enlightenment sense. So the Enlightenment is conditioned very much by Descartes and others, where knowledge is like a very rationalistic, mathematical type of knowing. Where, of course, in the Bible, knowledge has a sense of intimacy. When Mary says, "How is this possible? I know not man." She's not been intimate. So knowledge means an intimacy with something. So he's wondering if that's true of God.
- 3.79** Here's the way he answers it. A rock, let's say, is very limited in its being because it's completely material. But we who have immaterial minds—I'll get back to that later

lecture—we have a rangeiness to our being. Following Aristotle, Thomas says the mind is quodammodo omnia. It's in a certain sense all things. It means beautifully that all of reality can appear in the mirror of my mind. My mind is capable of taking in all of reality. Why? Because it's immaterial. Because it's immaterial, he can take in all of reality.

- 3.80** God, we've heard, is supremely and completely immaterial, utterly actual, not a body. Therefore, there's an infinite range to God's capacity to take in being. First of all, His own being. So God knows Himself first. And Aristotle said that God knows Himself first. But Aquinas adds this: "In knowing himself, God knows His own power, and that to which His power has extended"—that means creation. Remember, He's in all things by essence, presence, and power. So when God knows Himself, He knows us because we're an extension of His power. It's beautiful, everybody.
- 3.81** He knows us in and through Himself, which is the way we are most authentically known. Part of sin means I'm understanding myself apart from God, in alienation from God, in rebellion against God. God knows me as I truly am in Him. Because He's immaterial in the most radical way, God knows Himself and knows all of creation.
- 3.82** I'll make just one more clarification here: the objector—and again, notice how generous he is to the objectors. They always make very clever arguments. The objector says, "But isn't the object known as the perfection of the knower?" So, as I come to know you, my mind is more perfected. It comes to greater knowledge. I didn't know you before this morning, and now I am knowing you, so my mind is being perfected by this. So if I say God knows the world, am I saying God is dependent upon the world, or God is perfected by this knowledge?
- 3.83** Here's Aquinas's answer: our knowledge indeed is derivative. So if someone asked me, "How did it go with that Peterson course recording?" And I'd say, "Oh, yeah, it was good. I came to this place, and it was designed this way. There were 20 people here." I would be telling them what I've learned from my experience, which perfected my mind.
- 3.84** But God's knowledge is not like that. Rather, Thomas says, "God's knowledge is antecedent and creative." What do I mean? Because you exist, my mind gets perfected when I come to know you. With God, God knows you, and therefore you exist. He knows you into being, not as though he's being informed by the world. How could He be? He made it completely. He is making it every moment. So, His knowledge isn't perfected by the world. Rather, the world is perfected by His knowledge of it. Important distinction, I think, because we don't want to put God in an attitude of dependency vis-à-vis the world, but always the opposite. Always keeping in mind that the more we are dependent upon God, the better it is for us. He's not competing with us. The simple God wants us to be fully alive, allows us to be fully alive.
- 3.85** With that, I'll bring this lecture to a close. I'll do a few more of the attributes tomorrow or the next lecture, and then we will talk also about the Trinity.

Lecture 4: The Trinity

At a glance — The doctrine of the Trinity in Aquinas's theology.

- 4.1 We're continuing our study of Saint Thomas Aquinas, this great master of the 13th-century Renaissance, this greatest of the scholastic philosophers and theologians. We looked at Thomas's approaches to God, the *viae*, the ways. We saw that for him, God is the unchanged changer. God is the non-contingent source of contingent existence. God is the supreme intelligence that guides non-intelligent things toward their end.
- 4.2 On the basis of those considerations, he then looks at various divine attributes, the most important of which I spent a lot of time with yesterday, God's simplicity to be God is to be, because in God, there's no distinction between essence and existence. God is not in a genus. God is not a being or a type of existent. God is *ipsum esse subsistens*, Thomas says, "the sheer act of being itself."
- 4.3 And then following from that, God's not a body because bodies change; they're mutable. God is unchangeable because He can't be reduced from potency to act. God is eternal because He must be outside of time, because time is the measure of change, and God can't change.
- 4.4 We saw, too, that God has knowledge. Why? Because God is sheerly immaterial, and it's the immateriality of our minds that gives us access to the whole of reality. God is sheerly immaterial, therefore has knowledge of all that is. First, including Himself, God knows Himself, and then knows His power, and therefore the extent of His power, which means He knows creatures. That's a little run-through of what we covered yesterday, of God, the Attributes of God.
- 4.5 There was one I left out, and I want to talk about it briefly before we get to the proper topic for this lecture, which is the Trinity. The one I left out is God's will and God's love. It's a very important point in Aquinas. Will is a modality of intellect. Here's what he means. When the mind knows something precisely as good, it *ipso facto* wills it. Let me say it again because it's a very important principle—he's an Intellectualist; the mind tends to come first for Aquinas.
- 4.6 When the mind knows something is true, then it has analytical knowledge of it. I might know the objective intelligibility in all of you. But the minute my mind grasps you as something good, what immediately emerges is *voluntas*, in his Latin, "will." Will is the desire to rest in the good that you possess or to seek the good that you don't possess. It happens automatically. The minute you know something as good, you can't help but either rest in it or desire it as an absent good.
- 4.7 So does God have a will? Of course, because God is sheerly intelligent. God knows all things. So of course, He knows them, first of all, Himself, and then all that participates

in Him. He knows them as good. Therefore, by that very act, God wills them. He desires, He loves. Let me say a word about that.

- 4.8** The first object of God's will is God's own being. God wills Himself. Now, what does it mean? It means He rests in the good that He is. God savors the good that He is. Don't think of it as some selfishness. God knows Himself as perfect, therefore is utterly good, utterly desirable. But this good is not absent to Him. It's His own being. Therefore, He rests in it. He savors it. He loves Himself in that sense.
- 4.9** We use that word, when someone dies, we say, *requiescat in pace*, "he rests in peace." I tend to think of that as a great hammock in the sky. You're going to rest in the hammock forever. That's not what it means, of course. *Requiescat*, the word in the middle of it is *quies*, "quiet" or "serenity." What that means is that you rest in the good possessed. You savor it, you have it, and you love it. Think of when you're in a great conversation with someone, and you're lost in it, and you're following it, and you're learning important things, you rest in that experience. You love it. You will it.
- 4.10** Now, there might be an absent good. If I look at the golf swing of Tiger Woods and I say, "Boy, that's so good. Look how perfect that is and how unlike mine it is." I want that. I will it, but as an absent good, a good that I'm seeking.
- 4.11** So does God have a will? Yeah. I love this. Someone once asked Thomas Aquinas, "What does God do all day?" You know what the answer came back? "He enjoys himself." That's very precise philosophical language. He enjoys Himself. He rests in the good that He is. He savors it. But now watch. God knows and loves Himself, but therefore, knows and loves all that participates in His being—I'll get to creation at the next lecture. God gives rise to the universe. Well, of course, He recognizes it as good. Think now of the Book of Genesis. "God found all of it good. The ensemble of it, He found very good." So of course, God wills, He rests in the goodness of His creatures. God loves all that is.
- 4.12** May I suggest that's a really important spiritual principle? If you ever feel yourself lost or alienated from God, or you feel like you're on your own, the very fact that you are is an indication that you've been loved into being. And the fact that you're sustained in existence means you're being loved moment by moment by God. You're being cherished. God's savoring the good that you are.
- 4.13** What I love here is that we begin in Aquinas rather abstractly with God as an unchanged changer, a non-contingent source of contingency. It can all sound rather abstract and sterile, maybe, antiseptic. But once we follow his logic and we come to all these insights, especially this one: that God loves first Himself, and then all that participates in Him. It's the love—what did Dante say? It came just a generation after Aquinas: love that moves the planets and the other stars. His astronomy was a bit off there, but the idea is really good: the love that suffuses all of reality. It flows from the love of God.

- 4.14 Here's an interesting objection. So remember, we talked about every time he raises *utrum*, "whether," you get the objections and then his response to them. Well, one of the objectors says, "Isn't love a passion? And since there are no passions in the changeless God, isn't it incorrect to speak of God having love?" Well, it's a commonsensical objection, and it comes up a lot actually in these theological conversations, people who don't like the idea of God's immutability. So Thomas holds to that, that God doesn't change. What the heck? If He doesn't change, then He's never moved by us. He never has a passion for us. We'll look at the clarification.
- 4.15 Thomas says that in us, who are composed of body and soul, we always have bodily passions that accompany the moves of the soul. And that's true. When you look at something beautiful or you come to some insight, well, something happens in your body, too. There's a reaction of your body. There's a passion in your body. Well, God doesn't have a body, so He doesn't experience passion in that sense, but that doesn't take away for a moment that God loves, because love is to will the good of the other. Love is to enter into and to savor the good of the other. So God has that, but doesn't need the passions of the body.
- 4.16 Press it a little bit, too. Why is this really good news? Consider for a moment the gods and goddesses of ancient Greece and Rome. They're really passionate, aren't they? They're always going through changes, and they're mad now, and then they're happy, and when they get the right sacrifice, they're mollified, then they get mad again. Do you want to be in relation to that divine power that's up and down and changing and going through different moods? I don't. I don't.
- 4.17 What I want, the Bible talks about, is the reliability of God's love, that God makes covenants, that God is faithful to us. Thank God, I would say, He's not characterized by fleeting and passing and evanescent emotions. No, the steadiness of the divine will toward us, we who participate in His very being. So God can't not love Himself, and by the same token, He cannot but love us.
- 4.18 Think of this, too—I'll come back to it when I talk about creation a bit—but to love is to will the good of the other. Therefore, whatever exists, God's willed it some good. Now, an angel, I would say, He's willed an extraordinary amount of good, more than He willed for me or for you. And for a dog, He's willed less good. We have more ontological perfection than a dog. I'll describe why that's the case for Aquinas, why he likes the variety in creation. But whatever is from a worm to an archangel has been loved, has been willed some good. That's Thomas's doctrine of the divine love.
- 4.19 With that, I'm bringing to a close this discussion of the divine attributes, which we have largely looked at through a purely philosophical lens. Think about a pious Jew or Muslim or a secular philosopher could probably follow along with much of this and say, "Yeah, okay. Yeah, it makes sense. Yeah, I get it. God must be this, that, and the other." I've been emphasizing in these lectures for the Peterson Academy, the more philosophical side of Aquinas, just to make it a bit more accessible to a wider audience.

- 4.20 But now I do want to say a little bit about something properly theological in Aquinas, and that's the doctrine of the Trinity. I know we're wading into very deep waters here, but I think it would be very unfair to Aquinas to talk about God and not talk about the Trinity, which is the distinctively Christian view of God.
- 4.21 As a little propaedeutic to this, can I say a quick word, everybody, about faith and reason? I mentioned before how much the New Atheists drive me crazy, like the Old Atheists, too. But one of the marks of the New Atheists is this constant polemic against faith as childish superstition. "You religious people. You've given up on reason. You believe any old nonsense. Superstition, credulity." May I say to you and to everyone watching, that is not faith. That is not faith. That is superstition, credulity, stupidity, blindness, childish, nonsense. The church doesn't advocate that. We never want a reason to be put to sleep.
- 4.22 Would anyone ever, even if you might disagree with Thomas Aquinas, would anyone ever say, hearing these lectures, "There's a guy that doesn't want to use his reason." Come on. He's one of the great rationalists, if you want, of all time. Faith, everybody, is never infra-rational, lower than reason. It's always supra-rational. That's the principle. Superstition and credulity and childish nonsense, that's what's below reason. We don't want that. The Church is as against that as any rationalist is. You don't want to be below reason. No, you want to awaken your reason as much as you can. Thomas is the great advocate of reason.
- 4.23 But now, what's authentic faith? Faith is what stands supra. It's supra-rational, beyond reason. Not repudiating reason, but acknowledging the limits of it and glimpsing something that reason by itself can't control.
- 4.24 Let me give an example or an analogy that I think is very telling. Coming to know another human being, another person, is your reason at work in that process? I hope so. I hope that when you're coming to know somebody, your eyes are open, your mind is alive, and you're seeking to know about this person, what you can learn, what you can see, what other people have said, maybe do a Google search, talk to the person. You learn a lot. Your reason is alive to this person, and it comes to understand.
- 4.25 But let's say now you become very good friends, and let's say you become very intimate with this person. Your reason has never been put to sleep. I hope not. But at some point, she will reveal something to you that you could never have known on the basis of reason. Maybe something about her deepest motivation or her deepest desire or her deepest longing. You'd never get that from a Google search. You'd never get that from talking to someone. You wouldn't get that from your own examination. You can only get that when that person opens her heart to you and tells you something, at which point—and anyone in this room who has ever fallen in love, mind you, falling in love, there's a surrender involved—you've got to make a decision at that point: do I believe this person or not?

- 4.26 Now, let's say what she's told you is totally repugnant to everything you've known about her through your reason, you're probably unlikely to believe it. But let's say it's not. It's not repugnant at all. It's congruent with what you know through reason, but yet it's something you could never have gotten through reason alone. You make a decision. You say, "I believe. I'll accept that. I believe you." That's what faith is like, authentic religious faith. It's a belief on the far side of reason.
- 4.27 Because the claim of the biblical religions of the Christian churches is that God has revealed something about Himself that reason couldn't get. He's not saying put reason to sleep, but He's saying, I'm going to tell you something about me that you wouldn't have guessed otherwise. The Trinity is one of these things. Philosophers don't come up with it naturally. It's not the fruit of a merely reasonable reflection. God spoke and we came to believe.
- 4.28 So I'm going to be exploring the Trinity, but with that proviso in mind: we're not abandoning reason; we're standing on reason, and we're looking out to something higher. So, where does the doctrine of the Trinity—why would someone like Thomas Aquinas even entertain this idea of the Trinity?
- 4.29 It comes indeed from revelation, precisely the revelation contained in Jesus Christ. What was given to the first Christians, the ones who first knew the Lord? He was someone sent by the Father. That comes up again and again. "The One who sent me." "I'm doing the will of the One who sent me." "I'm on a mission from the Father." And you say, "You sound like Jeremiah, Isaiah, Jacob. You sound like a lot of the patriarchs and prophets who were sent by God."
- 4.30 But then something really weird also was bequeathed to them, that the One who was sent by the One He calls Father, also spoke and acted in the very person of the God of Israel. What do I mean? "My son, your sins are forgiven you." And remember the bystander who says, "Who is this guy? Only God can forgive sins." He's speaking and acting in the very person of God.
- 4.31 How about, "You've heard it said, but I say—" He's referring there in the Sermon on the Mount to the Torah. The Torah is the supreme law for a Jew. It was the law given to Moses by God. There was nothing greater than the Torah because the one behind it is God Himself. So when Jesus says, this carpenter from Nazareth says, "You've heard it said there, but I say—" who could possibly claim authority over the Torah except the God of Israel himself?
- 4.32 "Unless you love me more than your mother and father, more than your very life, you're not worthy of me." He's a religious teacher. Okay. He's telling us important things about the spiritual life. All right. But if I said that to you today, if I'm teaching Thomas Aquinas, and I said, "By the way, unless you love me more than you love your very life, you're not worthy of me." You leave. Right. And you'd be right to leave. You'd

think I'd lost my mind. No human being, unless the One who is Himself the supreme good.

- 4.33** I've been citing just from the synoptic Gospels there. But then you get to the Gospel of John, and things become very explicit. "I and the Father are one," Jesus says. What? It befuddled people at the time. Philip: "The one who sees me sees the Father." What? Would Jeremiah ever say that? Would Isaiah ever say that? Jacob, Abraham? No, they'd never dream of saying that.
- 4.34** And then, we hear the beginning of the Gospel of John, "In the beginning was the Word. The Word was with God, and the Word was God. And the Word became flesh and dwelt among us." This is what gives rise, everybody, to the Trinitarian doctrine. All the people I've been referring to, the synoptic writers and John and all the first Christians, they're Jews, or they're very much in the Jewish thought world.
- 4.35** What's basic to Judaism? Deuteronomy 6, "Hear, O Israel, the Lord your God is Lord alone." There's one God, the unity of God. Does Thomas Aquinas affirm that? Yes, in every word of the first part of the "Summa," about God's simplicity and the absolute nature of God and God's not in a genus and essence and existence coincide, all that's a fancy way of saying, "Hear, O Israel, the Lord your God is God alone."
- 4.36** Yet there's this One sent by the Father who is acting and speaking in the very person of God. More to it, He rose from the dead. When that happened, you would get away with saying, "This guy is nuts. I think he's saying some good things, but he's a little out there. I'm not going to follow him." He rises from the dead. Which convinced them He is who He says He is. He is who He says He is. The first Christians are trying to figure this out. Who is this God now who's manifested—the God of Israel, the one God, but manifested as sender and sent.
- 4.37** Next step: they sense among them—now the followers of Jesus—the inrushing of the one they call the Spirit. The Spirit is not some mere creature. No, the Spirit is the one who christifies them and brings them into the divine life. There's a sender, there's someone sent, and now there's this Spirit sent by both of them. It's all one God of Israel. Go figure. This was bequeathed to the first Christians. Not that even the biblical authors had it all figured out. I think they took in the data of revelation.
- 4.38** May I suggest, too, there's a great text in the First Letter of John. It's a master text of the Christian tradition where John says, simply, "God is love." Now look, I just told you, following Aquinas, and this is standard philosophy of God, that God loves. Sure, God has will, and He rests in His own goodness and rests in our goodness. God wills. Yeah, God loves. But the weird statement of John is not just that, that God loves. It's "God is love."
- 4.39** Therefore, there has to be in the one God of Israel, someone who loves, someone who's loved, and the love that they share. Otherwise, you wouldn't say, "He is love."

You'd say that He loves. But if His own most nature is love, there's got to be a play of lover, beloved, and love.

- 4.40** Again, they didn't have this all figured out. I think these are the data of revelation, what was revealed to them. It took centuries. Look at the first couple of centuries of the Church's life. The smartest people around—think now of Origen of Alexandria, think of Irenaeus of Lyon, think of the Cappadocian Fathers, think above all of Augustine of Hippo, the great Saint Augustine—they're trying to figure out: how do we hold these two things together?
- 4.41** I might say there are two extremes. On the one hand, there were monarchians. It's like a monarchy. The monarchians held strongly to the unity, the unicity of God. What's this Trinitarian stuff? Well, the one God appears in different modes, I guess. So there's the imperious God of the Old Testament, and then there's the gentle Jesus of the New Testament, and then there's the Spirit that animates the church. It's the one God, but now in different modes.
- 4.42** You're seeing me right now. I got my black suit on my Bishop's cross, and I'm lecturing you. This is Bishop Barron in his teacher of the church mode. A few days ago, I was in my golf shirt and pants, and I was playing golf with a friend of mine. I'll be going out for dinner later tonight. It's the same Bishop Barron, but he's in different modes, he wears different clothes, a different tone of voice and all that stuff. Yeah, it makes sense. No, that's way too simplistic. That's called, by the way, modalism, that there are simply modes of presence of the one God. It's not honoring—the great theologian said—not honoring the distinctiveness of these three persons, the One who loves, the One who is loved, the love they share, the sender, the sent, the shared mission. It's not honoring that enough.
- 4.43** So others on the other side, tritheists, so emphasize the diversity that we ended up not with the one God of Israel, but with three gods, basically, three. There's this Father, and then there's a Son under Him and a Spirit under them. That's why it's also called subordinationism. There's the high God, then a little subordinate God, and then a third-level God. And no, no, that doesn't honor the unity of the God of Israel. "Hear, oh, Israel, the Lord your God is God alone." We can't have three gods.
- 4.44** Watch the church fathers, the early theologians, oscillating back and forth between these two modes, one emphasizing the monarchy, the other emphasizing more a tritheism, and they're trying to work it out. Might I suggest Augustine writes a wonderful book called "De Trinitate." If you have like a year sometime, with nothing else to do, you can plow through that. But Augustine represents one of the high-water marks in the attempt now to work out this dilemma.
- 4.45** I bring all of this up because Saint Thomas Aquinas, in the 13th century, this great scholastic master, has received this whole tradition from the Bible and then, distilled through the fathers of the church, given great expression in Augustine, he's now going

to try to take this in in his magisterial scholastic manner and lay it out to us as clearly as he can. So that's the Trinitarian thought and theology of Aquinas.

- 4.46 The text I'm going to look at here is I'm going to leave the "Summa Theologiae" for the moment. I've been looking at that almost exclusively now in the opening lectures. I want to look at the earlier "Summa" called the "Summa contra Gentiles"—I mentioned it yesterday—written a little bit earlier in the 1250s. It's a more philosophical text, but I think the treatment of the Trinity in that text is especially illuminating.
- 4.47 Here's how Thomas sets up the thing in chapter 10 of Book 4 of the Contra Gentiles, if you want to find it in the text. There's one God, but yet the clear biblical witnesses, there's something like a generation in God. The Son comes forth from the Father. So the Word that was made flesh in Jesus seems to have come forth from the Father. There's something like generatio, is his Latin term there.
- 4.48 Well, how does that make sense? Because our experience of generation in nature would always involve something like change. If a child comes forth from his mother, a seed is generated by a plant; there's some change involved, right? But God is the unchanged changer, so that doesn't seem to make sense.
- 4.49 More to it, in any generation we know of in nature, there seems to be at least numerical differentiation. There's one here, the generator, and then there's someone generated, and they're numerically distinct. But that can't be true of God because God is simple and God is one and unchanging. And there can't be one God here, another God there. So what gives?
- 4.50 Moreover, Thomas says there seems to be some diminution or imperfection involved in what's generated from the generator. It seems to be something less than what the generator was. But that can't be true of God. There can't be greater or less within the simple absolute God. So we got a problem. We got a problem. Thomas tries to resolve it now in chapter 11 of Book 4—I need a drink of water before I get into this resolution.
- 4.51 So, we got a problem: one God, but there's generations. How do we explain it? Here's his principle. He lays it in chapter 11. The higher the being, the higher the reality, the greater its capacity for interior and perfect self-reproduction. Let me say that again, the principle. The higher the reality, the more perfect and the more interior its capacity for self-replication. I'm going to give examples. Don't worry. All reality, Aquinas holds—and this is actually a very interesting thing to think about—all reality is marked by a capacity to replicate itself, to form an imago, "an image" of itself.
- 4.52 Let's start at the very lowest level for Aquinas, the lowest level of being: inanimate physical objects like a rock. Is a rock capable of self-replication? Can a rock form an imago of itself? Well, yeah, but in a very imperfect and very exterior manner. What do I mean? Think of a rock that's been sitting on the ground for a long time, and it's raining, and muds form, and so on. I pick the rock up, and there's an imago of it in the ground. There's an impression of it left in the ground.

- 4.53 Or let's suppose I pick up the rock, I throw it through the window, and it leaves behind a mark of itself on the window. Is it an imago of the rock? Yeah, it is, but at a very low level of perfection. Is it a perfect replica of the rock? No, it's a vague impression of the rock. It's a vague outline that was left behind by the crashing through the glass, imperfect and very exterior to the rock. It's the impression left in the mud that was exterior to the rock, the crack in the window that was exterior to the rock, requiring, in that case, me picking it up and throwing it to make that impression. It forms an imago, but it's really imperfect and it's very exterior to it. Rocks.
- 4.54 Next level up: plants, vegetative life. Can a plant reproduce itself? In the manner of a rock, yeah, the plant could leave an impression in the mud. I could pick up a plant and throw it through the window and it could leave— But the plant now is able to reproduce itself in a far more perfect and far more interior way. Why? The plant forms a seed. Seed falls to the ground, and then a rather remarkable imago of the plant emerges or a tree reproducing itself. It's much more interior because the seed is formed inside the plant. It's much more perfect because it's not just a vague impression; it's a replica of the plant. Still not perfect.
- 4.55 So the seed that gives rise to the plant is not exactly the same as the plant that produced it. It's like it, but not exactly like it. Moreover, it's exterior. The seed had to fall to the ground and had to grow in the dirt. Higher than a rock's capacity for image production? Yeah, but far from utterly interior and utterly perfect.
- 4.56 What's next? Rocks to plants to animals. What's an animal capable of? Well, I could throw an animal through a window, I suppose, and leave a crack in the window. An animal could put its hooves in the ground and leave an impression like a rock. But the animal now is able, let's say, a mammal, to reproduce itself in a much more interior way and in a much higher level of perfection. In Aquinas's imagination now, being at these different levels is heating up. He uses that image of heat, actually. It's intensifying. Its capacity for self-replication is getting hotter and more intense.
- 4.57 All right, rock, plant, animal. But now we're going to pass a quantum. Think about now a line drawn above animals. We come to us, to human beings. Can we reproduce in these lower ways? Yeah, I could throw you through a window and leave a mark. I could press you into the ground. Yeah. We reproduce, too, in the mammalian way. Okay, yeah. But why do I say a quantum has been passed? Because we are capable of a type of image making or reproduction that is qualitatively different in terms of its perfection and its interiority. Because I'm talking now about the mind. Here, Aquinas is borrowing from Augustine quite a bit.
- 4.58 What's the mind capable of? The mind can form an image of itself that is remarkably accurate. The mind can know itself and in a manner that is utterly interior to itself. What am I talking about? Let's say you're working with a counselor or with a spiritual director or with a good friend, and you're trying to understand your life. What happens in that process is that your mind poses itself to itself as an object. In the process of

working with a therapist or a counselor or a good friend, you are posing yourself as an object of contemplation. But who would ever imagine that you've split into two persons? No, no one thinks that. I am analyzing myself.

- 4.59 It's even reflected in the language as *Me pregunto* in Spanish, "I ask me." *Me pregunto*. *Je me demande* in French. I ask myself. That means "I wonder" in both those languages. You want to say, "I wonder." *Je me demande*. Well, what's going on when the mind is able to pose itself as an object of contemplation? Augustine says you've got mind, and what he calls *notitia sui*, "self-knowledge." Thomas calls it the interior word. There's the "mind," *mens*, that's the Latin term. Then there's the *notitia sui*, "self-knowledge," or the "interior word." Two things, two beings, two me's? No, no, no, it's I. I'm asking myself.
- 4.60 Now, stay with the counseling or spiritual direction image. Let's say in that process of self-knowledge, you come to greater self-appreciation, greater self-confidence or greater love for yourself. You come to understand and love yourself more fully. Mind, self-knowledge, *notitia sui*, and then what Augustine calls *amor sui*, "love of oneself." *Mens notitia sui amor sui*—"mind, self-knowledge, self-love." Three things? No. One, individual. But yet the mind is capable of this tripartite function.
- 4.61 "Ah,"—says Augustine, and Aquinas follows him—"what do we find out in the Bible? I have made human beings in my image and likeness." Does that mean bodies? No, God doesn't have a body. We know that. God is not material. So, it's not our materiality that makes us the image of God. What's the image of God? The mind. The mind is reflective of the dynamics that are going on inside the Trinity. Now, I'm getting ahead of myself. Hang on. Stay with our image of the rock, the plant, the animal, quantum line, human beings. There's a capacity for self-replication, which is now remarkably perfect and remarkably interior.
- 4.62 Are we ready to get to God yet? Not quite. Rocks, plants, animals, quantum line, human beings. Next level: angels. Aquinas, by the way, he has two great titles. One is he's the Doctor Communis. He's the "Common Doctor" of the Church. It's a very high title. He's like the theologian we all have in common. The other title of Thomas is the Doctor Angelicus; he's the "Angelic Doctor." He spent a lot of time thinking about angels, actually.
- 4.63 What's an angel? An angel is a creature, not God. So essence and existence are different in an angel. He's a creature. But an angel is a purely immaterial spirit. Does the angel have this capacity? Yes, because the angel is pure intelligence, pure mind. Angel has mind, self-knowledge, self-love, and its capacity for self-replication is higher. Why? Because an angel doesn't depend upon the outside world to come to intellection. We do. We're embodied spirits. We're animals that have these minds. I need to rely on the exterior world to come to any knowledge. An angel doesn't. An angel knows and loves itself immediately, perfectly. So self-replication, becoming more interior, more perfect.

- 4.64 You see where he's going. The image he uses—I find it very beautiful. He said that when you come into a house and let's say you feel heat on the porch, and then you get into the house, and the front room is even hotter, and you go deeper, and it is hotter. What do you know? There's some source of heat in this house that's like pure fire, and you're sensing it on the exterior, but now you're moving deeper into it. That's what's happening in this analysis of being. I'm watching from a rock to an archangel this capacity for internal and perfect self-replication getting hotter, hotter, hotter, more and more intense until it reaches what? God.
- 4.65 The simple God, yes, the one God, the God without a body, the God essence and existence coinciding, the one we've been analyzing. But what's characteristic of God? God—and we're using this model of the human mind; that's our access to it—God is capable of a self-replication that is utterly perfect, utterly interior. When I say utterly perfect, I mean that the Son is a complete, unrestricted, perfect imago of the Father. So that we can say they are one in being.
- 4.66 Distinct? Yeah, because there is in God mens, "mind"—that's the Father—notitia sui, the Father's "interior word,"—we call that the Son—and then look, the Father and the Son, the Son is such an utterly perfect image of the Father that they're one in being. The Father and Son look at each other, and what happens? They fall in love because the minute you know the good as good, what? You want it, you rest in it, you love it. So mens, notitia sui gives rise automatically to this intense, white-hot amor sui, self-love, that we call the Holy Spirit. That's the Trinity.
- 4.67 The unicity of God and simplicity of God have not been compromised. They would be if God were at the creaturely level. There'd be some play of otherness or differentiation. But in God, this process of mind, interior word, self-love is so powerful and so intense that it doesn't compromise the divine unity and simplicity. That's the image he wants us now to entertain as we think about the Trinity.
- 4.68 Let me give you an image for the Holy Spirit that I learned from Fulton Sheen years ago. The Father, the mens, the mind of God, the Son, the interior word, the imago of the Father, and then Sheen said that the two of them look at each other and they go [exhales], they just fall in love. The [exhales] is the Spiritus Sanctus—spiritus means "breath" in Latin. The holy breath shared between the Father and the Son. That's the Holy Spirit. Is the Son one in being with the Father? Yeah. Is the Spirit one in being with the Son? Uh-huh. The being is not compromised, but the sheer relations obtain.
- 4.69 Let me go back to the objections that we heard, that generation that can't take place in God because generation involves some imperfection. Well, there is no imperfection. The Son is the perfect imago of the Father. He comes from the Father. He's generated, but there's no diminution. There's no imperfection involved.
- 4.70 Is there matter involved? No, there's no matter in God. It's not a question of a plant or an animal reproduction. Is there a change involved? Well, our experience of

generation, there is always change involved, but not here. There's no change involved. This intense self-replication happens absolutely and automatically from all eternity. It's not like it came to be or there was a time when it was not and then it happened. No, it always obtains.

- 4.71** The emanation that happens within God happens according to this intellectual model, and therefore what? "The Word was always with God." Go back now to the Johannine prologue: "The word was with God." Because the reproduction is absolutely perfect, we can say with John, "And the Word was God." Not greater, not less, "the word was God."
- 4.72** He says this, which I love: think of a statue of a great person that reflects that person or reminds us of that person. Now, think of the son of a human father, a much more perfect imago, a much more perfect representation, but still not utterly perfect. But now imagine the Son, the Son of the Father, not just a statue that reminds you, not just a son in the physical order that is remarkably like dad, but now one who is utterly one in being with the Father. That's what we're talking about.
- 4.73** Here's another now important clarification. In the creed, we cite the great Nicene Creed, and we say that the Son was eternally begotten of the Father. God from God, light from light, true God from true God. And then we add, just to rub it in, "begotten, not made, one in being with the Father." Aquinas is reflecting upon that. What's made, are creatures. We were made by God. That means God didn't have to create us, and it means that we're less than the One who made us. Of course we are. That's what marks a creature, whether it's an archangel or a worm.
- 4.74** But the Son of God is not made, not a creature. He's begotten of the Father. That means He comes from the Father, but in a way that utterly and perfectly images the Father. Moreover, it happens here automatically and not as an act of the will, not as though the Father, "I wonder if I'll give rise to the Son." God does indeed decide to create. Creation is indeed an act of the will. The coming of the Son from the Father is not an act of the will. It automatically belongs to the very to be of God.
- 4.75** What I want to do now in these closing minutes is give you a schematic summary here. So this is the great image now from the Contra Gentiles, the image of the image-making, reproduction. You can get the Trinity in a way, if you can count 1, 2, 3, 4.
- 4.76** One: there's one God. So everything I said in the previous lectures, obtains. I'm not denying one little thing I said. "Hear, O Israel, the Lord your God is God alone," the unicity of God, essence and existence coinciding—all that's true. There's one God. Christians are not anything but monotheists. There's one God.
- 4.77** Two: there are two processions within God. We say the Son proceeds from the Father. Again, that's mens, "mind," notitia sui, "self-knowledge," interior word, proceeds from the Father. And then, proceeding from the Father and the Son is the Holy Spirit, the Spiritus Sanctus. Why from both the Father and the Son? Because He's the shared love.

He's the love breathed back and forth between the Father and the Son. So one God, two processions.

- 4.78** Then, here's where it gets tricky. We say three persons in God: Father, Son, Holy Spirit. Why do we say persons? I always love Augustine's answer. He said, someone asked him, "Why do we say, we call them personae, persons?" He said, "So we have something to say when people ask us what they are." The problem is, as we use the term person—I'm a person, you're a person, you're a person. Nice to meet you. Nice to meet you. One, two, three. There are three persons here. But that's not what we're talking about, because that's an issue now of three separate beings. It's you and it's me —
- 4.79** So we don't mean person in that way. What do we mean? Saint Anselm, many centuries later, when he was asked, he called the three persons three nescio quid, Latin for "I don't know what." Nescio quid, "I don't know what." They're not like anything in our ordinary experience, the primordial mind of God, the self-knowledge of God, the self-love of God.
- 4.80** Aquinas makes a little step in a maybe more helpful direction. He calls them subsistent relations. It's a very peculiar term. Subsistent, if you're an Aristotelian as he was, refers to a substance, something that exists through itself. So, I'm a substance, you're a substance, and we might have a relation. So Aristotle talks about that, that you're over there and I'm here, I'm talking to you, that substances who are subsistent have a relation. Relations are subordinate to subsistent things.
- 4.81** So Aquinas, who knew that very well, plays a little game here in a way. He says that whatever these things are—Father, Son, Spirit—I'm going to call them subsistent relations. But that's Aristotelian nonsense. The one thing relations aren't is subsistent. Relations are our secondary qualities obtaining between subsistent things. "Yeah, I know," says Aquinas, "I know. But the only way I can make sense of this is to say that these things are essentially relations."
- 4.82** What do I mean here? How is the Father different from the Son? In being? No, that would make God into two things. Do they have different minds? No, they share the same divine substance. So how are they different? They're different in their sheer relationality. The Father is the one who begets the Son. The Son is the one begotten by the Father. The spirit is the one—lovely term now in Aquinas—spirated by the Father and the Son, spirare, "breathe." He's the one breathed out by the Father and the Son. Not three things, not three persons in the ordinary sense, but three subsistent relationships that share the one divine essence. Got it?
- 4.83** Si comprehendis, non est Deus. "If you understand, it's not God." The Trinity, in a way, is like at the liturgy when you use incense. The incense symbolizes prayers going up to God, but also it's smoke in your eyes. It's like, "I can't see." Right. The most sacred things can't be seen clearly, just as at the highest levels of physics, things get really

weird and anomalous. That ordinary laws don't obtain. Here we're talking about the very ground of being. Are we surprised that things are getting very anomalous?

- 4.84** Joseph Ratzinger—of course, he became Pope Benedict XVI—he said the Trinity signals the absolute nature of the relative. It's a paradox, of course. The one thing relation seems not to be is absolute. But Ratzinger says, "No, the ground of being is a set of relations: Father, Son, and Spirit." So, I said, count to four: one God, two processions, three persons—whatever they are, nescio quids, three subsistent relations, and then four.
- 4.85** He calls four immanent relations. Here they are. The Father to the Son is called active generation: the Father generates the Son. The Son to the Father is called passive generation: He receives from the Father. The Father and the Son to the Spirit is called active spiration: they breathe out. Then, finally, the Spirit's relation to the Father and the Son is called passive spiration. Active generation, passive generation, active spiration, passive spiration—those are the four immanent relations that obtain within the Trinixty.
- 4.86** I think, here, everybody, in a way, we've gotten to the bottom of things or the top of things. We've gotten to the beatific vision. We've gotten to the point where we're naming what's true of the most fundamental reality. And again, we shouldn't be surprised that things get very strange and anomalous there, that the usual categories don't obtain.
- 4.87** God, the one God of Israel, simple, absolute, unchanging, not a body, essence and existence coinciding, all of that, is finally a set of dynamic relationships that constitute love: mind, self-knowledge, self-love—the love that God is, the love that moves the planets and the other stars. It's probably a good place to end this lecture.

Lecture 5: Doctrine of Creation

At a glance — Aquinas's doctrine of creation and its philosophical stakes.

- 5.1** In this lecture, I want to talk about the Doctrine of Creation. I'm very personally connected to this because I did my three years of doctoral studies in Paris, largely on Aquinas, and largely looking at this question of creation. I looked at two texts: the "Summa" and this wonderful disputed question called the "De Potentia Dei," about the "Power of God." So, whenever I come to this question, I'm reminded of those days back in Paris.
- 5.2** A couple of things about the Trinity before I move on. That word persona— I said, that is just because we want to be able to say something when they ask what they are. But that word's interesting. Persona meant the mask worn by an actor. Because personare, the actor would put the mask up, and there was a little sound box. So when the actor would speak, it would amplify the voice. So personare, person, always involves relationality. The actor was speaking to the audience. The Greek word for that, prosopon, has the sense of—optomai is "to see," prosopon has a sense of "looking toward." So both words are not totally arbitrary. Both have a sense of built-in relationality. I'm looking toward another. I'm speaking to another: personare.
- 5.3** So the three persons in God, these three subsistent relations, it's this constant speaking to and hearing. To shift the metaphor: a breathing in and a breathing out. Does God change? No, not in the creaturely way. So all that remains true. God's immutability. But we're talking about something different here. We're talking about this sheer intense relationality that is so perfect that it doesn't compromise the unity of God. But it's the absoluteness of the relative, as Ratzinger said. That's repugnant to classical thought because the relative is of a lesser degree. The absolute is what's really important. No, Christians will say that the relative is itself absolute at the deepest level of being; there it is.
- 5.4** The other thing I'll reiterate before we move on is that it is, to some degree, meant to stymie the mind. The mind has this trapping quality. The mind wants to know, and it's used to this world, and it's going to categorize and understand, and I got it figured out, and I want to know. But when it comes to the most sacred things, there's an instinct to throw smoke in our eyes. There's an instinct to say, "No, no, no." You think of Moses and the burning bush, "No, take off your shoes here, man. You're on holy ground."
- 5.5** The shoe thing is interesting. If you have shoes on, you can walk anywhere: rocky ground, difficult ground. If you have shoes on, you can walk very confidently. If you don't have shoes on, it gets pretty dicey. If it's rocky and dangerous, you want to move very tentatively. So when God says, "Take off your shoes, Moses. You're not in command here." "I'm going to go figure out what this is. Why is that bush not being

consumed?" You're in the wrong spiritual space if you're doing that. Take off your shoes, kneel down; you're on holy ground.

- 5.6** There's something about the Trinitarian language that we use, of course, all during the liturgy, that is meant to be like smoke in your eyes. "Wait a minute. I think I had this thing about God, and now you've thrown all this confusion into it." In a way, that's the point. I think you can be relatively correct or relatively incorrect in the way you use the language. It's not just arbitrary, but part of its purpose, I think, is to confound the mind that wants to have everything.
- 5.7** With that, now I'm going to move to creation. So far we've been looking at God, and I told you, for Aquinas, theology is talk about God and everything in relation to God. So we begin with the arguments, the attributes, and then it culminates in this supreme weirdness of the Trinity. But we've been talking about God. But now, the world, why is there a world at all? That's a really puzzling question. Because if God is God, perfect, absolute, unmoved mover, He's the essence in existence coinciding. He's got every possible perfection, knows Himself, wills Himself, loves Himself. Why would He bother creating? Good question.
- 5.8** The answer Aquinas proposes is drawn now not from Aristotle, but from Plato. Remember, I told you, when discussing God's perfection and God's goodness, he used an Aristotelian model. God is called good because he's perfect, and what we seek is the perfect. So we call that good, and God is therefore supremely good. That's an Aristotelian analysis.
- 5.9** Plato plays the game differently. For him, the good, the good, is not so much that which is sought. The good is that which gives. Remember in "The Republic" of Plato, when the man escapes from the cave and sees the real world out there, and then it's in the light of the sun, and he finally looks up, and he can barely see the sun, but he realizes the sun is what gives light to illumine everything in the world. What he's been living in is just this cave full of shadows. But the ultimate reality he finds is the sun, which gives light to illumine everything else.
- 5.10** Plato said that's a metaphor, that's a symbol of the Form of the Good. Think of all the Forms, the abstract realities. The highest is the Form of the Good, which is even beyond being, Plato says—it's very interesting—beyond being. Why? Because it's what gives being. It's what makes being possible. The Good for Plato is what is diffusive of itself. The Latin, the lovely phrase, is *bonum diffusivum sui*. "The good"—*bonum*—"is diffusive of itself."
- 5.11** So, for Aristotle, it's what we seek. For Plato, it's what gives. *Bonum diffusivum sui*. When you're in a good mood, do you hide in your room? No, usually when you're in a bad mood, you hide in your room. When things are going really well, life is good, what do you want to do? You want to go out with your friends, and you want to have a

conversation, you want to have a party. Bonum diffusivum sui. Let's celebrate. I'm in a good mood. Things are going well. I want to celebrate. Let's have a party.

- 5.12** That's the answer Aquinas gives to the question: Why did God create? Out of need? No, because God has no needs. It's a very, very important point, theologically and spiritually. God has no needs. How could He? He's perfect. Why is that good news for us? The minute you say God has needs, watch out. If God, with all the power, God, the source of reality, has needs, what's he going to do? He's going to manipulate us.
- 5.13** Again, read the Greek and Roman myths. I love the Greek and Roman myths. I read them as a little kid. I love them. But I am always really wary when you read these books about, "Let's go back to the Greek and Roman religion." Keep me away from Greek and Roman religion because those gods who were indeed needy meant they were going to start manipulating. They need something from us. Well, then they're going to use us and abuse us. They need our sacrifices. They need our homage. If they don't get it, they're going to be pretty mad.
- 5.14** Does the God of the Bible need our sacrifices? Read Psalm 50, by the way. It's really illuminating. If you're ever caught at this point, God says, "You think I need your sacrifices? You think I need the blood of your bulls? Give me a break. I made everything. I made all the beasts of the field. How could I possibly need them?" That's such good news. It means the world exists purely as an act of goodness and an act of love. Bonum diffusivum sui. God makes the world not to satisfy some lack in Him, but rather to manifest His glory and to share His life.
- 5.15** Everybody, so much of the spiritual life hinges on this thing. I've been doing spiritual direction for years and years with people. How often folks are caught at this point that they think of God as some manipulative power that they have to mollify? God doesn't need anything. He doesn't even need our moral perfection. Somehow that if I'm a good boy, then God will be satisfied in some way. He doesn't need my moral perfection. He wants my moral perfection. He wants it. Why? Because it makes me happy.
- 5.16** Getting this straight, it's a metaphysical point, but with huge spiritual implications. Following the divine law, going to Mass, performing rituals—God doesn't need any of that, but He wants it because it's good for me. As I worship God, what happens? I get rightly ordered. As I live a properly ordered moral life, what happens? I find happiness. That's the point of morality. It's to make you happy. But we have to reverse this, and it's right on this metaphysical point of: why did God create? If there's anything like need, then our spiritual lives are going to be all off-kilter. No, no. Bonum diffusivum sui. The good is diffusive of itself, and so God shares with us.
- 5.17** And that's why, as I cited him the other day, one of my heroes, the great Saint Irenaeus of Lyon, "Gloria Dei homo vivens." The glory of God is a human being fully alive. That's what God wants. He's not playing a game with us. The glory of God is when we get in line so he can be satisfied—no, no. When we're alive, God is happy. God is joyful.

Parents that want to share their lives with their kids, that's the metaphor, that's the model for God. That's why God creates.

- 5.18** Let me make reference here to a successor of Aquinas, actually, who sat in his chair of theology in Paris, just a generation after him: a man named Meister Eckhart. We know him as Meister Eckhart, Master Eckhart, a German Dominican, known now as a spiritual writer of great power, seen as an edgy figure by many— Meister Eckhart. But I think he was pulling out some of the implications of Aquinas's great doctrine on creation. I call him to mind because of an insight he had.
- 5.19** He said that there's the metaphor of climbing the Holy Mountain that's used by a lot of spiritual people, and there's something right in it: God, and we need to climb up the Holy Mountain to get to God, and so all the spiritual exercise is involved in that. And Eckhart said, "No, no. Don't climb mountains. Sit and sink." *Sitzen Sie und sinken Sie*. Sit and sink into God. What did he mean? God is the ground of our being, not a distant, supreme being that I have to climb a mountain to get to. Again, I'm not badmouthing the mountain metaphor. It's got virtue to it. But the danger is that up there, out there somewhere, is this supreme being, God, that I have to climb up to. No, always already God is the creative source of my being moment to moment.
- 5.20** How do I find God? Sit and sink. In other words, you're already in God, inevitably. It's more a matter of waking up to that fact. I got this metaphor from Ron Rolheiser, who was a spiritual writer recently, and he said that much of our prayer life is looking at pictures of water. "Look at that ocean. What a fascinating, that. Look at that lake, how beautiful that picture." He said that the whole point is to realize you're in the water. I spent my life looking at pictures of water when all the time I've been in the water. All the time I'm in God. So, sit and sink is his spiritual advice. I think it's, as I say, drawing off the implications of Aquinas. Let me try to show that to you.
- 5.21** I'm going to start with question 44 and follow in the first part of the "Summa Theologiae." So we're back to Thomas's masterpiece. But I'm also going to look at my disputed questions, the one that I worked on for my doctoral paper on "De Potentia Dei," "On the Power of God."
- 5.22** So the first issue here is whether God has power. Now, that can seem rather abstract, but if you've been following philosophy in the West for the last roughly 200 years, the question of power is enormously important. And if your eyes and ears are open to the world today, if you talk to almost any teenager in America, the question of power is extremely important. What power is? Who has power? What's power for? So listening to Aquinas on this, of God's power, like the prototype of power, is extremely illuminating.
- 5.23** So the objectors say that God has no power. But then there's the *sed contra* here, and it's interesting. The *sed contra*, which is typically from the Bible, is "God is able from these stones to raise up children to Abraham." Two things: the extent of God's power is

to raise up children of Abraham from these stones, but the focus and purpose of God's power is salvation. Salvation. God's power for Aquinas is not something arbitrarily exercised. It's always united to the love that He is. It's expressive of His love, not of domination, not of us against them, and I'm going to dominate you. No, no, no. He's going to raise up from these stones children to Abraham. The purpose of God's power is always salvific.

- 5.24** Also, this I love, in one of the questions on the incarnation, in the *tertia pars*, the third part, of the "Summa," Thomas argues, "There's nothing more powerful than that God became a human being." It's cool, isn't it, that the incarnation is the greatest expression of God's power. Yeah, because of how extraordinary it is, but also its salvific purpose. Why was God exercising his power that way? To save us. So whenever we play this game—and I'll touch on this a bit—of power to dominate, power to manipulate, power to assert my authority, that's not the way God uses his power. It's so strong in the Bible and in Thomas.
- 5.25** So in the *respondeo* to this question, whether God has power, now he's going to resolve it. Thomas affirms God's *potentia*, His "power," is absolute, unlimited. Why? Because He's simple, because He simply is. He's the sheer act of being itself. He has every perfection. So of course, the range of God's power is unrestricted, unlimited. There is nothing that God cannot do or accomplish. That seems to follow pretty clearly from His simplicity.
- 5.26** Now, following from this—and this always reminds me, in any catechism class or when you ever have a sophomore or a question from a high school kid, this usually comes up. "Therefore, can God do the impossible?" the objector asked. Kids for years, "Can God make a rock so big that even He can't lift it? Can God make a square circle? Can God do what's immoral? Can God do impossible things?" And here's Thomas's answer. God can do what's merely impossible from a natural standpoint. It's like, "I couldn't possibly do that, or no human being I know could possibly do that." But if something is logically consistent, logically possible, God could do it.
- 5.27** For example, the virgin birth. Is that logically impossible? No. It's something that I can't accomplish naturally or normally. How about "raising up children from these stones"? Well, no, it's unlikely. It's not something that any ordinary person could do, but it's not logically inconsistent.
- 5.28** However, what God can't do is what's strictly impossible. But don't be misled by language here—that's Aquinas' insight. "Oh, therefore, His power is limited." No, no, no. To say God's power is unlimited is to say God can do anything. God can accomplish anything that's consistent with being and with the integrity of His own nature. What he can't do is non-being. Can God make a square circle? No, because a square circle is just a non-entity. It's a type of non-being. I can use the term square circle, but it means nothing whatsoever.

- 5.29** Can God sin? It's a very interesting question to me. Thomas's answer was no, because it would be impossible to God to sin. How could the perfectly good being sin? We might be tempted to say, "Wait a minute. Then I'm more powerful than God because I can sin. I can do bad things, so I'm more powerful than God." No, no. Because sin is a type of non-being. Sin is a type of—I'll come back to that—it's a type of perversion. God can't do that. God can't do what's impossible. "He," Thomas says, "cannot make affirmation and negation simultaneously true or any of those things which involve any such impossibility." Can God make $2 + 2 = 5$? No, no.
- 5.30** Why is this important? Because he's holding off here something that has reared its ugly head throughout intellectual history and is very much alive today. What I mean is the danger of voluntarism— voluntarism, from the Latin word *voluntas*, meaning "will." A voluntarist would hold to the primacy of will over intellect. The primacy of will—and notice how that's connected to power—the primacy of power over intellect or over being.
- 5.31** A modern example is René Descartes, the founder of modern philosophy, the great rationalist. But Descartes said, "Why is $2 + 2 = 4$?" Because God determined that. God wanted that. God decreed that. Could God decree that $2 + 2 = 5$? Yeah, if He wanted to. And then it would be. Why is adultery immoral? Because God decided it should be immoral. He willed that. Could He will the opposite, that adultery is now a virtue? Yeah, I suppose. He's God, after all. He has complete *voluntas*. He has unlimited power, right? So He has power over logic. He has power over morality. God can do whatever He wants.
- 5.32** Aquinas is in radical disagreement with this voluntarism, and it's tied to the divine simplicity. You'll see why. When I say God is simple, God simply is. We can talk about attributes of God, like intelligence and will and power and immutability and eternity. But because God is simple, all those are the same. All are identical to God's way of being. But think of it as like a prism. If you took the white light in this room and you put it through a prism and it broke into a variety of colors, that's like immutability and perfection and knowledge and love and will and power. Our finite minds see the simplicity of God, but now broken into this variety of attributes. But in God Himself, because He's simple, they're all the same. They're all the same. God's knowledge is His will, which is His being, which is His immutability, which is His eternity, which is His perfection, all because of His simplicity.
- 5.33** What does voluntarism do? It separates out the *voluntas* of God, the will of God, from the being of God or from the mind of God. Thomas would say—and he is importantly right about this—God cannot do something that's repugnant to His own being. Why is $2 + 2 = 4$? Not because God arbitrarily decided, but because that reflects the integrity of the being that God is. It's a little minor reflection of the integrity of the divine truth. It's congruent with God's way of being. Why is adultery a sin? Because it's out of step with

the congruence of God's mind and will and reality. It's not limiting God's power to make this move. It's preserving it in its proper integrity.

- 5.34** The danger with voluntarism, and it's all over the place today, it's like this giant run wild, this unmoored giant who's now just expressing his voluntas and his power and his will. No, no. God's will—thank God, thank God—is congruent with His being and with His truth. Otherwise, He's a really dangerous devil. He's a dangerous, dangerous reality. But the reliability of God is grounded in this congruence.
- 5.35** I don't know if you remember the famous Regensburg Address that Benedict XVI gave. He'd been Pope only for a few years, and it became notorious because he made a comparison about Islam, and it's probably unfortunate the way he did it. But the burden of that talk was not about Islam; the burden of that talk was voluntarism. And Benedict XVI was saying that what Christianity embodies is the primacy of logos, not the primacy of voluntas. If you say voluntas, "will," has primacy, watch out, watch out, because then that's a hammer and everything else will be a nail. Boom, boom, boom. "I'm going to decide whatever I want."
- 5.36** When the New Testament says that Jesus is the incarnation of the logos, reason, the divine reason, and Christian theology insists upon the congruence of logos and will in God, now it's not like He's a hammer and everything else is a nail. Now the divine will is in line with the divine mind. Thank God. Thank God. That's Thomas Aquinas.
- 5.37** Go back to someone like Friedrich Nietzsche in the 19th century, I think the most influential 19th-century philosopher, more than Marx, on our time today. Nietzsche, who said, "God is dead." I agree with Jordan Peterson that he didn't say that in an exultant tone. He said that in a desperate tone. "God is dead, and we killed him." He thought that Western philosophy had moved in the direction of denying God. But he knew what followed from that. All that's left, therefore, is the will to power.
- 5.38** If God's gone, that means the anchor for our morality is gone, the anchor for truth is gone. What's left then? My will, asserting my own truth. Your will, asserting your own truth. Your will, asserting your own truth. What do we get then? The war of all against all, and no appeal possible to some objective truth by which we could measure our wills. For me to say, "No, no, what you want there is wrong. You shouldn't want that." Or, "What you're desiring, that's right. That's good." No, I can't do that. If God is dead, the ground of morality is gone, and all I'm left with is a bunch of hammers. Boom, boom, boom. Who's going to win? The biggest hammer, the most powerful hammer is going to win.
- 5.39** Look at our society today. I think the victory of Nietzsche, mediated by Michel Foucault, the great French philosopher—I say great because of influential. I don't agree with him at all. But he's a 20th-century version of Nietzsche, where he reduced everything really to plays of power. Our objective claims to truth and to morality are covers for what's really going on, for plays of power. If that's all it is, it's the war of all against all. It's a

bunch of hammers fighting each other. That, everybody, is the effect of voluntarism, seems to me. Aquinas in these—I know they can seem like dry text, but that's a very important clarification making here—that God can do anything, yes, but God's will is not reigning over his mind, but they come together. Thank God.

- 5.40** With that now, let's move to this question of creation from nothing. So we say in the technical language of the church that *creatio ex nihilo*, "creation comes from nothing." Now, why is that important? Look in ancient philosophies and mythologies. What do you find? Something like God or the gods fashioning the world out of some pre-existing stuff. In a lot of the old myths, there'll be a war of gods. They'll fight each other. And then from the bodies of the conquered gods, the world is constructed.
- 5.41** In the more philosophical accounts, like in Plato and Aristotle, something like matter exists from all time, and the gods shape it—that's Plato. Aristotle is: the prime mover is so preoccupied with himself, he's so interested in himself, self-thinking thought, but the matter is out there, and it's attracted to the prime mover and therefore shapes itself into the world that we know. God or the gods shaping pre-existing matter.
- 5.42** Can that be true of the real God? No. Why? Because God is *ipsum esse*, God is the sheer act of to be itself. That means there can't be anything that exists independently of God, that exists outside of the press of God. Whatever exists besides God must be utterly and completely dependent upon God. Therefore, He's not like an artist who's putting together a canvas and oil and color and so on, not like a carpenter who's taking wood and then shaping it in certain ways, not like Michelangelo sculpting the marble, because all those things would assume that the creator is one thing, and then there's something else out there that he works on. It can't be true of God if He's *ipsum esse*.
- 5.43** Rather, the whole of what exists apart from God must come in every detail and in every way from God. That's what it means to say God makes the world *ex nihilo*, from nothing, so not from anything else. He doesn't draw the world out of His own substance because He can't change; it's not that. Nor does He make it from anything pre-existing. But rather, through a sheer exercise of His power, God brings the world into being from nothing.
- 5.44** Now, let me just state a spiritual principle right away. What stands between us and God, therefore? Nothing. If He made the world from something, then there'd be something existing independently that God has related to. But if He makes the world from nothing, then there's nothing that stands between us and God. We are always already in relation to God in the most intimate and powerful way possible. Again, Meister Eckhart: am I climbing the Holy Mountain to get to him? Nah. I'm sitting and sinking. I'm realizing I'm already in the water. That's the spiritual implication of *creatio ex nihilo*.
- 5.45** Notice something, too; it's interesting here. Is creation a motion? Remember, we saw in the previous lectures that motion is the reduction of something from potency to act. So

there's something that's already out there that has potential to be something else, and that's how it moves. Well, is creation therefore a motion? No, because there isn't anything already out there which God is now going to change. So it's not a change. It's not like there wasn't creation, and then there was creation. No, that's the type of change. Is it in time? No, because time is a creature. Time is the measure of motion, Aristotle says. Mobile things have to be created, so time itself is a creature.

- 5.46** What was God doing before He created? Dumb question. There is no "before" He created. It's the wrong terminology. Time doesn't apply. Is it in space? No, no, because space is a creature. It's not like there's God, and then there's a big empty space, and then God gave rise to a world in that. No, no. Space itself is a creature.
- 5.47** Notice there's no escape. There's no escape. There's no escape. "Where can I run from Your love?" Remember, I cited the other day, Psalm 139? "Where can I run from your love? I climb to the heavens, You're there. I go to the end of the Earth, there You are." Yeah, I know, because that's what the Creator is like. He's inescapable because He makes from nothing.
- 5.48** There's no sooner or later when it comes to creation. It's not a question of time. Rather—and this is a phrase I've always loved in Aquinas—we should speak of *creatio continua*, "continual creation." Creation happened way back then, right? No, no, no. That's the wrong way to think about it. What about the Big Bang? Whatever the Big Bang was, that's not creation because the Big Bang is some hyper-concentration of matter and then blows up. Whatever that was, fine, describe it, and it's for the physicist. But that's not creation. Creation is *creatio continua*. It's the ongoing relationship between the Creator and creatures, the informing at every moment of the totality of a creature's being. That's creation: the here and now rapport between *ipsum esse* and beings. Let me put it that way: God, *ipsum esse*, the here and now rapport between God and beings, that would be creation.
- 5.49** Notice, too, that I think of Jean-Pierre de Caussade here, the 17th-century Jesuit spiritual master. He said that everything that happens, everything that happens, is directly or indirectly the will of God. Either God directly wanted it, or God permitted it. Whatever exists, whatever exists. There isn't like some space that God isn't touching. "God's concerned with things up there or things over there, but not things here." No, no. Whatever is. So our being here right now is directly or indirectly the result of the will of God, of God's continual creative presence to us. That's Aquinas.
- 5.50** That's why I cited Teilhard de Chardin yesterday, the story about him as a child, his famous line, "There's nothing profane for those who know how to see." So we speak of the sacred and the profane. And there's something right in that distinction. I get it. But ultimately, there's nothing profane for those who know how to see, that understand how God relates to the world.

- 5.51** Now, let's keep going, and things will get even more radical in a way. I remember in my doctoral paper saying that surprisingly, the doctrine of creation is as puzzling as the Trinity in some ways. It's as puzzling as we tease it out. Thomas will insist that creatures aren't so much substances standing over and against God. That's too much of God is here, then there's something out there, and then God relates to them. That can't be right. If creation is from nothing, it's continual. God is present to all things.
- 5.52** We have to say something like, "We are relationships to God." I know it's anomalous. We say, "No, no, I'm a substance, and I have a relationship to God." No, you are a relationship to God. You're in the water. You're not just looking at the picture of the water. You're in the water. You are here and now coming forth from God, and to realize that is revolutionary, I think, in your spiritual life. I refer to this as a metaphysics of the gospel. The more you lose yourself, the more you find who you are. The more you lose yourself in God, only in God is my soul at rest. The more I realize my groundedness in God, the more I become who I'm supposed to be, the more I cling to my prerogatives and my independence, and here I am over and against God, I've lost who I am. Surrender. You're already in the water. Surrender to God. That's the spiritual implication of creation.
- 5.53** Here's something from question three of "De Potentia [Dei]." I'd spend a lot of time, I remember, with this text. Thomas wonders in the *utrum*, whether creation is something really in the creature. It's a peculiar question, but is creation something that's really in the creature. He wants to know, if you want, like the locale of creation: where do we see creation happening? His answer is that it can't be something in between God and the creature. Because that's our problem. God's over there, then I'm here independent, then we have this relationship. That can't be it because in my totality, I've come forth from God. So what is it?
- 5.54** Here's Aquinas: "It's not an approach to being nor a change brought about by the Creator"—we saw that—"but only the beginning of being and the relation to the Creator from whom the creature has its being." It's almost like a Zen statement, isn't it? Here's the conclusion: "And thus, creation is nothing other than"—I'll say it in this lovely Latin first—"quaedam relatio ad Creatorem, cum novitate essendi." That means, so creation, where is it? What is it? Creation is *quaedam relatio*, it's "a kind of relation." *Quaedam* is one of those weasel words in a way—it's a kind of relation. *Ad Creatorem*, "to the Creator," *cum novitate essendi*, "with freshness of being."
- 5.55** Where is it? Where is creation? It's a kind of relationship. So the creature is a relationship always already grounded in God. "To the Creator," *ad Creatorem*, *cum novitate essendi*, *novitas essendi*, "newness of being, newness of being."
- 5.56** Remember Jesus with the woman at the well? "You come to this well every day, you drink, and you get thirsty, don't you? I want to give you the water bubbling up in you to eternal life." What does the Lord want to give her? He wants to give her this relationship to God. "You've been looking for love in all the wrong places. I mean,

you've been trying to find satisfaction in the goods of the world. It won't work. They'll always leave you thirsty. I want to give you water welling up in you to eternal life." Cum novitate essendi, with "newness of being," newness of being. Every moment, we are here and now being created by God. Every moment. I am always already a relationship to God. That's the radicality.

- 5.57** How about this from Gerard Manley Hopkins, the great Catholic poet, in his most famous poem? "There lives the dearest freshness deep down things," in his characteristically cryptic expression. "There lives"—so think if he's looking at the world—"there lives the dearest freshness"—novitas essendi, newness of being—"deep down things." If you look to the deepest ground of reality, the deepest ground of you, you're going to find this water welling up to eternal life, this freshness of being, being created by God moment to moment. So we're never that far from the freshness of being and renewal of life. That's the spiritual good news here.
- 5.58** Something else now. If this is all true, then everything in creation is related to everything else and by the deepest connection. So if we're living on the surface of things— I'm over and against you and there's cameras over there, and I'm going to leave this building—all that's true, true enough, as I'm looking at the surface of things. But if I go deep down, the dearest freshness deep down things, if I go deep down, what do I find? I find that my deepest center, where I am here and now being created by God, is your deepest center, and your deepest center, and your deepest center.
- 5.59** Think of Thomas's older, contemporary, Francis of Assisi, who spoke of brother sun and sister moon. You say that's sweet poetry. Well, maybe, but it's also pretty good metaphysics. The sun and the moon and the stars and the planets—think of Dante here—they're all our ontological siblings. They're all related to us by a bond deeper than any we can really imagine because we're all coming forth here and now from God.
- 5.60** Can I suggest that the ethics of the Sermon on the Mount can't really be understood apart from this metaphysical vision? Why in the world would you love your enemy? So Jesus says, "Love your enemy. Bless those who curse you. Pray for those who maltreat you." What? Why would I do that? Unless you realize that the one who's your enemy, and really is your enemy, let's say on the relative surface of things, in the deep down, is connected to you and is an ontological sibling to you. "Wow, okay, now I get why I should love even my enemy, why if someone strikes you on the right cheek, turn and give them the other. Someone presses you into service for a mile, go with them, too."
- 5.61** What are you signaling? That, yes, you're opposed to me, and yes, you're attacking me, and yes, you're my enemy, but I'm trying to signal to you and everybody else, there's a deeper bond. There's something deeper that we can appeal to. I think the ethics of the Sermon on the Mount is related to this metaphysics of creation.
- 5.62** I used the phrase already; I got it from Thomas Merton, the great Trappist writer from the last century. Merton was a Trappist monk, so a specialist in prayer, especially

contemplative prayer. Someone asked him one time, "What is contemplative prayer?" And he said, "Finding the place in you where you are here and now being created by God." That's right out of Thomas Aquinas, it seems to me. Right out of Thomas Aquinas, who Merton knew very well. Aquinas had a big influence on Merton becoming a Catholic and becoming a monk. Think about that. So when I find the place through a conscious act of the mind and the will, I find the place in me where I am here and now being created by God. That's contemplative prayer.

5.63 Now, I can live my life in many levels, relatively surface level and so on. But isn't it good from time to time to sit and sink, to find the place in you where you are here and now being created by God? That's Merton, and I think it's grounded in someone like Thomas Aquinas. It's being in the water, not looking at a picture of the water.

5.64 In the remaining minutes, let me do something a little quirky here, but I think it applies. James Joyce, the great Irish novelist, who was indeed formed as a Catholic and remained, I think, largely Catholic in sensibility, has that great autobiographical novel called "A Portrait of the Artist as a Young Man." It's about Joyce discovering his vocation to be a writer, to be an artist. There's a famous scene in that book where he's discussing the question of beauty with his friend, and he's using categories right out of Thomas Aquinas. He said, "Let me explain to you."

5.65 He said, consider that basket—he saw a woman going by in the marketplace with a basket on her head. And he said that first, you see it as circumscribed, as one thing set over and against the rest of the world. You isolate it; you see it as one. He said that, then you look at its component parts, how that basket is fitted together for its purpose and how it has a harmony and organization to it. And then finally, you exalt in its form. You exalt in the formal structure of it. What he's playing with there is, again, Aquinas. Aquinas says that the beautiful occurs at the intersection of three things: *integritas*, *consonantia*, and *claritas*, his Latin for "wholeness," "harmony," and "radiance." That's what Joyce was playing with.

5.66 So think of the basket on the woman's head: wholeness. I first see it as one. It holds together as one thing. *Consonantia* is the play of part against part, the harmony of the whole. I admire that. And then *claritas*, sometimes by that, Aquinas means literal brightness. I like brightness, clarity. It gets our attention. But Joyce knew that in the deeper text, Aquinas means the *claritas formae*, the clarity of form, that when the form of something shines, we say, "Ah, that's beautiful."

5.67 Now, I'm going to give you a dumb example—Joyce's is the basket on the woman's head—a golf swing. I'm a bad golfer. Please never, ever watch my golf swing. But when you watch a beautiful golf swing, Tiger Woods or Rory McIlroy or somebody, what do you notice is the *integritas* of it. It holds together as one. You look at any amateur golfer, if you sit by a golf course, just watch the golfers go by. Their swing is not about one thing. It's all over the place. It's disjointed. It doesn't hold together as one.

- 5.68 Watch Tiger, you notice the consonantia of the swing. I love when they do those things where they show a swing in slow motion, they play classical music behind it. It makes perfect sense because the harmony—don't watch me—the harmony of it is striking. You see how all the elements of it fit together: the shoulder turn and the position of the hips and the way you come down to the ball—again, don't watch me—consonantia.
- 5.69 And then finally, you watch Tiger or like Rory, and you go, "Oh, man, that's a golf swing. That is a golf swing." What you're noticing there is *claritas formae*, the clarity, the luminosity of the form. That's why when that's over, you go, "Beautiful, beautiful." Even when you watch a football game, and someone lays out for a catch in the end zone, it's beautiful. And it is. What you're noticing is *integritas*, *consonantia*, *claritas*. When you see a beautiful face, and you say, "What a beautiful person," you're noticing those three elements.
- 5.70 Aquinas thinks that God, the Creator, is an artist. He uses that image all the time. He's the general of an army—he uses that one, too, and I'll come back to that; he's organizing a bustling army for its purpose. But very often, he uses the metaphor of an artist. God makes the world, and as Genesis says, "He finds everything good and the ensemble of it, very good." Why? Because He wants the world to be a display of beauty. His own beauty is now made manifest in the splendor of the world. Part that splendor consists in the variegated quality of the world.
- 5.71 One of the questions is: why would God make a world that is so diverse and has got so much multiplicity? And why the zillions of fish in the ocean and birds in the air, and you walk along the ocean, the shells by their gazillion and stars by their gazillion. Why is there such a wild variety and diversity in creation? And the answer is: God wants the world to be at least a relatively adequate display of His own glory. He says that what one creature is not able to display, another one does. And so over space and over time, it's God, the artist, who is doing His great work of displaying His own glory.
- 5.72 I'm going to use this just to segue into the next lecture because you say, "Okay, I get a lovely idea, but the world isn't always beautiful," is it? The world can be a mess and a jumble. And now we get to the problem of God's providence.
- 5.73 So I've talked so far about creation, which is the most elemental modality of God's relation to the world. But once we have creation in place, now we have to talk about God's providence. How does God order the world that He has made toward an end? His ultimate purpose is, yes, indeed, to order it toward the beautiful. But what happens? And why does God permit even great evil and suffering to find its way into His beautiful creation? That'll be the topic for the next lecture.

Lecture 6: Providence and the Problem of Evil

At a glance — Providence and the problem of evil, mirroring Aquinas's own orderly method.

- 6.1** So we continue now by looking at God's Providence. I've been trying to mimic the orderliness of Aquinas' thinking. He was nothing if not orderly. Beginning with God and then the divine attributes culminating in the Trinity, and then seeing God giving rise to a world outside of Himself. So the next logical step is to look at God's providence. How does God provide for the world that He's made? How does God relate to that world? How does He direct it? So that's our next topic.
- 6.2** This will culminate, too, in the problem of problems. In some ways, the problem that gives rise to theology, which is the problem of evil and of suffering. I subscribe to that view that maybe if you trace it all the way back—theodicy, to give it this technical name, how to justify the ways of God in the presence of evil—is what gives rise to all of theology. It's the irritant in the oyster that gives rise to the pearl, trying to deal with this problem of: why is there so much dysfunction in a world, presumably created by an all-good, all-perfect God? So we'll come, at the end, to that problem, which, in a way like the Trinity, you'll end up, we're gesturing toward a solution without having a neat answer.
- 6.3** Can I provide for you first, though, a master metaphor that I hope hovers over this whole discussion of God's providence? Because I think when we get this wrong, a lot of problems ensue. Think of God in relation to the world as something like an author in relation to a novel. Just for the sake of argument, let's use Tolkien in relation to "The Lord of the Rings." So, "The Lord of the Rings"—I'm sure most have read or seen the movies anyway—sprawling, densely complicated narrative filled with all kinds of characters: human beings and orcs and wizards and elves and dwarves and all sorts of crazy stuff. All sorts of different landscapes and environments. A main plot, to be sure, and then tons of subplots all the way through. Characters galore. A richly complex novel. Its sentences are beautifully crafted.
- 6.4** What is Tolkien responsible for in "The Lord of the Rings"? Everything, every bit of it. Every character he imagined: main ones, little ones. Every plot he constructed: the main plot, subplots. Every sentence, every single one he wrote, every comma, every semicolon, every period, carefully chosen by the author. His providence over the world of that text is absolute.
- 6.5** Or like Dickens. Take Dickens in relation to one of his great novels, like Tolkien's: rich, dense, complex, crazy characters, names galore, subplots, main plots, period, semicolon. Think of Dickens in relation to "Oliver Twist." What's he responsible for? Every little possible detail of that book he's responsible for. Is there any bit of it that escaped his providence? No.

- 6.6 But is Tolkien anywhere in "The Lord of the Rings?" No. There's Gandalf, and there's Frodo, and there's Bilbo, and there's the orcs, and Saruman, and there's Tolkien—well, no; he's not a character in the story. You don't find Tolkien anywhere in the story. Dickens is a character in Oliver Twist? No, there's all kinds of characters, but you never meet him. Their providence is absolute, even as they let the story be, even as they themselves are not a fussy cause or character within the story. To my mind, that's the best metaphor we have for God's providence.
- 6.7 Is it absolute? Is God the author of the whole of being? Yeah, we just covered that, right? Creation, ex nihilo. There's nothing that stands between us and God. God is responsible for every nook and cranny of the world. There's no pre-existing stuff upon which He works, which therefore escapes His order. No, no. It all comes from Him continually. *Creatio continua*. It's *quaedam relatio ad Creatorem cum novitate essendi*. It's "a relation to the Creator with newness of being," moment to moment.
- 6.8 So you look at the world and you say, we're in this great novel, and God is writing it. God's responsible for it. At the same time, is God a causal agent within it like other causal agents? Is He one causal agent among many? Is He one character? "Oh, there He is. Here's a lot of people, and oh, there's God." No, He doesn't appear that way.
- 6.9 I'm going to shift the metaphor a bit. So this room was clearly designed by somebody. There was an architect who thought through this room. Every inch of it? Yeah, presuming there was one architect, let's presume there was. Yeah, and every little detail, he thought of it, designed it, laid it out. Where is he in the room? Well, he's everywhere in the room. I can see his mind everywhere. Maybe if I was really attuned to the architects in Phoenix, I could say, "Oh, yeah, I recognize another building like his." So his mind is everywhere. His hand is everywhere. But where is he in the room? I don't know. He's nowhere in the room. He's not here. He's not here.
- 6.10 It's something like that, I think, as you look at the great theologians reflecting on God. Is He in all things by essence, presence, and power? Most intimately so. Yeah, we saw that in a previous lecture. But yet He's not one being among many, not one fussy cause. Is He, in one sense, even as He utterly provides for the world, is He at the same time allowing the world to be according to its own causal patterns? Yeah.
- 6.11 I'm going to give you an example from the Bible. In some of the earlier sections of the Old Testament, God appears as like a human character. He's walking with Adam in the garden. Other times, He appears like one being among many. I would argue that's a relatively primitive level of revelation when people were conceiving God that way. But now go to, I think, a more sophisticated text like First and Second Samuel. I had the privilege some years ago of doing a commentary on 2 Samuel, so it's a text I know pretty well. It's about David. Saul and Samuel and David and Solomon. You look at that story as it unfolds about the kings and about jealousy and about wars and about economic struggles and imperial aspirations and all that's going on.

- 6.12** Can you read everything in that story from a political or economic or cultural standpoint? Yeah. In fact, God never appears as a character or as a voice. He's not a character. He's not in the story at all. You can read it, and believe me, commentators do. We read it from a purely political-economic standpoint. It makes perfect sense on its own terms. But yet, on every page of First to Second Samuel, the clear assumption is that God is working His purposes out, that God is acting, that God is involved, not as one character among many, but as the One who, in some weird way, is writing the whole of the story, even as He allows the particulars in the story to have their own integrity.
- 6.13** Now, keep something else in mind. Those are literary examples, historical examples. The thing I talked about earlier was of God relating to the world the way a cube relates to a square. Remember what I said? A square is in two dimensions. A cube is like a square now raised to a higher pitch. It's now a third dimension has been introduced. Then how many squares can fit inside a cube? Well, an infinite number. A cube can let an infinite number of squares be within its ambit.
- 6.14** God is not so much a being operating at the same level that we are, but the source of being, the ground of being, the Creator of all things, who can allow the world to have its own integrity, even as He operates ineluctably through it. I know it's paradoxical, but I think we have to think in terms of author to book, of square to cube, of the modal difference that obtains between the manner of God's causality and ordinary, worldly causality. The one lets the other be, even as it accomplishes its work. Keep all that in mind now as we look at these texts on God's providence.
- 6.15** I think where people get stuck is imagining God as a fussy being among many. Then how do I make sense of what He's doing and relating to me? Remember the Isaiah quote that Aquinas liked? "Lord, it is You who has accomplished all that we have done." Right. That's it. We've done it. We've done it. But Lord, you've accomplished it, working non-competitively and ineluctably through our own finite freedom and causality. Keep all that in mind. I think that's the master motif behind this, and I know it's tricky.
- 6.16** So let's look first at the question of the universality of God's providence in Aquinas now. So Tolkien to this book, Dickens to his novel, all that. So, is God's providence universal? Thomas says, "Yes." Many have argued, he says, philosophically, that God is provident over certain aspects of being, maybe the spiritual, maybe the higher things, maybe He's occasionally involved, maybe only at high abstract levels. No, no. Thomas believes the biblical view, and he cites the Book of Wisdom that "God orders all things sweetly, and His providence stretches from end-to-end mightily." That's the quote from Wisdom.
- 6.17** Thomas says, "Sure," because God is ipsum esse, not one being among many. He's the Creator who makes all things ex nihilo. Therefore, of course, He has to be involved in all the particulars of creation. His conclusion is that God's providence extends to particulars.

- 6.18** Over the years, I've given retreats to a lot of groups of priests, and I usually begin with a little opening, fervorino, and I'll say various things about the nature of a retreat. But one line I always cite is this one. I'll say, remember, Thomas Aquinas said that God's providence extends to particulars, meaning to us here and now, doing what we're doing right here. So I say to the priests, as we begin our retreat, "Remember God has brought us together, and God has drawn us for His purposes." I'll say it to you. I'll say it to people watching. God's providence extends to particulars.
- 6.19** We can try to hide from God. Remember, there's no grasping, no hiding. We can try to hide from God. "Oh, no, no, He's not concerned for me. He may be concerned with the Presidents and prime ministers, or maybe high levels, angels or something. He's not concerned about me." No, no. You can't get off the hook that easily. God is intimately involved in and concerned with all things at all times. Even the simple act of praying. We pray in Thanksgiving at a meal. You say, "Why are you wasting God's time? Are you bringing God into this little lunch you're having at Denny's or something?" Well, God's providence extends to particulars. God is providential over what's happening to you right now. So, of course, you should thank God at all times.
- 6.20** So the universality of it follows from God's nature. So is God any more intimately involved with an angel than with a worm? Not really. See, the angel participates more fully in the to-be of God. The angel has greater perfection than a worm. But God is no closer to an angel than to a worm. He's equally close to all expressions of finite being.
- 6.21** And then, keep this in mind, too, that we're not talking just about God as a force or principle. We've heard God has mind and God has will, and God has love. Therefore, His presence to all things is a loving, personal, knowing presence. Does God know what's going on right now? Of course. Does He care about it? Yeah, He does. Does He love us right now? Yeah, He does. Right now. Has He drawn us here?—I'll come back to this. Has He drawn us here? Yes, yes.
- 6.22** The spiritual implications, again, are very powerful to me. We can easily push God to a distance, play the deist game: He's way up there, out there, back there, or someplace. No, no, Aquinas won't let us. Right now, God is knowing and loving us as we do what we're doing.
- 6.23** Here's something else very interesting to me. It strikes me as pre-modern, and I mean that as a compliment. We're so obsessed with individuality, with the rights and freedom and prerogatives of the individual, and there's a lot of reasons for that. But certainly in the political philosophy that gave rise to our country, that's a major concern. But pre-moderns were not as obsessed with the individual. They had a keener sense, it seems to me, of the totality.
- 6.24** Here's something that Aquinas says in the third part of the Contra Gentiles. "Thus, among many of the things, what God cares for most is the order of the universe." It's interesting, isn't it? He does, of course, care for individuals, but what He cares for most

is the order of the whole universe. Now, this will be important when we think about the problem of suffering. What does God have most in mind? What is He most concerned about is the order and the good of the whole.

- 6.25** Here's where he uses that image of the general and his army, the general who pulls together an unruly army of soldiers to accomplish some great purpose. God is concerned with the great purpose of the entire cosmos. Again, we would tend to favor the individual, probably. If anything, the pre-moderns favor the universal. He loves—and I've cited a couple of times the Genesis remark that He finds individual creatures good, but He finds the totality of creatures very good. Again, keep this in mind when we get to the problem of evil.
- 6.26** What does God say to Job? When Job says, "Why am I suffering? Why did you give this to me?" What does God do but He gives Job this great tour of the whole universe. "Where were you, Job, when I did that? Where were you?" That biblical instinct for the totality, I think Aquinas honors here.
- 6.27** Now, Dickens and Tolkien, keeping them in mind, how do we avoid the problem of divine domination, divine dominance? First of all, that God doesn't need the world. So, He's not interested in dominating. He doesn't have any need to do it. His entire purpose vis-à-vis the world is loving. And I don't mean that sentimentally; I mean it as a metaphysical claim. His entire purpose vis-à-vis the world is to let it be and to will it good. So, don't worry right away about this providential God that controls all things is dominating us. No, no. His control is a directing toward the good for the good of the universe.
- 6.28** And then secondly, it's the author to book thing. Don't think of it as God manipulating other individuals, but letting the totality of it be in such a way that all the individuals can accomplish their purpose even according to their own powers. But He allows the totality to be. That's the better way to think about it.
- 6.29** Who was it who used the example of baking a cake? It was a theologian I was reading recently. How do you bake a cake? Well, you need flour and you need water and you need the heat of the oven and various things. Would you ever say, "I need sugar and flour and God and the heat of the oven?" No, you need all those things, and that's sufficient to describe how you bake a cake. But when you finish the cake and you eat it, do you say, "Hey, thank God. Thank God for that cake." Yeah, of course. Not as though He's one of the ingredients that made the cake, but He's the condition for the possibility of all those elements coming together in such a way that the cake exists.
- 6.30** So that's why we can acknowledge both at the same time, acknowledge the square and the cube, because the cube isn't dominating the square; it's allowing a million squares to be. That's how we think about divine providence, I think.
- 6.31** Now, I want to cut to this. Well, let me cite John Paul II here. John Paul II, the great Pope, said, "For people of faith, there are no coincidences." "Hey, I happened to run

into this person. What a nice coincidence." Hey, this just happened to me. What a nice, happy chance." Here's Aquinas's answer, and John Paul II was very Thomistic: yes, when read from the standpoint of particular causality, I can say that, meaningfully, like, "Hey, it just happened. Good luck. I ran into this guy. What a happy coincidence." Fair enough. You can say it that way when looking at things superficially. But notice what he says, "For people of faith, there are no coincidences."

- 6.32** Here's Thomas Aquinas's example. He says to imagine a king, and a king sends a messenger to do something, and he sends another messenger around the other way to do something. And his purpose, the king's purpose, is for the two of them to meet because he has a deeper goal in mind. And so he sent them without their knowing, and they run into each other. "Hey, good to see you. What a happy coincidence. And yeah, we can work together on this." For them, a coincidence. Yeah, fair enough. And it was for them. Not for the king. The king, from a higher point of advantage, knew exactly what he was doing as he was ordering these things.
- 6.33** For people of faith, put in Thomistic terms—for people who are keenly aware of the providential God—there are no real coincidences. Again, remember Jean-Pierre de Caussade, "Whatever happens to us is either directly or indirectly the will of God." I would suggest, everybody, your life will change in the measure that you take that in. In the measure that you really believe that, your life will change. Whatever happens to me, good or bad, is somehow, directly or indirectly, the will of God. For people of faith, there are no coincidences. Interesting.
- 6.34** Now, let me cut to the chase to, I think for us, the most interesting example of this general principle, which is human freedom. So you say, "Following this God, creation, providence, author, book, I get that. But doesn't it make us into like, puppets and marionettes here? God's just working His purpose out. And in fact, Bishop, doesn't your example of the book give away the game? Look, Tolkien is totally controlling all the action here." Yes, the analogy limps at that point. Let me try to explain this in Thomistic terms.
- 6.35** Freedom. What about my freedom? We're moderns, all of us, willy-nilly. We're very influenced by modernity. Modernity had an idea of freedom that goes something like this: freedom means my capacity to make a choice without coercion, exterior or interior. I decide. It's the freedom of choice. That's not classical freedom. That's not what biblical or classical people meant by freedom at all. Rather, they meant something like this: freedom is the ordering of desire in such a way that the achievement of the good becomes first possible and then effortless. Let me say that once more: freedom, authentic freedom, is the ordering of the will in such a way that the achievement of the good becomes first possible and then effortless.
- 6.36** Example: I'm standing in front of you as a pretty free speaker of English. I can say pretty much whatever I want in English. I've studied a lot of foreign languages in my life. I'm not all that good at any of them. When I was learning them, I always felt like a captive. I

felt unfree. I knew what I wanted to say. I remember being around like seminar tables in Paris when I was doing my doctoral, early years, doing my doctoral work, and I knew what I wanted to say. I had all these fancy francophones around me or just carrying on. I knew what I wanted to say, but darn it, I couldn't say it. I didn't have the freedom that I had in English.

- 6.37** Or if you learn a musical instrument, when you're first starting, you're just, "I can't do anything. I can barely play this thing. These songs are all too much for me." But then, as you take it in, you become freer and freer. And by the end, you can play whatever you want. That's not spontaneous choice freedom, like "Hey, play whatever you want. Speak any way you want. You can't speak French? Don't worry about it. Just make up your own language." That's not it. It's rather so interiorizing the rules of language and the grammar and the syntax and vocabulary that it becomes so second nature to you that the achievement of that good now becomes effortless.
- 6.38** Playing the piano—"I can't do anything. But now I'm free. I can play any type of music I want." Because I've chosen to play any way I want? No, because I've interiorized the rules of music, and it's in my hands now and in my mind. It's become so part of me that the achievement of the good now becomes effortless. I'm free. We won't understand this if we see Thomas in modern terms, that freedom means spontaneous choice. No, no. The ordering of the will or ordering of desire in such a way as to make the achievement of the good first possible and then effortless.
- 6.39** Does God want us to be free? Yes, yes. But what does it look like? It looks like getting rid of the distractions and attachments that are keeping us from achieving the good that God wants us to achieve. It's not increasing my capacity for choice. It's getting rid of the things that are distracting me from the good that I should be achieving. In that way, the providential God is luring our freedom so as to achieve what He wants us to achieve. It's His goal, but it's to make us happy. You're choosing something, you're choosing the good, and God is the ultimate good, and He wants to lure you in that direction. He's making you more free by putting Himself more clearly in the way of your will and luring and drawing it toward Him.
- 6.40** Here's a concrete example. Everyone knows that I'm a bad golfer, but I like golf. Here we are in Phoenix. Suppose someone told me this afternoon, "Tiger Woods is going to be at the TPC Stadium Course in Phoenix. He'll be there at one o'clock. You know what? I talked to him. He's going to give you, if you want, a half-hour lesson, Tiger Woods." I'm going. I don't care what's going on. I'll cancel it. Of course, I'll be there.
- 6.41** Now, suppose that person that made the arrangement for another reason just wanted me there. He wanted me at the TPC Stadium Course, maybe to meet someone else. I don't know. But his purpose was to get me there. And by God, he got me there. How? By knowing what I wanted, what I would desire, and then arranging things in such a way as to almost guarantee that I would go.

- 6.42 Let's say I show up at the TPC and there's Tiger Woods and all that. I'm delighted. Would you ever say, "That guy is not there freely. He didn't go freely to a TPC Stadium Course." No, of course, I went there freely. And yet that other person who made the arrangement got what he wanted. He got me where he wanted me to go.
- 6.43 Or another one: anyone that knows me, knows I love Bob Dylan. In fact, Bob Dylan, as we record these words, is coming to my hometown of Rochester, Minnesota, in about a month or so for a concert. But let's say today someone said, "Bob Dylan's in town in Phoenix for a concert, and believe it or not, he's willing to have a cup of coffee with you right after you finish these lectures. He's going to be right down the street." I'm there. I don't care if the Pope is calling me. I'm going to go to see Bob Dylan.
- 6.44 Let's push it further. Let's say the person who wanted to get me there for some reason had looked at my calendar, talked to my assistant, made absolutely sure there was nothing that would prevent me from going. And so I go. Of course, I go, and I see Bob Dylan, and I accomplish what that person wanted me to accomplish. Had I gone there unfreely? Was I being coerced? Well, no. My freedom was being lured by a good placed in front of me that ineluctably drew me to that end.
- 6.45 Now, God, who knows everything about everything, knows me better than I know myself, understands my motivations utterly, can arrange circumstances any way He pleases. If God wants me to do something or wants me to go somewhere or wants something to happen, can He make it happen? Yeah. He's the providential God whose providence extends to particulars. But in that process, would He be undermining my freedom? No. He was awakening and luring and drawing my freedom.
- 6.46 Again, this is where the Tolkien analogy is going to limp because he's dealing with just characters he's made up. I'm a character that God has made up, but I'm endowed with mind and will. And so God doesn't deal with me the way He deals with a rock. He deals with me in this alluring manner.
- 6.47 Let me give you a little taste of this because it's some of this high-octane theology that I love. This was a big debate right after the Reformation because they were very interested in this question of how is God involved and how much are we involved and grace versus nature and law and all this stuff. So there were huge debates, Protestant and Catholic, around this. There was a fellow named Luis de Molina who made a huge contribution to this question in a very interesting way. Molina introduced the idea of God's middle knowledge. What does he mean?
- 6.48 Well, God has knowledge of what will be. God has knowledge of what could be. But in the middle of those two, "middle knowledge," *scientia media*, he calls it, God has knowledge for all eternity of what would be. What would be. God has subjunctive knowledge. What would happen if in 2026, I put Bob Dylan at the cafe and Bishop Barron were there? What would happen under those circumstances? "That's what would happen." God knows that. What would happen if Bob Dylan wasn't there?

Something else. What would have happened if Tiger Woods couldn't have made it that day? What would happen if he were there? God, in his middle knowledge from all eternity, can survey all these possibilities.

- 6.49** What I and all of you would do freely, God can see. The world that God wants, which involves what we would all do freely, He surveys them all and says, "Okay, that's the world I want." He ratifies the world in which we all freely accomplish what God wants. God's providence is extending to particulars, our freedom being preserved because God has just seen what would happen, what we would do freely, and that's the world that He chooses to ratify. It was Molina's way of dealing with this problem of providence being too domineering, and then providence not being domineering enough. The middle knowledge allows him to say both and.
- 6.50** If you want to have fun, if you know any Dominicans or Jesuits, just put the word Molina in there. Molina was a Jesuit, and then the Dominicans and Jesuits thought about this. But I think it's a very interesting proposal. It's in this space I've been trying to describe how both types of causality are operative, God's and ours, in a non-competitive way.
- 6.51** But also keep that freedom idea. I'm deriving that from a Dominican scholar called Servais Pinckaers, who distinguished between what he called freedom of indifference—that's modern freedom—"I say yes or no, and based on no coercion, it's just my free choice," versus what he called freedom for excellence. That's the one I'm talking about, when I'm being ordered toward the good. Freedom for excellence is what Thomas is talking about, and that's what fits into God's providence.
- 6.52** With that, in the remaining minutes, let's at least broach this question of evil, of suffering. So you're following me: "I get it. God, creation, providence, different modes of causality. God's providence extending to particulars. Okay, okay, okay. Even God's middle knowledge, what would happen. So He ratifies the world that He wants. This is the world He wants? This one, the world that we actually live in, is the world that God somehow has permitted?" Go figure.
- 6.53** I'm speaking now to you as a priest, too, who has done a lot of pastoral work over the years. Most people don't come to you and ask you about the essence-existence distinction. Theological nerds like me are interested in that. But people come to you all the time when you're a priest with deep, deep theological questions. They usually have to do with providence and the problem of evil, usually in the form of, "How could God have allowed this? Father, explain to me: how is God involved? This God you've been talking about, of love and creativity and involvement in our lives, makes us out of love, wants us to flourish. Beautiful, Father. But come on, we're in the real world here. How do you explain it?"
- 6.54** I'll tell you a story. This is from many years ago. I was a young priest, and I preached this homily, and I thought it was pretty good. It was about providence and the beauty

of the world and what God does. All these people streamed past me. "Oh, thanks, Father. What a great homily." Then, up to me came this man, an older man, and he said—I didn't recognize him; he was a visitor to the parish—and he said, "Yeah, Father, I got a theological question. I tell you, that homily did not help." I said, "Tell me."

- 6.55** And then, he told this terrible story about his granddaughters. He was a grandfather with two granddaughters, and one developed this disease that the doctors barely understood. All they knew was that she would become blinded from it, and then she would die. She was in the throes of this when the second granddaughter developed, because of genetic predisposition, the same problem. And he said, "Now my younger granddaughter cries in her bed at night, fearing that she will go blind soon and then will die."
- 6.56** So this is Sunday morning, and I'm there greeting people, "How about those Bears?"—I'm from Chicago. And then, that story unfolded. I always think of him as embodying the great *cri de cœur* of the human race, the great cry of the heart before God when there's terrible suffering. And look, we all face it in different ways. Every human being, we all face it sometimes, this question of suffering. How do we deal with it?
- 6.57** Can I give you John Stuart Mill's famous argument, which is basically an argument against God? He says that if evil exists, and surely it does, then God cannot be omniscient, omnipotent, and omnibenevolent. Because if he's omniscient, he'd know about it. If he's omnipotent, he could do something about it. If he's omnibenevolent, he'd want to do something about it. So what the heck? If there is evil, there can't be such a God. Maybe there's some God or some first principle up there, but He can't be the God you people are describing, that knows all things, loves all things, and is all-powerful. It can't happen.
- 6.58** That's a powerful argument. That's a powerful argument. A lot of people, including that grandfather, who came up to me, maybe they wouldn't have formulated it quite that elegantly, but that's what he was feeling. Well, can I give you one now from Saint Thomas Aquinas? Remember, I told you he steelmans the arguments of his opponents. He doesn't give you a weak version of them. He doesn't do it. In the famous question, *utrum Deus sit*, "whether there's a God," we looked at the arguments he gave for the proposition; he looked at a number of objections.
- 6.59** One of them is this: "If one of two contraries be infinite, the other would be altogether destroyed. Thus, if there were an infinite heat, there'd be no cold." That's his example. But God is called infinitely good. Therefore, there should be no evil. But there is evil. Therefore, God does not exist. May I say, darn good argument. That's a darn good argument. It anticipates John Stuart Mill by several centuries. So again, Thomas is not blind to this problem. He's deeply aware of it, as all great theologians are.
- 6.60** So you might wonder, what's his answer? Let me just say it to you first, then we'll try to develop a little bit. Here's his answer to that objection: "Since God is the highest good,

He would not allow any evil to exist in His works, unless His omnipotence and goodness were such as to bring good even out of evil." He's riffing on Augustine there, where Augustine said many centuries before Aquinas that God allows certain evils to bring about goods that wouldn't otherwise exist. But again, listen, "Since God is the highest good, He would not allow any evil to exist in His works, unless His omnipotence and goodness were such as to bring good even out of evil." God permits evil so as to bring about a good that could not be brought about in some other way, and that's the fundamental answer.

- 6.61 Here's the first thing to notice that's exceptionally important in this discussion. Evil for Aquinas and for the great Christian tradition is not something positive. It's not a principle that stands equally against the good. Rather, evil is described in Latin as a *privatio boni*, it's a "privation of the good," not something substantial. Evil is always a privation, a lack of a good that ought to be there. Think of a cavity in a tooth. Whenever I go to the dentist, I think of a cavity in the tooth. It's a deformation of the tooth. Tooth is good, but there's a lack. Think of cancer that's compromising an organ. The organ is good. The cancer is the lack or the compromise of it. Think of moral turpitude, that your will and your mind and your behavior are the good, but the immorality is a twisting or corruption of that good.
- 6.62 Do you remember—I'll go back to Tolkien again—remember the Nazgûls are these wicked, I don't want to call them creatures because they're flying around and they're the capes and everything. But when they hit the ground or they're killed, it's revealed that there's nothing there. They're nothing, surrounded by these capes. It's Tolkien's commentary on this issue, that evil is a type of non-being. It's a corruption.
- 6.63 So we should never talk about God creating evil, nor should we speak of evil as a coequal principle facing God down. So don't play—I mean, Star Wars is the latest embodiment of it, the very old dualistic cosmologies. They go way back, gnostic forms of them, even before gnosticism. Star Wars is a good example. Light side of the Force, dark side of the Force. Who's going to win? I don't know. It's just a great battle between the two. I know that's always superficially attractive because it makes sense of a lot of things. It's this battle going on. But we must never think of evil as some coequal principle that's facing God down. Evil is a *privatio*, it's "a lack."
- 6.64 You say, "What about the devil? What about dark spiritual powers?" Yeah, but the devil is fundamentally good, meaning in his being, his will, his mind. The trouble is the perversion of all that, is the twisting, is the corruption of all that. That's what's evil about it. The devil is not some coequal metaphysical principle that faces God down.
- 6.65 What does Saint Paul say? "Where sin abounds, grace abounds the more." That's a moral statement, but also it's a metaphysical statement. Whatever sin you'll name, whatever deformation, there's always a greater good. It's an exceptionally important principle, metaphysically, but also morally, to keep in mind, lest we're beguiled by evil. We think it's some coequal principle. It's not. It's a lack.

- 6.66** But this still begs the question: why would God allow such lacks and imperfections to obtain within His creation? You know what is actually from a biblical standpoint, cool to think about is, what's the snake doing in the garden? Here's God makes Adam and Eve in the garden, and everything's great. Well, what the heck is the snake doing there? Why is there this principle of corruption? I'll leave that for the moment.
- 6.67** Here's a way to test this principle. Chesterton says this, that you can think about good without thinking about evil. You can think about God, who's surely good. But you can't think about evil without thinking about good. So you can't. Evil doesn't exist on its own. It exists only parasitically upon the good. You can't think about it without thinking about the good. That shows you its derivative parasitical quality. I love this, from Chesterton. He says that yes, the problem of evil is vexing indeed. Everyone knows that. But the only problem that's more puzzling is the problem of the good. Why should there be good at all? That's more puzzling than the problem of evil. It's his way of stating the primacy of good over evil.
- 6.68** But again, still, the question remains, "All right, I get it, but why would God permit this to happen in His creation?" Well, the principle: He allows it to bring about some greater good. Let's look at that in terms of what the tradition calls physical evil and moral evil, two basic types.
- 6.69** So first of all, moral evil, which is always easier to deal with. Moral evil: Hitler, Stalin, the great sinners who've wreaked havoc in the world, some wicked person that made your life difficult, your own moral evil, your own turpitude. Why would God permit that? An answer is—it might seem a little too simple, but I think it's stating the basic fact—God allows that so as to permit freedom. If God wants people that will really love Him and not just be marionettes, He must allow for freedom. But to say freedom is to say the possibility of an abused freedom.
- 6.70** And so you say, "Why would God permit Hitler?" Because He wants human freedom to obtain, He wants us not to be marionettes. That means He accepts, He permits in His creation this corruption of our wills. Okay, that one's relatively easy to deal with.
- 6.71** The really hard one was called physical evil. So think here, the grandfather with the two granddaughters. Why? Why? These two kids are not wicked people. These two kids get this horrible disease, and now they're screaming in terror at night. Why? Why? The earthquake that kills a thousand people or 10,000 people. The disease that takes the life of a little kid. The physical evil is the most confounding in a way.
- 6.72** The principle: God allows certain suffering, certain evil, to bring about a good that wouldn't otherwise obtain. Can we sometimes see this? Yeah, I think so, sometimes. Something evil happens, a great illness or a loss, which opens you to a new vision or to a new possibility. Something in you is enhanced spiritually, having gone through that suffering.

- 6.73** I think years ago, in counseling people, and like, "Oh, Father, the job, the job that I wanted, I didn't get it. I'm so mad. Why wouldn't God let me have that job?" But then two years later, "This other job opened up that was so much better and has set my life in such a great direction." "That person, I wanted to marry her, and she dumped me, and I'm going through such terrible suffering." Yeah, and then four years later, you found the woman of your dreams that you're married to. So, yeah, sometimes we can see evil happen, bad things happen, but they opened up to something good.
- 6.74** Can we always see it? I can't. I can't. Who's a great biblical example, and I've alluded to him already, is Job. The Bible knows all about this. Something I find wonderful with the New Atheists and the Old Atheists, too, "The problem of evil, and you religious people have never really come to terms with that." Give me a break. The two greatest texts on the problem of evil are the Book of Job in the Bible and "The Brothers Karamazov," it seems to me, the great Christian-Russian novel. Christians are very comfortable in a way, dealing with this problem. It's right at the heart of our very sacred text.
- 6.75** What do you find in Job, Job who endures every possible suffering? To rub it in, Job is righteous. He's the righteous man. According to the Book of Deuteronomy, if you follow the divine law, He'll reward you. That makes sense. If you're a bad guy, God will punish you. Good guy, He'll reward you. Job is like, perfect. He's great. He's wonderful. And yet every possible negativity falls upon him. And his wife, Mrs. Job, has the famous line: "Curse God and die." What are you doing here? Not really helpful pastorally.
- 6.76** And then, Job's friends come, and they sit with him for seven days in silence. Really good. I always told my students at the seminary, "Watch them in the early moments of their pastoral intervention. It's really good to sit with a suffering person in silence. The trouble is when they open their mouth, these three friends. What they engaged in were different versions of what I call the Deuteronomistic principle, Book of Deuteronomy. If you're good, you'll be rewarded. If you're bad, you'll be punished. The arguments are basically, "Job, I know you think you're righteous, but you must have done something wrong. For all this to happen to you, there's something you did wrong." Job: "No, no, no." He retains his innocence, and he's right. He is righteous.
- 6.77** Finally, he dismisses the three friends. And then, in maybe the most dramatic scene in the whole Old Testament, he calls God into the dock. "Explain yourself. Explain yourself. Why would you have done this to me?" And then, famously, the whirlwind comes, the desert whirlwind, and out of the whirlwind—because a whirlwind is doing what? Kicking up the sand. It's lime incense, like I can't see clearly. "Job, you think you got it figured out, but you don't." And then out of the whirlwind comes the voice of God, and it's the longest speech by far of God in the entire Bible. So it's very important to listen to that.
- 6.78** Of course, what does He do? He doesn't say, "Job, here it is. Let me explain to you. Evil is the privation of the good." He didn't do that. As I mentioned before, He takes Job on a great tour of His creation. "Where were you when I laid the foundations of the world?"

Where were you when I told the sea this is where you should come to an end? Where were you when the animals gave birth? Where were you?" And he takes on this great tour of all these things that Job probably has never thought about. The implication: "But they're all part of my providence, Job. They're all part of the great story that I'm writing. I know you're hyper-focused on your own suffering right now, and understandably," but He breaks him out of that narrow consciousness into an awareness of the entire topography of creation.

6.79 And then, there's a dramatic moment. He says, "Job, have you considered my creatures Behemoth and Leviathan?" Who are they? They don't know for sure. They could be like a crocodile and maybe a whale. We don't know, but they're some—He describes these mighty, strange creatures that live in the depths and in the distant corners of the world, creatures that Job probably has never imagined, never thought about. And God says, "If you look at them, how beautiful they are and how impressive they are," in other words, "Job, there's so much going on in y creation and your life, which I love. In reverence, you're my beloved creature. But you're part of a story. You're part of a book that's infinitely larger than your chapter." That's the divine strategy for dealing with the problem of suffering. It's not to give an answer because he probably couldn't take it in.

6.80 I told this story before; it's also from my pastoral experience: a young dad had a son who was about three, and I forget what it was, but the son had some very serious illness, and it required surgery. So the little boy goes in, had the surgery, successful enough, but afterwards was in great pain, the little kid. And his dad said, "I sat there next to him, and he was crying in pain, and he was looking to me like, 'Why are you doing this to me? Somehow you're involved in this. You're my father. I thought you loved me, and yet here you are presiding somehow over this.'" The kid wasn't saying that, but that's what his look said to his father.

6.81 The father came to me and said, "What was so frustrating was that even if I wanted to, I couldn't really explain it to him. 'Well, it's surgery, and they have to go in, and they have to do this and take this organ out, and it's going to hurt for a while.' But this is a little kid, two and a half or three years old. I couldn't explain it to him, even if I wanted to." I remember when he told me that story, I thought, "That's God in the Book of Job." Job crying out, as we all do at different times, "Why? Why? Why?"

6.82 Is there an answer? The Father had an answer. He did, but he couldn't even, in principle, explain it to his son because his mind was just not capacious enough to take it in. So God, taking Job on the great tour of the Cosmos, opening up to all the contours of the story that God's writing. What's God concerned with? All of space and all of time, all of it.

6.83 You know those things where you play chess at different levels? There's a chessboard at different levels, and people play this complex game, but it's related to that game. How many chess games is God playing? Infinite variety of games. Where are you? Well, you're on one of these chessboards. From your perspective, it's just dumb suffering.

That's all this is. But is it part of a complex of God's providential design that even if He wanted to, He couldn't fully explain it to you?

- 6.84** So what's the answer? Surrender. Remember, I said the God that can't be grasped but can't be hidden from. Well, that's the God that speaks to Job. Job can't hide from that God, but Job can't grasp Him either. An acceptance in love and in faith that God is about the business of perfecting the world that He's made, that's probably the best we can do in this most painful problem that's at the heart of God's providence. Thanks.
- 6.85** I know that you've studied Paul Tillich and Thomas Aquinas. Tillich, I view as the modern liberal theology and Thomas as classical theology. What did you learn from both, and what have you taken from those two? Because I feel like they're fairly divergent.
- 6.86** They are. Well, they're similar in this way: they both use philosophy and theology, both like the language of ontology. So that attracted me to Tillich. He reminded me there of Aquinas. I learned from Tillich a Christological way to read metaphysics. So he's a Protestant, which means he's going to lead more with the biblical and the Christological. And he read classical ontology in a more Christological way. That prompted me to look at the Christological texts of Aquinas and to use them to interpret the metaphysical ones. So that was my doctoral paper, and it was very much influenced by Tillich.
- 6.87** Tillich, too, was a chaplain in the First World War. He was up against the worst of humanity. He did a theology, he said, for people whose world had collapsed. So it was a very existential theology in touch with Freud, in touch with modern psychology. He blended the psychological, spiritual, and biblical with the ontological. I use that as a way to get into Aquinas a bit more deeply. So, I appreciated him very much.

Lecture 7: Aquinas's Anthropology

At a glance — Aquinas's anthropology — the philosophical and theological account of the human person.

- 7.1** We've come to Lecture 7 out of eight. I'll be looking at this question of what's called philosophical or theological Anthropology in Aquinas. Now, it's not Margaret Mead-type methodology. It's a look at the human being in the light of God. That's theological or philosophical anthropology.
- 7.2** Now, before I get to that, a couple of things occurred to me as I was preparing for this. One is, I didn't want to leave you completely in a lurch in regard to that grandfather I told you about yesterday. We were looking at the problem of suffering. The grandfather came up to me and told me about his two granddaughters with this terrible disease, and he's wondering: why would God have done this? He's haunted me ever since. He was a visitor to the parish, so I never saw him again. I have no idea what happened to him or the granddaughters. But his story has stayed in my mind all these years.
- 7.3** What did I tell him that day? I think it maybe was a little grace of the Holy Spirit. I said to him, "I don't have an answer. I don't know why God is allowing this." Then, I said to him, "But I do think you're on a very holy quest." Because he said to me, "I've been on a quest trying to understand this." He said, "I've talked to priests, to rabbis, and ministers, and philosophers," and he said, "Your homily didn't help today." I said, "I don't have an answer, but I think the quest is a holy one," because he didn't give up on God. He didn't say, "My granddaughters are suffering, therefore, I don't believe in God. I reject God." No, no. He was like Job. He was angry with God. He was getting on the list with God. He was wrestling with God. And that's a holy thing to do.
- 7.4** That, I think, is the great wisdom of the Bible. The Bible doesn't give you a pat answer to that question. Job doesn't get a pat answer from God. He gets that cosmic contextualization of his question, "Where were you?" Maybe that's the best we can do. We're drawn into the space somewhere in between acknowledging the fidelity of God, the goodness of God, and the inscrutability of God at the same time. You can resolve it easily by just saying, "Oh, God's all good, and good people are rewarded, bad people are punished." Well, we all know that's too simplistic. Or you just say, "No, there's no God at all. The world makes no sense." Neither one.
- 7.5** The Bible draws us into the space where we say yes to God's fidelity. But man, is it an inscrutable fidelity. How it's playing itself out, I don't know. But again, with Job in mind, what's the likelihood that we, with our exceptionally narrow grasp of reality— think of what we can see and understand of the world, this little tiny bit—that we're going to understand the intentions of the author of the entire universe. What are the odds that we're going to get it?

- 7.6 It's been compared to a great novel, let's say, and the pages have all been taken out of the book and now scattered to the wind, and you happen to pick up, maybe it's a ripped single page of that novel, and you're reading a little tiny section of it, and you say, "I don't know what this is. It doesn't make any sense at all." I know. It's part of a chapter, which is part of a book that you don't even know about. That's the biblical way of approaching this question of suffering. God is faithful, and God is inscrutable, and we live in that space with it. So I didn't want to leave you completely in the lurch about the grandfather and what I said to him.
- 7.7 The other thing I was thinking about as I was preparing for today is never forget— as we go through these highly philosophical texts of Aquinas, so think of the Trinitarian reflections and all his thinking about the nature and the attributes of God—never forget that young kid who spent nine years in a Benedictine Monastery, immersed in the Bible and in the Psalms in the rhythm of prayer. Don't forget this young Dominican when his brother tried to rip the habit off his back and he clung to it tenaciously. Don't forget this young man who was imprisoned by his own family for a year and during that time read the Bible to the point where he memorized large parts of it. Don't forget that every single day this Catholic priest, Dominican friar, celebrated Mass and then assisted at a second Mass and rarely got through either one without copious tears. My point is that Thomas indeed uses lots of philosophical language, but it's always in service of the Bible. It's always in the service of what was open to him through the pages of the Bible.
- 7.8 What comes to mind here is the great definition of theology proposed by Saint Anselm. I mentioned him now a couple of times, the author of the ontological argument, a century and a half before Aquinas. But Anselm characterized theology as *fides quaerens intellectum*, "faith seeking understanding." What comes first is faith, *fides*. But then we've got these restless minds that God gave us, and so faith always seeks to understand. It seeks greater insight and wisdom. To do that, use philosophy, sure. Use the sciences, of course, whatever works, as your restless mind is seeking to understand the faith more profoundly. So, as Aquinas uses all this philosophy, don't forget how anchored he is in the Bible and in revelation. I want to make sure I just got that point out before I go any further.
- 7.9 Following the orderly mind of Thomas Aquinas, we've seen his approach to God. We've then seen his development of the attributes of God culminating in this doctrine of the Trinity, God's Triune nature. And then we saw, God, who is love, God who is goodness itself, *bonum diffusivum sui*, "the good is diffusive of itself," and so God pours out creation, not out of need, but out of sheer generosity, sheer love.
- 7.10 And then we saw that since God is present to all things, He's in all things by essence, presence, and power, and most intimately so, that means He's present to it with mind and will and with love and with purpose; therefore, God is providential vis-à-vis His creation. We've been following this orderly presentation of Aquinas.

- 7.11** Now, in looking at the human being with greater focus, we're looking at this particular creature that God provides for in a very distinctive way because we are made in His image and His likeness. All creatures reflect God. Even the simplest, smallest thing Aquinas felt reflects something of God's goodness and beauty. We, however, are made in the image and likeness of God. As I said in a previous lecture, not in our bodies, because God doesn't have a body. In our minds, in our spirits, in our souls, we are like unto God. There's a similitude. There's a coherence, a correspondence between us and God. So God exercises vis-à-vis us a particular providence. Stay with that as I go through some of these texts.
- 7.12** What does it mean to be human? It means a lot of things. But at the deepest level, it means I'm ordered to God. I'm haunted by God. I find this in my dialogues with atheists—I've had a lot of public and private conversations with agnostics, atheists, nonbelievers—they can't shake God. It's often the atheists, in fact, I think, who are most haunted by God, and they're wrestling the most with God. But there's something about our humanity that it's like a magnet. We're drawn to God. It's what makes us most ourselves.
- 7.13** The tragedy, in my mind, of a secularism, a secularist ideology, is it denies this element. And when that element is denied, we move into a very bad psychological and spiritual state. Discovering the imago, the image of God in us, and then ordering it toward its source, now you're coming alive, now you're discovering really who you are. That's behind Aquinas as he looks at the human being.
- 7.14** Let me start now with this, with the biblical thing in mind, too. The great text, I think, behind all of Christian reflection on anthropology is the beginning of Genesis. The first creation story we hear that God takes clay and He molds from the clay almost like a figurine, like this human body. But then we hear He breathes into this figurine, His spirit, and the human being emerges. Now, please, the Bible does not speak in scientific language or philosophical language. The Bible speaks in the language of poetry and myth and metaphor. And this is a very good example in the Book of Genesis. It's speaking in a highly metaphorical language.
- 7.15** When it says that we're drawn like this little figurine from the clay, what does it mean? It means there is something in us inescapably that is of the Earth that belongs to matter that is related to all of our animal cousins. Don't deny that we're animals. We get hungry, we get thirsty, we get tired, we feel the thrill in our body of a pleasure and pain. We're like unto our cousins, the other animals. Yes, indeed. But that's not all we are. Again, in the symbolic language of Genesis, God breathes His ruach—that's the lovely Hebrew. Translated in Greek as pneuma, into Latin as spiritus, hence "spirit" for us. God breathes into this figurine something of His distinctive nature. That's the point.
- 7.16** Don't think of it as the air I'm breathing in my lungs. That belongs to my—that's the clay part of me. What's being symbolized here is the properly spiritual dimension of our humanity that cannot be reduced to the physical. The Bible follows with great clarity

that we are this interesting, sometimes confusing, sometimes maddening hybrid of body and soul, of earth and spirit, of lower nature and higher nature.

- 7.17** I think the great tradition, religious and philosophical, has always realized this duality. We're animals, but yet we can entertain the highest and most abstract thinking. We can do high theoretical mathematics. We can imagine the universe in all of its rational complexity. We can design the most complex machines. We can aspire to God. There's something in us that's not reducible to the material. How do you think these two things together? You might say that's the basic question of all philosophical anthropology. How do we understand us in our humanity who are hybrids of earth and spirit, of body and soul?
- 7.18** There's a great tradition, a great trajectory on this question that runs from Plato to the present day. Let me say a word about this. This would be the dualistic way of reading this problem. Go back to the text of Plato, what do you find? He thinks, yes, we're a hybrid of body and soul. He thinks body and soul are very different commodities. In fact, the soul, the mind, that which entertains philosophical ideas, that which aspires to the good and the just, is like a prisoner in a prison, says Plato. So we have bodies, yes, that order us to the sensible world, but the sensible world is passing and evanescent and impermanent. The soul deals with high, beautiful, abstract, perfect things like the Forms. And so the soul finds itself, oddly imprisoned in the body.
- 7.19** Plato thought philosophy was a rehearsal for death, because death meant finally the prison break. Finally, my soul can escape from the fetters of the body and of matter. Think here of the great account of the death of Socrates. When Socrates has to drink the hemlock, he's been condemned to death, and his disciples are all in tears and they're wailing over Socrates. He's calm. "No, no, no. This is what I've lived for. My whole philosophical life has been a preparation for this." So he calmly and with great resignation drinks the hemlock because this is the prison break that he longed for.
- 7.20** This view is very ancient and it's very stubborn, this very dualistic understanding of soul and body. You find it now in these various Platonic philosophical schools that come after Plato. You find it very strongly in the Gnostics, a movement that flourished in the early Christian centuries, like the second, third, fourth centuries. It was something that the early Christian theologians battled.
- 7.21** Think of Saint Irenaeus battling the Gnostics. What did the Gnostics hold? A similar theory to Plato's, that there's a spark of divinity, a spark of spirituality in us, but it's stuck in, it's imprisoned in matter. In fact, it's there as a punishment. This material world, the Gnostics held, is made by a low-level God, not the real high God who is purely spiritual, but a low, fallen deity has produced the material world. And so our souls, the spark of divinity, find themselves stuck in matter. What's the point of the Gnostic program is to facilitate the escape of the soul from the body, ascetic exercises, a deep suspicion of sex and reproduction, because that ties you to the body and to

matter. No, no. You want the spirit to escape, finally, from the imprisonment of the body.

- 7.22** You know where you find it? Think of Thomas Aquinas's order, the Dominicans. Dominicans were formed in part to battle the Albigensians. Who were the Albigensians? They were Neognostics who were operative in the south of France, and Saint Dominic knew about them, and he wanted to fight them. And so the Dominicans were formed in part to battle Albigensianism, which was a revival of Gnosticism.
- 7.23** You know where else you find this? It's very interesting to me, very curious. Ancient world, yes, Plato and the Gnostics and so on, but it also comes back at the dawn of modern philosophy. I mentioned René Descartes before, the man generally regarded as the father of modern philosophy. Remember, Descartes said, "I live in this world full of dubitable things, and there's nothing I know for sure, and it's driving me crazy. And so I'm going to doubt, systematically, whatever can be doubted." Well, can this world be doubted? Sure. It could be an illusion. I could be having a dream. I could be deceived. My glasses might be throwing things off. This world is very dubitable, so I'm going to doubt it. I'm going to say it doesn't exist.
- 7.24** What's the one thing, famously, that Descartes couldn't doubt? That he was doubting, from which comes his most famous one-liner, "Cogito ergo sum." "I think, therefore, I am." So the one thing he couldn't doubt is that he's a doubter. One thing he couldn't doubt was that he was actually a thinking thing. So he says that there's a great distinction, therefore, between the *res cogitans*, "thinking thing," the *cogito* in my mind, and then the world of what he called *res extensa*, "extended things," physical things. They belong to totally different realms because one can be doubted, but the other one can't be doubted.
- 7.25** So what's he left with, Descartes—a later philosopher gave it this characterization—we're like a ghost in the machine. We have these bodies that are like machines. They're machines made out of meat, but they're machines. And then I've got, weirdly, within the machine, something like a ghost, like this thinking thing that's totally distinct from the body. Watch, if we had time to go through modern philosophy, how modern philosophy is very much haunted by this idea. It's a reassertion of the old Platonic idea, of the soul stuck in the body, not prisoner in prison, but ghost in a machine.
- 7.26** Let's cut to the chase. Today, what do you find in some of the wokest language, especially in regard to gender ideology? The real me, in here, somewhere, the real me is a woman, but I'm stuck in this man's body. It's very interesting to me how people today will hear that and say, "Oh, yeah, I get that, I guess that's true." But that's a very ancient way of talking. That goes right back to Plato, and it goes right back to the Gnostics, that somehow the real me is in there. Like Descartes, the *res cogitans* is in there somewhere, but it's in this machine that it awkwardly relates to. That's one strain. I just sketched it from Plato through the Gnostics to Descartes, even up to, I

think, contemporary gender theory, a very dualistic understanding of how soul and body, real me versus my materiality, how they relate to each other.

- 7.27** Plato's greatest student, as we know, was a man named Aristotle. Aristotle spent 20 years—as a young man, he comes to the Academy of Plato and stays for 20 years. One of the more interesting, I think, pairings in the history of culture, that you have arguably the two greatest philosophers in the Western tradition, one was the teacher of the other. Aristotle takes in a lot of Plato, he does, but also disagrees radically with him.
- 7.28** One of their points of disagreement is on this very point: Aristotle thought that no, no, no, that was way too dualistic of an understanding of body and soul. So Aristotle proposes a very different way. He says that no, the soul is not a prisoner in a prison, not a ghost in a machine. It's not stuck in matter. Rather, soul is what he called the form of the body. It doesn't mean so much external configuration. He means the energizing quality that makes this body distinctively what it is. The soul is the form of the body; *energeia* would be his word, "the energy," the organizing energetic pattern by which this body is defined. That's a very different game. Not a prisoner in a prison, not a ghost in a machine, but something much more intimately connected to the body.
- 7.29** Thomas Aquinas, now writing in the 13th century, is the inheritor of all of this. First of all, he's a biblical man, so that's the most important. He's a reader of the Book of Genesis, so he believes there's this coming together of both the earthly and the heavenly, the material and the spiritual, body and soul in us. Yes, indeed. But he didn't think the Bible presented it in Plato's manner. He didn't think the Bible presented it as something off, that the soul is stuck in the body. Why? Because everything God made is good in Genesis. The body is good. It's not a prison for the soul. So, as the Christian Aquinas reflects on this, he says, "I think Aristotle got this more right than Plato."
- 7.30** Now, keep something in mind. Remember I told you for a thousand years before Thomas Aquinas, Christian theologians and philosophers had been using Plato for the most part. Think of Saint Augustine, whom I love, I reverence, but on this point, I think he's somewhat problematically Platonic. He tends to think in a more dualistic way about body and soul. Aquinas, the biblical man, I think, sees the Aristotelian tradition as a better way of talking about the body-soul relationship.
- 7.31** Remember also I told you that when the texts of Aristotle were coming into the West around the time of Thomas Aquinas, they met with a lot of resistance because they thought that he was a little shaky on God, a little shaky on creation, and especially, they thought, a little shaky on the soul. Because if Plato's danger is too much dualism, what's the danger of Aristotle? It sounds like it's almost reducing the soul to the body. Does the soul have any integrity apart from the body? And for a Christian, does the soul survive the body?

- 7.32** So Thomas Aquinas is going to say, "I'm an Aristotelian. I think he's got this more right. But"—and we'll see how this happens—"I'm going to bring something of Plato into the conversation, too," because he's going to affirm the immateriality and immortality of the soul, but within an Aristotelian framework. It's actually, I think, one of the most deft dances Aquinas performs in his intellectual life, this reading together of Plato and Aristotle on the question of soul.
- 7.33** So with that, I want to look first at the Aristotelian side, where he stresses the oneness, the unity of body and soul. Let me give you some examples here. Here's a quote from Question 75 of the first part of the "Summa," "A particular human being is composed of this soul, of this flesh, and of these bones. So it belongs to the notion of humanity to be composed of soul, flesh, and bones." That might strike us as rather obvious, but that was a real departure for the time. He's saying that the real me is not my soul. No, the real me is all of it: body, soul, bones, nerves, muscles; that's all me. The unity of the two is being stressed here.
- 7.34** I love this quote. It's from his commentary on Paul to the Corinthians. It's a little throwaway line, but very interesting. Thomas says, "Anima mea non sum ego." That means "I'm not my soul." Think about it for a second. When someone today says, "The real me in here feels a certain way, but it's out of step with my body," Thomas Aquinas says, "Anima mea non sum ego. I'm not just my soul." The soul is not the real me. The real me is body and soul as a union. I don't separate them out: here's the real me or the authentic me. No, no. This soul, this flesh, these bones, these muscles, that's the real me. That's a revolutionary insight for the 13th century.
- 7.35** Another quote, this one from Question 93 of the first part of the "Summa," "The whole human soul is in the whole body and also in every part of the body, just as God is present to the entire universe." That's a really cool comparison. Remember, I said God is present to all things by essence, presence, and power, and most intimately so, not closer to an archangel than to a worm. God here and now sustains the being of all things. Well, what's the soul like? Aquinas said that it's like that, vis-à-vis the body. The soul—here's another quote that I love, and it's strange—Thomas says, "The soul is in the body, not as contained by it, but rather as containing it." Let that sink in. That would be a point for meditation for the rest of the month.
- 7.36** Think of Plato or Descartes: the soul is in the body. Yeah, it's stuck in there. It's a prisoner in a prison. It's a ghost in a machine. Not for Aquinas. The soul is in the body, so to speak, not as contained by it, but rather as containing it. The soul, the energizing form and pattern of the body contains the body. That's a beautiful revolutionary understanding of anthropology, present to every part of the body as God is present to every part of the universe.
- 7.37** Then this: here's an important implication. This is from the second part of the "Summa," Question 25: "We ought to cherish the body. Our body's substance is not from an evil principle, as the Manichees imagined, but from God. And therefore, we

ought to cherish the body by a friendship of love." Do you remember I told the story about Thomas at the table with Louis IX? He's in a fit of abstraction. Then he rings down his beefy fist and shook the glasses on the table. And what he said outloud was, "That will settle the Manichees." He was thinking about this problem. The Manichees were dualists. The Manichees were Platonists, if you want: body and soul, spirit, matter, opposed to each other.

- 7.38** Listen to him again: "We ought to cherish the body. Our body's substance is not from an evil principle." That's an old idea. That's the light side of the Force, the dark side of the Force. That's the good God, the bad God; spirit good, matter bad. Aquinas has no time for that. Because it's not biblical. It's not the Book of Genesis. God made everything good. "Therefore, we ought to cherish the body by a friendship of love."
- 7.39** Way too much, even Christian spirituality, turns into a chastising of the body. The body is the problem. We've got to get away from the body. We've got to discipline the body. We have to practice all kinds of asceticism that will get the body under control. Thomas is very uneasy with that because it's dualistic. He shows several times in his writings an impatience with Origen. Now, Origen, I love—Origen of Alexandria, early Church Father, great thinker, but deeply Platonic.
- 7.40** One of Origen's ideas that Aquinas hated was that we're in these bodies as a result of sin. So Origen said that we all lived in a spiritual realm prior to this life, and those of us who got stuck in bodies, we did something wrong up there. If we were good, we'd still stay up there as angelic figures. But we clearly did something wrong because our spirits got stuck in these grubby bodies. I get it. That's an old Platonic idea, and Origen—when we feel not at home in our bodies, I get that. But Aquinas has no time for that, no time for it. We're not here as punishment. How does he know that? Because the Book of Genesis said so. Everything God made, including our bodies, are good, so don't play that game.
- 7.41** Did this give rise to a suspicion about pleasure, about sexuality? Yeah. Look at Saint Augustine, again, whom I reverence, but Augustine was not that great on these questions of sexuality. He tended to see sexuality as something fallen. "For the sake of procreation, I guess it's okay." But otherwise, he wasn't that crazy about it because it drew us so much into matter. Thomas has no time for that. Listen to Thomas Aquinas: "Natural inclinations are present in things from God who moves all things. So it's impossible for the natural inclination of a species to be toward what is evil in itself. But there is in all perfect animals a natural inclination toward carnal union. Therefore, it's impossible for carnal union to be evil in itself." That's from the "Summa contra Gentiles," Book 3.
- 7.42** You might say, "Yeah, I guess," but that's revolutionary for a Christian theologian to say, because there was this Augustinian conviction that sensual desire and sex and all that is suspect, and "I guess for the sake of procreation," but it's a— No, no, no, Aquinas says, "A natural inclination that we all have toward this carnal union,"—as he calls it—"is

from God," and it ought to be celebrated as such. It's a much more humanistic, and I would say a much more Aristotelian understanding of humanity than Platonic.

- 7.43 Here's something else: Aquinas is convinced, and we see it in his method, that our knowledge of God comes ultimately, or I should say, comes first through the senses. Remember, his approach to God is a posteriori. It's from after experience, not a priori. He looks out at the world with his eyes and with his hands and what he can see and touch and taste and smell. That's the world that mediates to him, ultimately, God and knowledge of God. It shouldn't be despised or eschewed. It should be embraced.
- 7.44 In many philosophies, the intensity of our knowledge of God is contingent upon how detached we are from our bodies. Think of Plotinus here. He's the greatest of the so-called Neoplatonists, so after Plato, this school of a new Platonism arose. The greatest figure there was Plotinus. Plotinus did indeed say that through a series of exercises, we should try to extricate the soul from the body so that we can be, in his famous phrase, "alone with the alone." God is the great alone, the solitary principle, and I want to be "alone with the alone."
- 7.45 Not Thomas Aquinas. No, no. He likes the fact that we get at God through fingers and eyes and ears and looking out at the world. Remember, he's Aristotelian. Plato is pointing up to the Forms; Aristotle is pointing out to the world. That's Aquinas. And so God's going to come to us through our bodies as well as our souls.
- 7.46 Now, I'm speaking as a Catholic bishop. Catholics love sacraments: water and oil and bread and wine, and imposition of hands. It's a very physical reality. Thomas was asked: how come in the sacraments of the church, there's both matter and form? That means in every sacrament, there's form, which is the verbal element. I'm going to always say something that specifies what I'm doing. But then, there's also matter: water, oil, hands, and bread and wine. Why both those things? His answer: because we have bodies and souls. It's that simple. If we were angels, Aquinas said, we wouldn't need sacraments. Angels don't need sacraments. They don't have bodies. But we do have bodies. And so we're going to get at God through both form and matter. Again, it's an Aristotelian sensibility.
- 7.47 Just a couple of things more on this point. I think the emphasis on body-soul unity is no more clearly and dramatically expressed than in his treatment of the state of the blessed in heaven. I think, everybody, a lot of us, even Christians in the West, are still haunted by Plato here. How do we think about heaven? What does heaven mean? Well, heaven means I finally escape from the body, and my soul goes up to heaven to be with the angels and the other disembodied souls. Really? That's Plato. That ain't the Bible. That's Plato. That's not Christianity.
- 7.48 What are we saying in Christianity? We look forward to the resurrection of the body and life everlasting. We don't say that our hope is that we can finally leave these grubby bodies behind and we can be up with the pure spirits. We believe, by the way,

in the resurrection of Jesus from the dead. Not Jesus, He died on the cross, and then His soul went to heaven. That's a Platonic fantasy. That's not Christianity. Christianity is that we ate and drank with Him after His resurrection from the dead. Let's look at Acts, Chapter 10. Think about that one for a second: "We ate and drank with Him after He rose from the dead."

7.49 And then, that wonderful scene—it's in Luke's account—when Jesus appears to them, and then He said, "You got something to eat?" And they gave Him some fish, and He ate it in their presence. And then He says famously to Thomas, "Come put your finger in my hands and put your hand in my side. A ghost doesn't have flesh and bones as I do." That's the source of the Christian understanding of whatever resurrection means. It doesn't mean Plato's fantasy of an escape of the soul from the body.

7.50 So, Aquinas: "At the resurrection, the soul will not assume a celestial or ethereal body or the body of some animal. No, it will resume a human body made up of flesh and bones and equipped with the same organs it now possesses." That's extraordinary. That's from the "Compendium Theologiae." That's a smaller work of Aquinas. Let me say it again: "At the resurrection, the soul will not assume a celestial or ethereal body"—like an angelic thing—"nor the body of some animal. No, it will resume a human body made up of flesh and bones and equipped with the same organs it now possesses." That's called an Aristotelian understanding of heaven, that soul and body are in such a unity that they can't be separated out.

7.51 I think I've made it sufficiently clear that he's Aristotelian, not Platonic in his basic orientation, and that makes him very different from the tradition that anteceded him. One reason why he was controversial was that he was departing from the standard Platonism on this question.

7.52 I've said all that. I will not gainsay any bit of it, but you might now be haunted by a question which is, "Okay, I get it. He's much more Aristotelian, much more into the unity of body and soul. But is he now in danger of falling into Aristotle's problem of so identifying body and soul that the soul loses any distinctiveness? It loses any real spiritual integrity, and therefore, the immortality of the soul is compromised?" That's the dilemma, and Aquinas knew it very well. So here's the other side of his anthropology if you want a more Platonic side, but never going all the way toward Plato. Again, it's a clever little move he's going to make here. To get at this now, we have to look at Thomistic epistemology, a fancy word for a philosophy of knowledge. How do we know? How do we know? Well, Aquinas, as we've seen many times, holds that knowledge begins in the senses. That's true. How do I know anything? Because as a little baby, I opened my eyes and I took in the world, and then I began thinking about it. And even my most refined knowledge comes first through the senses. But we're not just dumb animals that open our eyes and take in data. No, no. The soul is structured in such a way that it relentlessly seeks to know. How does this happen?

- 7.53** The eyes, to give you one example, take in data from the world. And then, Aquinas says that that data is impressed upon the memory as a phantasm, he calls it, this fancy way of saying like an image, a memory. We all have memories. We call them memories, which are imitations of the world that we see. They're versions of the sensible order. I can remember my mother and father. I can remember my first day of school. I can remember. Those are called phantasms for Aquinas.
- 7.54** But then, what he calls the intellectus agens begins to work—that's Latin: agens is a participle. It means "acting," the "acting intellect," the intellectus agens. What is that? It's the intellect that takes the phantasm, the image, the memory, and then seeks to understand it. It asks this question relentlessly. I always think of this, whenever you hear a little kid—we knock this out of kids, but we shouldn't—"What is that? What is that? Why? Why is that? What is that?" Aquinas says the agent intellect asks quid sit, quid sit, "What's that? What is that?" What's it looking for? It's looking for form. So it's got the image, it's got the particular, but now it wants to know: what's the pattern that makes that thing what it is? Form and pattern, I'd say, mean the same thing. What's the intelligible structure or pattern of that thing?
- 7.55** So I look at this podium and I can close my eyes and I have a phantasm of it, I've got an image of it. My intellectus agens asks, "What is that? What is that?" So, it then abstracts from this particular, its intelligible pattern, and it says, "That's a podium." In other words, it has something in common with any possible podium. It enables me to say, "Oh, yeah, it's like that thing, which is also a podium, and that's a podium. And if I were building a podium, it would be something like this." Because my mind has abstracted from it a pattern.
- 7.56** Think of a chemist looking at glass, "What is this? What is it?" "That's water." "What's water?" "It's H₂O." What's he done thereby is he's found the intelligible pattern that makes water water, which I'm not going to drink. And then he can say, "Okay, okay, now I'm off and running because I can compare it now to other instances of H₂O, and I can compare it then to other types of chemical compounds that aren't like H₂O." What's my intellectus agens doing? It's picking out patterns from particulars.
- 7.57** Then, Aquinas says that the agent intellect impresses upon what he calls the passive intellect: that form. That means the mind, entertaining as a sheer pattern and abstraction that form, and we call that understanding or having insight or apprehending a form. Does that make sense? Once we see this in any science of any kind, this is happening all the time. It's what the mind naturally does: it looks for patterns.
- 7.58** But now here's where it gets, I think, really interesting. The more you think about it, the stranger and more mysterious it becomes, I think. We all know about memories and things that we imagine. I've got images in my mind of particular things. But when my mind knows a pure pattern, it's passed beyond this world of particular sensible things. It's moved into a purely abstract, invisible, purely formal world.

- 7.59** Let me give an example. The number seven. Now, I could draw the number seven, and we could hold that in our minds. I could put seven things in front of you, counting, "1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 7." Okay, got it. I could think of the word seven and hold that in my mind. I imagine S-E-V-E-N. But if I were to say, "No, no. I'm thinking not about any of those things. I'm thinking about the number seven." What's in my mind? It can't be any of those particular things, because if it were, then I couldn't see what links together all those things as the number seven. See what I'm driving at? If I were to say, "When I have the number seven purely in my mind, it's that." No, it can't be that. That's a symbol of what's in my mind. "Oh, it's in my mind: one, two, three, four, five, six, seven." No, no, no. No, no. That's how I recognize that that's seven.
- 7.60** Let's say you have the quadratic formula in your mind, if you're a mathematician. I remember as a kid learning that and the teacher putting it up on the blackboard. I could imagine the symbols on the blackboard of the quadratic formula. But, no, not that. That's a symbol of it. When you understand the quadratic formula, what's in your mind? Something purely invisible, something purely formal, something that can't be particularized, it doesn't have a color, a shape, a size. Mind you, it would be true in any possible world, wouldn't it?
- 7.61** Let's say you've got $2 + 2 = 4$ in your mind right now. I don't mean the symbol $2 + 2 = 4$. I mean the equation. True in this world? Yeah. True on Mars? Of course. True in the most distant solar system? Yeah, of course. True in any possible world? Yeah. In other words, you've left this world of ordinary sensible experience, and you've entered into a world of pure formality, pure immateriality.
- 7.62** Plato got this right. You remember in the parable of the cave, where the people are stuck in the cave, they're chained in place, and all they see are the flickering shadows on the wall? That's us. That's ordinary life. Things come and go. Then he escapes, gets out of the cave, and then sees the Forms. But what was the mediating moment before he gets out of the cave is the discovery of mathematics. Because pure mathematics opens you to a different world. It opens you to a properly spiritual world.
- 7.63** Thomas Aquinas would hold that the mind, through the agent intellect, is able to entertain that world, which means the mind in its essential structure is itself immaterial. If the mind were just the brain and just brain firings and just imagination, it could not attain to this level of intellection. But it does attain to this level of intellection. Therefore, there's more to the mind than mere matter. Could the brain explain sense experience? Sure. Could it explain memory? Yeah, I guess. Can it explain intellection at this level? There's something more than material about our minds.
- 7.64** By a very clever move here, Thomas, staying within an Aristotelian framework, but nevertheless holds that the mind, the soul in its highest powers, does have something of the quality that Plato recognized, does indeed have the quality of immateriality. What follows from this? The immortality of the soul. So does Aquinas recognize that the body falls apart, that the body gets sick at death, the body disintegrates? Yeah,

sure. Does that mean the soul just evanesces, the soul just goes away with the body? No, no. Because of this immaterial, therefore, immortal quality, the soul doesn't fade away, but the soul can survive even the death of the body.

7.65 Again, it's a subtle dance he's doing here. He's an Aristotelian Platonist. He's a Platonic Aristotelian. But all of it is in service of his Christianity because he wants to hold on to Genesis and its strong sense of the unity of body and soul, and he wants to hold on to the resurrection and eternal life. But again, it's not Platonic eternal life. It's the resurrection of Jesus's eternal life, body and soul. He's trying to say both these things at the same time.

7.66 Just a word again about the resurrection. Does the soul survive the body? Yes. I'm wondering if you find this interesting, because I do, because this has happened really in my lifetime, this research into near-death experience. We know more about death than any other generation because of modern medicine, that people have been drawn back from the threshold of death, and these extraordinary reports of, call what you want—consciousness, awareness, mind, soul—surviving the dissolution of the death of the body, those extraordinary stories of people that find themselves outside of their own body, able to see it, able to recognize all the physicians and nurses coming in to identify the instruments that were used.

7.67 My favorite example is the case of a person who left his body, saw all of that, but then left the room, went down the corridor of the hospital, went outside the wall on the far side of the hospital, looked back and noticed on the windowsill a gym shoe, a red gym shoe. He comes back to his body, wakes up, tells this extraordinary story, and he says, "Yeah, by the way, why don't you go look? There's a red gym shoe on the windowsill on the back of the hospital," which they found. Thomas Aquinas is speculating about this in the 13th century, and thinks, yes, there's something about our consciousness, our soul, that survives the death of the body. Are we getting some experience of that or some measurable data about that? Yeah, maybe.

7.68 But the point I was going to make was, yes, the soul survives the body, but for Thomas, is the soul without its body happy? Not really. A disembodied soul is not a human being. Remember, because *anima mea non sum ego*, "I'm not my soul." And so Aquinas thinks that in the consummation of all things, it's not the disembodied soul, but a soul reunited now to an elevated, resurrected body. That would be a talk for another day about eschatology and about heaven and hell, but it fits here in the anthropology.

7.69 This idea of the *imago Dei* goes back, of course, to Genesis: we're made in the image and likeness of God. It comes roaring up into the tradition, and it's so basic for so many of the spiritual masters. There's something in me that is like unto God, and therefore, as I said, it functions like a magnet. It's what draws us to God. There's something in us that's like God and wants to return to God.

- 7.70** I'll give you a dumb example, but this struck me when I was a kid, and I saw Spielberg's "Close Encounters of the Third Kind" for the first time. Am I dating myself? Do you remember that movie? Remember these ordinary people? They're marked by these alien spacecraft. They come, they mark them, and their skin is affected. The light shone on them. And then, by obsessive preoccupation, they know they have to get to this place of meeting, and they begin painting and sculpting this weird mountain with a plateau. What's going on? I don't know. They don't even know. Their families are alienated from them, and everyone thinks they're crazy.
- 7.71** And then, a handful of them figure out what they're doing. It's the Devil's Tower— is it in Wyoming? That's where they got to go. They got to go to Devil's Tower. And so a handful of them make it, and they climb up despite all kinds of opposition. And then, the great mothership comes down, and then there's this union. I remember as I watched that movie— Spielberg, of course, plays with this all the time, of the space world was evocative of the transcendent. But that's what we're all like. We all are marked by God. We're marked by God, and we're hungry and thirsty for God, and we won't rest until we find God. Despite opposition, and despite our own— people think we're crazy, or I think I'm crazy, I'm drawn to this point of encounter. That's what the imago is in us. That's what the imago is.
- 7.72** Listen to this, though: "Our intellect never understands so many things that it could not understand more. It follows that our souls cannot be limited by nature to a certain fixed natural notion." What's he talking about here? Remember, I mentioned the intellectus agens. "What is that? What is that?" It seeks: that's a podium; it finds the pure abstract form of a podium. Now, is it satisfied? Well, no. Talk to any kid or anyone that's going down a rabbit hole on the internet or something. You come to know one thing. What do you want to know? More and more and more. "What's a podium?" A podium is an artifact. It's something made by human beings. "What's an artifact?" Quid sit. "What's that? What's an artifact?" That's a material thing that's been formed for a certain purpose. "Material things, what matter? What is matter? Quid sit. What does he mean by matter?" Matter is—
- 7.73** You see what the mind is doing? It never rests. It's restless. Yes. It grasps, and then it wants to know. It gets one intelligible pattern, and it wants a wider intelligible pattern, and then a wider, and then a wider. Until what? Here's Bernard Lonergan, a 20th-century Thomist, one of the really great masters of the 20th century. He said, "What does the mind want? It wants to know everything about everything." You find those moments when you sense that? I won't be satisfied until I get the intelligible pattern of all intelligible patterns. I get the form of all forms. I get—this should sound familiar— not any particular being. I want being itself. I want ipsum esse.
- 7.74** What do I want? I'll put it in Christian terms now: I want the beatific vision. I want to know everything about everything. There's no limit to what I want to know. I don't want just another true thing. I want the truth itself. At those moments, everybody,

what's stirring in us is the imago Dei. We've been marked from birth. We got this in us. We can't get rid of it. And it pushes us on and on, upward, outward, toward truth itself, toward being itself, toward the meeting of all things.

7.75 You know that question, Heidegger called it die Frage nach dem Sein, "the question after being. You know what die Frage nach dem Sein is? "What's it all about?" Remember the movie, "What's it all about, Alfie?" What's it all about? So I know what you're about. I know what this is about. I know various intelligible patterns. Okay, but what's it all about? That's the hunger for God. That's a passion and a desire for God. Don't let secularism negate that or suppress that. That's the imago Dei. That's the soul and body, I would say, too, longing for God.

7.76 What does the Psalmist say? "As the deer yearns for running streams, so my soul is yearning for You, my God." I'm yearning for all kinds of things. Fine, fine. But above them all, I'm yearning for the intelligible pattern of all intelligible patterns. I'm yearning for truth and goodness themselves. I'm yearning for those flowing streams of eternal life. Aquinas takes this as axiomatic in his understanding of the human being.

Lecture 8: Aquinas on Ethics & Happiness

At a glance — Aquinas on ethics and happiness, the fitting culmination of his thought.

- 8.1** We come to our final lecture, and it'll be on Ethics. Now, that might sound a little bit abstract, but actually, it's the right place to end because of the way Aquinas thinks. Remember, *exitus-reditus*: everything coming forth from God, everything returning to God. What's ethics, but the means by which we, human beings made in God's image and likeness with body and soul, return to God. Ethics for him—he's Aristotelian here again—is teleological; *telos* means "goal" or end in Greek. And so it's a teleological ethic. How do we get back to the one from whom we came?
- 8.2** Note something, too, though, please: Thomas never defends a dumb, rhythmic view of things where things go out, things go back, like Nietzsche's eternal return of the same. It's not that, or just a dull, never-ending rhythm. Things come forth in all their goodness, beauty, order, and harmony. Sin interrupts. That's another story. But God wants now to bring everything back enhanced and rendered beautiful for its own sake. Remember, God has no need. God has no need of the world. Therefore, everything that God does is for the good of the world. The return to God is an enhancement of our humanity. That's the game that we're playing here. That's what ethics is all about.
- 8.3** Now, let me just say this as I begin: if you were to say, here's a Catholic theologian talking about ethics, what do you expect him to sound like? My guess is that for a lot of people, "He's going to say no, especially about sex." Well, we've already seen that Aquinas is very pro-sexuality. He's not an Augustinian or Platonist. Thomas affirms the goodness of sexuality.
- 8.4** Secondly, where does law come into his conversation about ethics? If you look now at the beginning of the second part of the "Summa," which is about the human being, law is broached for the first time in Question 90, nine zero. There are 89 questions. Remember, for Thomas, a question is subdivided into all kinds of articles. There are hundreds of pages before he gets to the consideration of law. Whenever we think that Catholic morality is all about law, especially things you shouldn't do, that is the completely wrong way to think about it, certainly in terms of our greatest doctor, the common doctor of the Church, Thomas Aquinas.
- 8.5** Where does ethics begin for Aquinas? Not with the law. It begins with *beatitudo*, "happiness." Happiness. It's the one thing everybody wants. I don't care who you are, how old you are, what your gender is, what your background is, what your ethnicity is, or your education. I don't care. Everybody wants *beatitudo*. The heart of ethics for Aquinas is trying to figure out what that is and then how best to attain that goal. So maybe anytime you're tempted to think that morality is all about law and saying no—no, we'll get there, because in regard to anything worth doing, there's going to be plenty of room for, "Hey, no, don't do it that way."

- 8.6** I want to have a great golf swing. Well, I have had different golf teachers. They've said no to me a lot because most of what I do in my swing is not that good. But it's not because they get a kick out of saying no; it's because I'm trying to find beatitudo in regard to the golf swing. So we'll get to things we shouldn't do. But the whole project begins with beatitudo, "happiness."
- 8.7** Now, let's get at this through an analysis of desire. Here's a contrast with Buddhism. I'm no great expert on Buddhism, but the people I talk to will say that at the heart of Buddhist spirituality is the blowing out of the candle of desire. That's what nirvana means. It means the extinguishing of the candle of desire, the illusion of a separate self with its fears and its needs and desires. Christianity isn't that. Christianity is a proper directing of desire, not extinguishing it. Desire is good; it's from God. But desire gets messed up in all kinds of ways. How do you properly direct desire to its end? That's the Christian ethical game.
- 8.8** Thomas analyzes desire, I think, in a very interesting way. Teilhard de Chardin, again, I've quoted him a couple of times, very Thomistic in this way, he said that you wouldn't get out of bed in the morning unless you believe in God. You wouldn't get out of bed in the morning unless you believe in God. Why is that true? Think of any desire we have. You obviously desired to be here today for this lecture on Saint Thomas Aquinas.
- 8.9** Let's do a little analysis of that desire. How come you're here? "I don't know. I've heard Bishop Barron before, and I'm interested in Thomas Aquinas. I want to learn more about him." Okay. Why do you want that? Why do you want to learn more about Thomas Aquinas? "He's a religious thinker, and I think that's an important part of life. I want to learn more about religion." Why would you want to learn more about religion? "Religion puts me in touch with the deepest and most important things in life." Why do you want that? "I think that's where I would find my greatest meaning and purpose and happiness."
- 8.10** You see, what I've done here, imitating Thomas, who has done this Russian doll thing, is take something as simple as a basic desire: you're being here this morning. Why? "To learn more about Aquinas." Why do you want that? "I want to learn more about religion." Why do you want that? And on and on we go as we analyze desire, seeking ever further horizons for our desire. What do we come to, ultimately? "Because I want to be happy." If you follow any analysis of desire, you'll come finally to: "because it makes me happy."
- 8.11** I'll give you one. So I played golf the other day. I came out here a day earlier to play golf with this friend of mine out here. How come we went to play golf? I like golf. I'm not that good at it. I get frustrated, but I like golf. Why do you like golf? I don't know, just the challenge of it. It's fun. It's fun. What does fun do for you? It makes me happy. I've come quickly to happiness because golf is something that is sought largely for its own sake. I'm not playing golf to prepare to be on the senior tour. Good luck with that; that's not why I'm playing golf. I'm not playing golf so I can raise some money. I have

done some fundraising on golf courses in my life. But the other day, no, I just played because I like playing golf. Golf is fun, and I want to be happy.

- 8.12** How come I'm here today? You're here, presumably, to learn more about Thomas Aquinas. Well, I'm here because Jordan Peterson invited me to give a course on Aquinas, and I think that's worthwhile. Why do you think that's worthwhile? Because I think Thomas is not that well-known in contemporary culture, and I want a wider audience to know about him. Why do you want that? Because I think he's saying very important things about life that are worth knowing. Why is that important for people? Because I want them to be happy, because making them happy makes me happy. See, at the end of every analysis of desire, if you go far enough, you're going to come to: "because it makes me happy."
- 8.13** So, what is happiness? Beatitudo would be his word. What is that thing that we're seeking in all of our desires, all of them? Why are you eating that breakfast cereal? Because I'm hungry and I don't like being hungry, and not being hungry makes me happier, and I want to be happy all the time. That's why I'm eating that breakfast.
- 8.14** Think of Thomas Jefferson. We Americans know that we've got rights to life, liberty, and the pursuit of happiness. Great. I'm glad I got that right because I don't want that right denied to me. But notice how Jefferson doesn't ever define happiness. And you say that he's leaving that to other people to define. That's fine. He's just saying you've got a right to pursue it, which is good. But the tradition is very interested in defining what beatitudo really is. Here's Thomas Aquinas as he's laying out his ethical principle.
- 8.15** I see a link between this analysis and the myths of the Holy Grail that were emerging around the same time in the Middle Ages. The Quest for the Grail, what is that? It's the quest for ultimate happiness. It's what the will is ultimately seeking through all of its proximate desires. It's seeking this great goal. Why is it so hard to find the Grail? Well, that's human life: we're on this journey, and we're following our desire, sometimes down errant paths, sometimes we stop too soon. What we ought to be looking for is what finally satisfies us. That's what Thomas is looking for, too: the Holy Grail.
- 8.16** So he analyzes a number of candidates for happiness, for the ultimate good, what the will is ultimately seeking. Here's the first one: "whether ultimate happiness consists in the possession of wealth." May I suggest to you that this is a very popular option for a lot of people? Do we live in a society that is really predicated upon the quest for wealth? Uh-huh. Who are the people we most admire? That's always interesting to ask about culture: whom do you most admire? Most of us know the wealthiest people in our society. Because wealth seems to be, boy, if not it, at least a real key to happiness.
- 8.17** Thomas says that you've got two types of wealth: natural and artificial. Artificial wealth we dispense with because it's a symbol of natural wealth. Just think of, "I got all this money in the bank." It's an abstract symbol of natural wealth. What's natural wealth? He said things like food, clothing, transportation, shelter, all those things that money

can buy. They're the wealth that gives comfort to us. Can that be the ultimate end? Can that be ultimate happiness? Well, no, because those things are good only in the measure that they produce something like this general physical contentment.

- 8.18** I mean, why is it nice having a beautiful, big house? Because it makes me feel comfortable or safe or content. Why is it great having a car, a beautiful car? Because it makes me feel content. I can get someplace faster. It's a beautiful car, and that makes me feel content. The wealth in itself, Aquinas says, can never be the final goal because it conduces toward something more elemental, which is this feeling of bodily contentment. And then even less so artificial wealth. This is the whole Midas problem. I can't point to my pile of gold and say that that's what's going to make me happy. Think of the dragon in Tolkien, sitting on the pile of gold. That's a symbol of this moral error of thinking that artificial wealth is going to make me happy. Neither one can make you happy.
- 8.19** I love this from Joseph Campbell. He observed that if you look at ancient society, medieval society, too, what was the tallest building in a village or a city? It was invariably the church. You go to the great cities of Europe, you go to the Old Town, what's at the heart of Old Town always is the church, the cathedral, because they knew there was the highest value. Now, come up into the Renaissance period, Campbell says, and what became the highest buildings are the palaces of the kings and the municipal officials. How about our society? There's no question about it. It's the great towers of wealth.
- 8.20** I think of my hometown of Chicago, the Willis Tower—we call it the Sears Tower—the John Hancock building, the Aon building, the three tallest buildings in Chicago. What are they? Insurance companies. It's very telling, isn't it? You go to Chicago, where's the cathedral? It was where I was ordained a priest, the cathedral. A little tiny, a little tiny—you can barely see it. It's completely dwarfed by these giant office buildings. And the three tallest are all insurance companies to make sure that we're insured in our wealth. What that tells you is what our society tends to value. Aquinas is saying that wealth can't possibly be beatitudo. It can't be the thing you're ultimately desiring.
- 8.21** He makes this observation here, but it's going to apply to every one of the things I'll talk about. He knew this very clearly, the addictive quality of wealth. "If I just get that house, I'll be happy. I'll be content. If I get that car, that's the car I've always wanted. If I just get that car, I'll be fine. I'll be content." Are you? Yeah, for a little while. For a little while, "I love this house. It's great." And then, six months later, "I don't know, it's not that great. I'm not that happy here. There's a bigger house across town. I think I need that one." "The car I got, it gets me where I want to go. It's got a decent sound system. But that guy next door, he's got a better car. I want that one now." And then you strive, and strive, and strive, and strive. Then, you get the bigger house, get the better car. And then for a little while, "Hey, I'm doing good. I'm really happy. I got beatitudo."

Yeah, good luck. In very short order, that's going to wear off, and you'll want more and more and more.

- 8.22** Here's Aquinas, "For when we already possess them,"—material goods, he says—"we despise them and seek others. The reason for this is that we realize their insufficiency once we possess them, and this very fact shows that they are imperfect and that the sovereign good does not consist therein." There's beautifully stated abstract language, but all of us sinners, we feel that, don't we, at different times in life? The very things we think will bring beatitudo. But the sovereign good does not consist in them because I'm restless when I possess them.
- 8.23** Paul Tillich, I mentioned earlier, talks about the desire to cram the whole world into your mouth. That's the concupiscent desire of those who think wealth will make them happy. It won't. You could cram the whole world into your mouth, and you're still going to be hungry. That's the point. That's the point.
- 8.24** So let's say wealth is not the answer. How about honors, fame, and glory? There are people that don't really care that much about wealth—I know a lot of them—but they are very interested in honors and fame and glory, to be thought highly of, to have titles that are worthy of my ability, that people admire me, that'll make me happy. "The reason I'm unhappy, the thing I'm seeking, I don't have, is enough glory. Look at all I've done, and that bozo over there is getting more honor than I am? What I have accomplished in my life, and they're praising her? Are you kidding?"
- 8.25** So I start seeking honor and glory. I strive and strive and strive after it, and then I get more. I get that title that I always wanted. I get the position I desired. People start getting jealous of me. "Okay, that's great. I got the honor and glory I want." How long does that last? It never lasts long. That wears off almost immediately, and you find yourself caught in the same addictive rhythm, don't you?
- 8.26** Chesterton says it's like a little train, just circling obsessively around this desire for honors and for glory. Here's something Aquinas says I think is really good. He says there's nothing wrong with honor and glory, but honor and glory are "flags of virtue," he says. It's a way of saying, "Hey, hey, look at this guy, he's done something really good." "Hey, everybody, pay attention to her. She's an accomplished person." So the honor is a flag. It's meant to signal to others something really good in you. What's sick about it—it really is a sickness, spiritual sickness— I get addicted to the darn flag. I get addicted to the stupid flag. The flag is meant for others to say, "Hey, hey, imitate him. He's done something good." What matters is the good thing you've done, not the stupid flag. But there are people, we all know them, maybe we see them in the mirror, who spend a lot of life running after in an addictive way these stupid flags of honor and glory.
- 8.27** Thomas says, "Virtue's true reward is happiness itself, for which the virtuous work. Whereas if they work for honor, it would be no longer a virtue, but rather ambition."

Again, naming it pretty succinctly. The true reward of virtue is happiness. That's what I want. I'll come back to that. The happiness will be found in virtue itself, not in the flag of virtue that I go running after. Both mistake shadow for substance.

- 8.28** Read the spiritual teachers on this. They're really clear. That happens a lot in our spiritual lives: we run after shadows, and we completely forget the substance of life. So we run after wealth. I run after glory. Same thing. I love this. Saint Ambrose, Thomas cites here, says that happiness, beatitudo, cannot possibly consist in being praised because human beings are so fleeting and so insubstantial and so often mistaken. "I've received glory." Yeah, but from a bunch of idiots. "The whole world thinks I'm really something." Yeah, but they don't know what they're talking about. They're as lost as you are, and you're reveling in the glory coming from them?
- 8.29** Here's Thomas in more precise philosophical language: "We must observe that human knowledge often fails, especially in contingent singulars such as our human acts. For this reason, human glory is frequently deceptive." This even means our knowledge fails in contingent singulars, meaning about particular states of affairs. So who's the best person in our society? We might name some goofy pop stars or something. Who are the people most admired in our society? We might name politicians or some cultural figure. So what? We're so mistaken about these things. And I'm going to be running after the opinion of the crowd? Why not seek the virtue in which real beatitudo consists? That's his point.
- 8.30** Think of this, too, everybody, psychologically speaking: when you're addicted to glory or honor, your happiness has been placed utterly in the hands of other people. You're out of control. I mean, you're literally out of control because everybody else is going to control your happiness. "They like me. Hey, I'm happy." And then tomorrow, "They don't like me. I'm unhappy."
- 8.31** See how the saints cultivate a detachment or insouciance—I love that word, insouciance, in French; it means "without care." I don't care what people think about me. I don't care what people are saying about me because I know who I am. I know what I'm seeking. I know the virtue that I want. But if I live by glory, I'm utterly in the hands of other people. God help you. It's a sick and pathetic way of being, and Aquinas wants us out of that.
- 8.32** I'm dating myself with the old Paul Simon song, where he said, "Every generation throws a hero off the pop charts." But that's true, isn't it? Every generation, "Look, how great—" and then down they go. Next generation, "Look at those people," and then down they go. Don't play that game. Don't play that game.
- 8.33** Here's the third one: how about power? Doesn't power make you happy? "The reason I'm unhappy is I don't have enough power. If I just had enough power, I'd be happy." Seductive? You bet. Someone told me that we're having the 25th anniversary of the Tolkien movies, "The Lord of the Rings" movies. What was the ring but a ring of power,

a ring of power that seduced everybody. I've said this before, but I think the most frightening scene in that whole movie is when Gandalf himself—remember the great Wizard, the great, good, good and great Wizard—for a moment is tempted by the ring. He sees it when Bilbo still has it, and they're trying to get rid of it, but he sees it. And you sense Ian McKellen, the great actor, you sense that he wants it. And if Gandalf got the ring, God help us. If he was seduced by the ring of power, the whole thing would have collapsed.

- 8.34** Power is very seductive. But why can't it be beatitudo? Why can't it be the ultimate good? Because power is always subordinated to an end beyond itself. It's not power in itself that I want. It's power so I can do something with it. It's power so I can accomplish something that I want. Power is always subordinated to an end outside of itself, and therefore in itself is always ambiguous. If I have power and I use it for the good of humanity—terrific. If I have power and I use it to aggrandize my ego, I use it to punish my enemies, I use it to make a mess of the world, then God help me. So power in itself is ambiguous, and it can't be the final end.
- 8.35** Mind you, when you figure out what the final end is, then you'll know what to do with power as with wealth and with honor. Once you know—we'll get there—what the real beatitudo is, then you'll know when you get power, how to use it. Then you'll know when you become famous, how to take advantage of it in a good way. You'll know if you get wealth, how best to use it. But when I mistake wealth and honor and power for the ultimate good, trouble ensues.
- 8.36** The last one is extremely interesting, and Aquinas knew this. So you say that it's not wealth, it's not power, not honor. But what about pleasure? Because I said that wealth can't be the ultimate good because wealth is meant to produce bodily pleasure, this sense of contentment. This is the hedonist position, which is very old and very venerable philosophical tradition, that the ultimate goal we want is pleasure, is bodily pleasure. The greatest pleasure for the greatest number is a more modern way of stating the hedonist principle. Well, maybe that's it, it's the pleasure of the body. That's beatitudo.
- 8.37** What does Thomas say? "The pleasure sensed by the body is but a trifle compared to the good of the soul." It's an interesting point, isn't it? So yes, I'm both an animal and I'm an angel. I'm both body and I'm both soul. At times when the body experiences intense pleasure, whether in food or drink or sex or comfort, I can think this is it. That's it. That's everything. But then I realize that when the soul experiences its pleasures, which are knowledge and virtue and union with others and with God, I realize, compared to those goods, the goods of the body are but a trifle. Now, I'm not taking one thing back on what I said about how much he reverences the body. He's not against the body at all. But compared to the good of the soul, the good of the body is but a trifle.

- 8.38** Another quote, "Consequently, it's evident that that good which is fitting to the body, and which causes bodily delight, is not man's perfect good, but is quite a trifle as compared with the good of the soul." That's from Question 2 of the second part of the "Summa." Not wealth, not power, not honor, not pleasure. So what is it? What is it? What is the thing that we're all secretly searching for?
- 8.39** Thomas knew the great biblical text that only in God is our soul at rest. What does his analysis of the mind tell him? That the mind wants, finally, to know everything about everything. It wants to know not just particular true things, but the ultimate pattern of all truth. Now, in a similar way, he's analyzing the will. What does the will want? It wants goods, and all these things we're describing are goods. Wealth, power, pleasure, honor, they're all good. But the soul realizes they're not the ultimate good. They can't be the final thing. What does it want? Not any particular good. It wants goodness itself. It won't rest until it finds goodness itself, which is precisely why all these things become addictive.
- 8.40** You can revisit that theme of addiction. I'm hungry for God, ultimately, but I make the mistake of saying that wealth is my God. And so I strive, strive, strive, and I get wealth, and for a moment, I'm satisfied. But any addict will tell you this: anyone who wrestles with an addiction, the buzz will wear off, and then I need more of it. I need more wealth. I need more, and I strive, and I strive, and I strive, and I get more wealth, but the buzz wears off faster the second time, doesn't it? And now I start panicking, and now I want more, and I want more, and I want more. And before I know it, my whole life is obsessed with the quest for wealth.
- 8.41** I've known a lot of older, sophisticated people, utter addicts when it comes to wealth, utter addicts. Because secretly, they're hungry for God, and they put something less than God in the place of God, so they become necessarily addicted to it. Same with honor: "If I just get that title, I'll be happy. Oh, I got it, and they admire me, and they think I'm okay." How long does that last? About 15 minutes.
- 8.42** And then, I need more honor. I need a bigger position. I need a bigger title. Strive and strive, strive, strive. I get it. I get it. And now, in about 11 minutes, it fades away. And I want more. I want more. I want more. Before I know it, I know a lot of people like this, very bright, very sophisticated, sometimes in high positions, they are utter addicts of honor. They're completely addicted to honor in a way that's destroying their lives. Every bit as clearly as addiction to booze or to pornography or anything else would destroy their lives, the addiction to honor.
- 8.43** Pleasure, the same thing. "If I just get enough pleasure in my life. The trouble is I've denied myself pleasure or people deny it of me. So I strive: it's food and sex and drink and comfort. Okay, now, I'm happy. I'm happy. I reached what I wanted." Ten minutes, that wears off. "I want more. I want more. I want more."

- 8.44** Something that anyone involved in pastoral ministry today deals with is pornography addiction, which is rampant in our society. I thank God every day that my generation, we didn't have the internet, and so it didn't affect people the way it does. But people today are massively affected by pornography addiction. The people who create this stuff know what they're doing; they're appealing to this very spiritual dynamic. "If I just get enough, I'll be happy." Well, you never will, because you're hungry for God, and this is no substitute for God. So it'll draw you into this addictive pattern. Power, the same thing. "If I just get enough power, I'll be happy." No, you won't. No, you won't.
- 8.45** I cited John of the Cross at one time, I think. John of the Cross is the greatest of the Church's spiritual teachers. A couple of centuries after Aquinas, he was a Carmelite priest, knew Aquinas really well, studied Aquinas very carefully. John of the Cross said that we have in us an infinite cavern. What he meant was our infinite hunger for God that can only be satisfied by God. "Only in God is my soul at rest." It's the infinite hunger. What do I do, John of the Cross said, "Most of my life I take the things of the world, and I throw them into the cavern thinking I'll satisfy myself." Like, "Oh, if I just got enough of that." Down it goes. "If I just get enough wealth," down it goes. More and more and more. Who cares? The cavern is infinite. It'll only be filled by the infinite God. He learned that from Thomas Aquinas.
- 8.46** I think it names the dynamic that we all face, all of us sinners. Because all of sin is like an addiction. It's an addictive pattern. It's only in God that my soul is at rest. So here's Aquinas: not wealth, not glory, not fame, not bodily pleasure. Quote, "The object of the will is the universal good. Hence, it's evident that nothing can lull the human will but the universal good. This is to be found not in any creature, but in God alone, because every creature has goodness only by participation. Thus, God alone can satisfy the will of the human being." Simply stated, but bank on it, base your life on it. God alone can satisfy the will of the human being.
- 8.47** Now, think of every single desire you've ever had. The ultimate motivating principle is this: what you ultimately want is happiness, beatitudo. What's beatitudo? God. God. So remember, I began with arguments from efficient causality: God is the first unmoved mover, the first uncaused cause, the non-contingent ground of contingency, that which brings things into being. This is another argument for God's existence, but it's based on teleology, final causality. It's beginning with the will in every act of the will and then seeking its ultimate cause. So you can't go on indefinitely; it's the same principle. There's no infinite regress of moved movers. I can't go on infinitely. I've finally come to something that is ultimately motivating everything I want. And it's God. "Only in God is my soul at rest. Only in God is my soul at rest."
- 8.48** Let me name at this point a principle that is tough. It's an important principle, but a tough one to take in. You say, "Okay, I get it. But at least wealth and pleasure and power and honor are right in front of me, and I can see them. I can sense them right in front of me. I get it. There it is. All right, all right, I understand it's not perfect, it's not

ultimate, but at least I can see it, I can touch it. God? Well, yeah, I can sense God, I suppose. But in this life, I don't see God." Yeah, this is a central dynamic in the spiritual life: the thing we want most, the thing we're desiring implicitly all the time is something that we only inchoately grasp in this world. What does that mean?

8.49 It means my desire, even to go to a baseball game, my desire to be here, my desire to get out of bed in the morning, is finally leading me to heaven. It's leading me to a world beyond this world. My desire for beatitudo is not restricted to this world. It can't be. Nothing in this world satisfies it. And so by nature—I'm going to state it paradoxically—by nature, I'm ordered to something supernatural. Frustrating? Uh-huh. Listen to every spiritual master on that. Frustrating? Read the Bible, page after page. The very thing I want, I can't have in this world. I can have it only through the grace of God.

8.50 It makes living in this world wonderful and painful. You know what I'm saying? It makes of this life a life of longing, a holy longing indeed, that will never be satisfied this side of death. It can be anticipated. I can sense it. Think of the liturgy, speaking as a Catholic, when you're at Mass, are you in heaven in one sense? Yeah, the Mass is meant to be heaven on Earth. But is it heaven in the full sense? Obviously not. It's a longing. It's an aspiration toward heaven. So beatitudo: what lures desire, ultimately, leads us to God.

8.51 Now we move into things that maybe we're a little more at home with when talking about ethics and morality. The first one is virtue. What orders us properly now toward God? So now we figured out, I don't want wealth, pleasure, power, honor. What I want is God. How do I get there? Now, Thomas talks about the virtues. He's deriving a lot of this from Aristotle, but he's giving his own spin. Virtues are these inner capacities that order me properly toward an end.

8.52 First one: justice. What's justice? It's doing the right thing. Justice is the virtue by which I do the right thing. Plato said that justice is rendering to each his due. A pretty good pithy definition: giving each person what that person deserves. Doing the right, morally upright thing—justice. For justice to prevail, what do I furthermore need?

8.53 I need a virtue called temperance. What does temperance do? It holds off inner resistances to justice. So let's say I know the right thing to do, but my inner life, my emotions, all that, are so disordered that I can't get it together. I can't do what's right. I'm so addicted to things. I'm so emotionally attached to this, that, and the other, that I can't do what's right. So I need the virtue of temperance to temper and order and properly arrange all that's inside of me.

8.54 What else do I need? Well, sometimes there's an external threat to justice. I know the right thing to do, but if I do it, I'm going to get attacked. If I do it, I might get hurt. If I do it, they might come after me. So what do I need? Courage. Courage is the virtue that holds off external threats to justice, doing the right thing.

8.55 Finally, I need prudence. What's prudence? Prudence. Prudence is practical moral know-how. Justice: do the right thing. Temperance: control it from the inside. Courage:

protect it from the outside. But what exactly does the just thing look like here and now? What does doing the right thing look like right now? It's a bit like a quarterback who's reading the defense and maybe calls an audible. He reads what the needful thing is right now, given the way the defense is organized. The great quarterbacks have skill, but they also have this intellectual virtue of prudence. They know the right thing to do in these circumstances. So Aquinas says that you need prudence to lead the moral life properly.

8.56 Where's the moral life going? The moral life is going toward beatitudo. It's ordering the whole of you toward God. But I need these virtues to be inculcated in me to get there. The next step: now we're finally getting to the law. Notice I've not wagged my finger once at you in this lecture. We started with this very happy news about beatitudo. Then, we moved toward the virtues that are needed. What's the final thing we need? Now we need the law.

8.57 What does law do? Law disciplines my action in such a way that it inculcates the virtues, which in turn order me toward beatitudo. I need the law. I can think about you raising a kid, to do the right thing, to be the right person. The kid might not fully understand all what that means, all these dynamics. What do you give the kid? Laws. Laws are meant to order him and to habituate him toward virtue. And then the virtue orders him toward the good. Aquinas says that's the way it works for all of us.

8.58 Law has three dimensions, he says. First, there's positive law. What's positive law? Those are the practical, concrete, in writing laws that govern a society. For example, you can only drive 65 miles an hour. That's a law of society. You can't buy and sell certain types of drugs. That's a law of society. You owe taxes, and that's a law. What are those laws doing? They're trying to inculcate in us virtue. It's positive law. But positive law—think Russian dolls again—positive law nests in what he calls the natural law.

8.59 What's the natural law? It'd be those moral principles that are written, as it were, in our nature by which we know the goods that we ought to be seeking: things like knowledge and sociability and religion and arts and friendship, these basic values that are written, as it were, within our human nature. Positive law, if it's going to be just, Aquinas says, has to be grounded in the natural law, which is why when people say, "Oh, don't legislate morality," Aquinas would say, "What are you talking about? That's all you ever legislate: morality." Think of even driving 65. What is that? It's designed to protect life, right? Because when you drive 100 miles an hour, you put your life and other lives in danger. So it's a law. It seems rather arbitrary, but its purpose is to foster life, which is one of the principles of the natural law. All positive law, if it's just, reflects the natural law.

8.60 The natural law, in turn, rests on what he calls the eternal law. What's that? It's the mind of God, what God knows, what God wants, and God wants our beatitudo. And so beatitudo conditions the natural law, which in turn conditions the positive law, which is

meant to make us virtuous, and the virtues are meant to make us happy. So there's the Thomistic laying out of the moral life. I think what's helpful there is that it gets us beyond just, "Hey, I don't like—stop that bad sexual behavior." No, no, there's a whole program that informs the journey toward happiness.

- 8.61** If you want to see a really good example of this Thomistic thing, read Martin Luther King's letter from the Birmingham City Jail. Do you know about that? So King is arrested, and he's held in the Birmingham jail. And a group of white pastors who are sympathetic with King, but they wrote to him and said, "You're pushing this too fast, and it's causing a lot of upheaval. Why don't you—Dr. King, we respect you, we love you, but you've got to slow down. Don't resist this as much as you're doing."
- 8.62** King took that letter in and thought about it, and then wrote this open letter in response to them, a letter from the Birmingham City Jail. What he argued was, "No, I can't wait. I can't go slowly." Why? "Because the positive law,"—in his case, the Jim Crow laws of the Deep South in those days, he said—"are repugnant to the natural law, which means they're repugnant to the eternal law." And then he cited Saint Thomas Aquinas.
- 8.63** I've always loved that text. I revered that text. Once I was at the Library of Congress giving a talk to government people, and I cited it to say that here's like one of the great Americans, and it's a distinctively American text. But at the same time, explicitly so, it's a deeply Catholic text. He's appealing to Saint Thomas Aquinas, who sees the purpose of law as a moral and ultimately spiritual purpose.
- 8.64** Let me close with this: all of this is meant to get us off the awful wheel of fortune—those who follow me know I've talked about this before. You can find this device on the Gothic cathedrals. The Wheel of Fortune is a great wheel. At the top of it is a king, and he's reigning. As the wheel—I'll do it from your view—the wheel turns this way. You've got someone who's lost his crown, and he says, "Regnavi," "I've reigned." Then, the wheel turns at the bottom, there's a pauper, and he says, "Sum sine regno," "I'm without any power." Then, it turns up here, and there's a guy climbing up, and he says, "Regnabo," "I shall reign." It's a beautiful depiction of life.
- 8.65** It's life in regard to wealth, pleasure, power, honor, all the worldly goods. Sometimes you're up, sometimes you're down, sometimes you're losing, sometimes you're gaining. That's just the way it goes. I don't care how famous you are; time will come when you're not famous. I don't care how much pleasure you're having; a time will come when you're not having pleasure. I don't care how much power you have; the time will come when you're stripped of power. The wheel inevitably turns.
- 8.66** What the great masters say, and Aquinas would totally agree with this, "Don't live on the rim of the wheel." Most of us sinners live on the rim of the wheel, as we ride around this merry-go-round of up and down, and we're lusting after all these goods of

the world. Live rather—and this is the way the Wheel of Fortune is depicted—in the center of it is Christ.

8.67 The central point of the wheel doesn't change: Jesus Christ, the same yesterday, today, and forever, the Bible says. Jesus, the unchanging center. Live there, live there. That's your beatitudo. However the darn wheel turns; the wheel is going to turn. All right, all right, I get it. Don't worry about it. Let go of the rim of the wheel and live grounded in the center of the wheel. All of the Thomistic program of ethics, from law to virtue to beatitudo, is meant to move us into that space.

8.68 And now, can you see—I'll bring it to a close with this—my lectures are meant to imitate the exitus-reditus. So we explored God and then the coming forth of all things from God, with all that that entails, about the beauty of creation and God's providence and so on. But it's all meant now to conduce back to God. You could know as much as Thomas Aquinas about God, but if you're stuck on the Wheel of Fortune, what good is it to you? What he finally wants to do is, by following this path—and there's his word, of course, via, which he loves—by following this moral path, we make our way back to the God who gave rise to us. God bless you all.